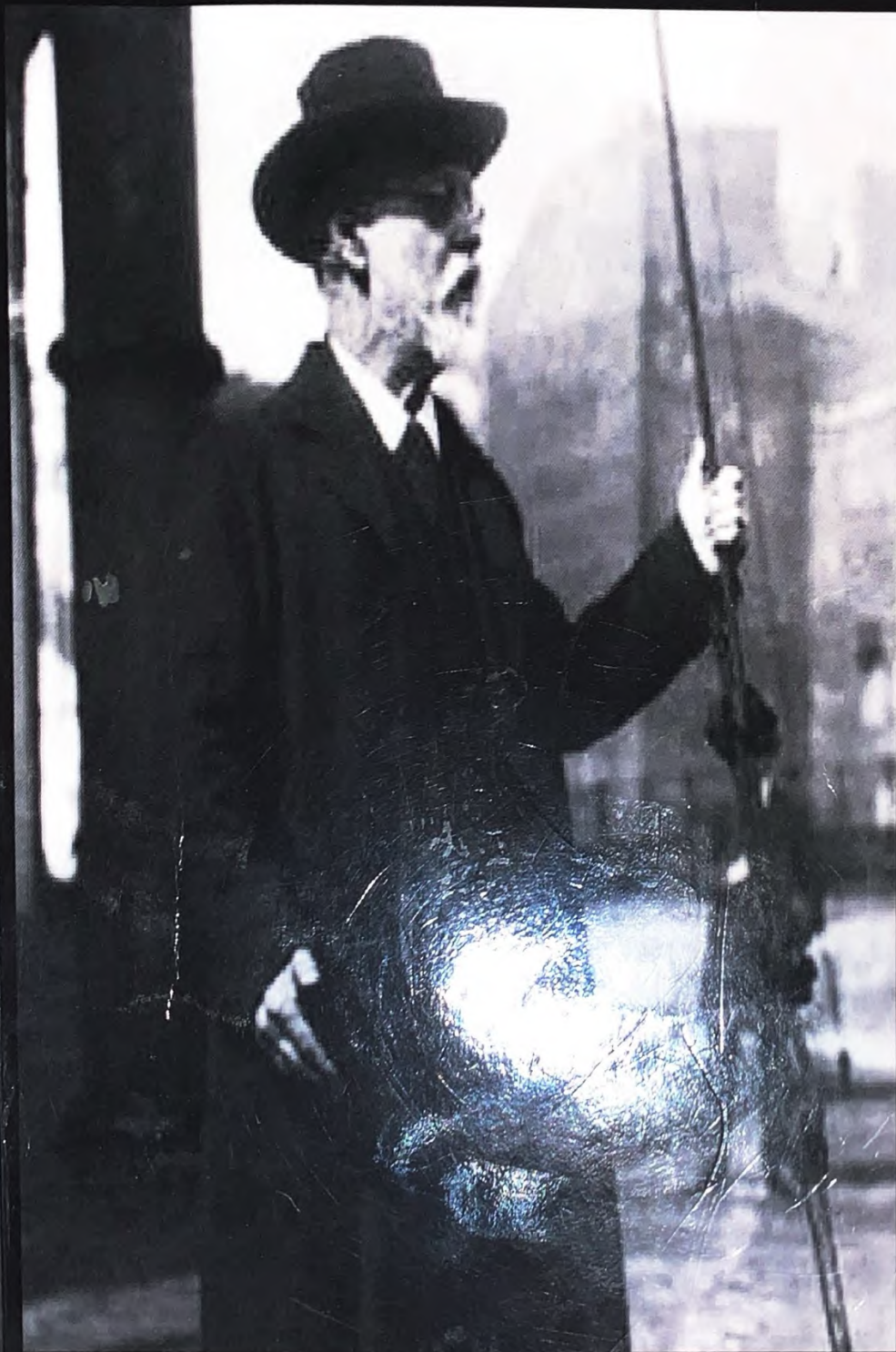


The Road to Power



Karl Kautsky



The Road to Power

Political Reflections on

Growing into the Revolution

Karl Kautsky

Edited by John H. Kautsky

New Translation by
Raymond Meyer



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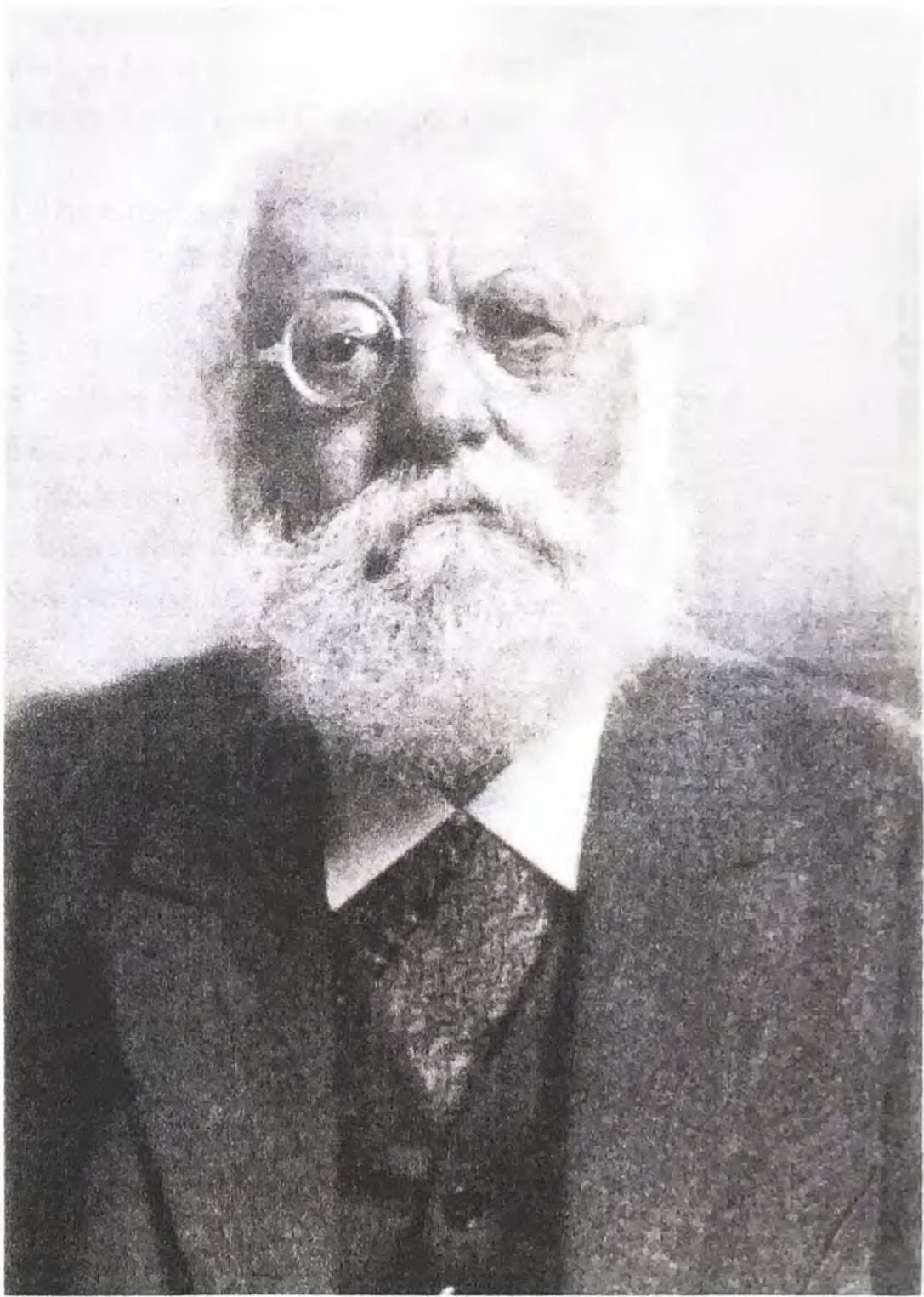
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This German edition included, in addition to the original German text, the introductions by Karl Kautsky to the first (1909), second (1909), and third (1920) editions and the correspondence which shed new light on the controversy surrounding the publication of the pamphlet.

The first English language edition included the introduction by John H. Kautsky.

The cover includes photos of Karl Kautsky (on the left) and the four main participants in the correspondence. They are, from top to bottom, Clara Zetkin, August Bebel, Victor Adler and Hugo Haase.



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Editor's Preface

The Road to Power has often been described as one of Karl Kautsky's most important and, at any rate, his most revolutionary work. Although it contains little that he had not said in some previous writings, it certainly is important as a summary of some of Kautsky's views as he developed them in 1908-9 in response to what he regarded as a new and a potentially revolutionary situation in Germany.

The book also gained prominence as a result of its reception. As Kautsky's last major attack on those who hoped for a gradual "growth into socialism" by means of reforms and coalitions in the autocratic Wilhelmine Empire, it outraged Revisionists in the Social Democratic Party as well as certain trade union leaders. On the other hand, Lenin identified himself with *The Road to Power* in the mistaken belief that "revolution" did and could mean to Kautsky what it meant to him.

The present edition is the first one in English, in a wholly new translation, of *The Road to Power* since the book was published by Samuel A. Bloch in Chicago in 1909, the year when the first German edition appeared. That American edition was quite unreliably translated and could, of course, not contain the important prefaces to the second and third German editions.

In his preface to the second edition, Kautsky responded to attacks from trade union leaders on his book. In his preface to the third edition of 1920, he argued that he still held the same views of revolutionary Marxism as he had in 1909, though by then he had been accused of betraying them. He also explained why he, at the beginning of the Weimar Republic, favored socialist participation in coalition governments that he had vigorously opposed under the Empire in 1909.

In my introduction I sought to place Kautsky and *The Road to Power* in the historical context of imperial Germany and the Social Democratic Party of the last decade before World War I; I also attempted to clarify Kautsky's concept of revolution. In an appendix, I included, in full or in part, two dozen letters regarding the bitter conflict between Kautsky and his Party's Executive Committee over the publication of a second edition of *The Road to Power*. I thank the International Institute of Social History in Amsterdam for its permission to quote or reprint in English translation the letters from its archives.

Words and references in parentheses are Kautsky's, those in brackets have been added by the translator or the editor. In the few instances where passages quoted by Kautsky are from works that have been published in English translation, they are here translated anew or

the translations have been improved, because the earlier ones are often unreliable.

The remarkably careful and accurate translation of the text and the prefaces was produced by Dr. Raymond Meyer; the letters in the appendix were translated by E. Haberkern. I have checked these translations and thus share responsibility for them and I am very grateful for them. I am deeply grateful, too, to Mr. Haberkern, the director of the Center for Socialist History in Berkeley, California, for sponsoring the project of publishing this new edition of *The Road to Power* and for his effective and friendly cooperation with me.

John H. Kautsky

Introduction

John H. Kautsky

I

Karl Kautsky's *The Road to Power*, published in 1909, is substantially a book on revolution. Its very title can be seen as a synonym for "revolution," and in his preface to its first edition, Kautsky describes his work as a supplement to his brochure on *The Social Revolution*¹ published in 1902. The word "revolution" occurs throughout, as do the virtually equivalent German terms *Umwälzung* and *Machtverschiebung* (i.e., shift in power relations); the book culminates in a chapter entitled "A New Age of Revolutions." Kautsky used the term "revolution" throughout his six decades as a socialist writer, but perhaps he did so most emphatically and saw the revolution closest at hand in *The Road to Power*.

Lenin, misled by the Marxian vocabulary he shared with Kautsky, misinterpreted and therefore liked *The Road to Power*.² Given his perspective of a revolutionary in underdeveloped tsarist Russia, he failed to understand what Kautsky, writing in the context of the industrialized German Empire, meant by "revolution." This is worth mentioning here, because, due to the prominence of Lenin's view of Kautsky, it has resulted in a widespread double misunderstanding that, I hope, the following pages will dispel. On the one hand, *The Road to Power* is often seen as Kautsky's closest approach to Leninism, because it is a "revolutionary" work; on the other hand, Kautsky is often accused of abandoning that revolutionary position shortly after writing *The Road to Power* and thus becoming a renegade, which is to explain Lenin's later break with him.³

What does Kautsky mean by revolution? *The Road to Power* provides some quite clear answers, but Kautsky's conception of revolution can only be understood as a response to his environment. It will be misunderstood if it is implicitly assumed that this environment was the same as the one confronted by Lenin in Russia or the one we face in the West today.

At the beginning of the twentieth century, imperial Germany, was not, like the tsarist empire, an underdeveloped country in the early stages of industrialization, populated overwhelmingly by peasants living in the isolation of their village communities and governed by a brutally repressive aristocratic-bureaucratic autocracy. Those who hoped for a social and political order that was drastically different from the existing one were not, as in Russia, tiny groups or conspiracies of intellectuals hoping for the support of unorganized, potentially revolutionary masses of peasants and/or of workers in the very few existing cities.

On the other hand, in the first decade of this century, imperial Germany was not, like Britain even at that time or like Germany today, a parliamentary democracy. Its Social Democratic Party (SPD) could not,

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like the British Labor Party then in its beginnings or the German Social Democrats today, hope to come to power merely by winning elections and gaining parliamentary majorities.

Kautsky, keenly aware of the differences between Germany and Britain and between Germany and Russia, argued that the strategy of his Party had to be different from that of the British socialists as well as that of Russian revolutionaries. In 1898, when Bernstein, who had been living in England and may have been influenced by the Fabians,⁴ began to advocate a strategy of gradual "growth into socialism," Kautsky stressed that in Germany, in contrast to Britain, the bourgeoisie did not stand for democracy. "I admit that the road taken by the English proletariat is better and demands fewer sacrifices and that we must wish we could take the same road; the course of history is, however, not determined by pious wishes but by facts, and these tell us that the English road is impassable for us, that the victory of democracy can be brought about only through the victory of the proletariat."⁵ Earlier in the same year, Kautsky had written to Bernstein: "I completely agree with you that in England the road to the development of a socialist society is open without a revolution.... Things are different in Germany. In Germany, a political revolution is needed to get to where the English are."⁶

In 1910, the year after Kautsky wrote *The Road to Power*, Rosa Luxemburg, who had participated in the Russian Revolution of 1905, advocated that the SPD in Germany support the kind of spontaneous economic and political strikes of unorganized workers that characterized that Revolution. Kautsky responded that the conditions for mass strikes in Prussia were different from those in Russia: "As far as the Russian model is concerned, the first successful mass strike there took place ... under such conditions as do not exist in Prussia today: a war disgracefully lost, the army disorganized, all classes of the population full of hatred and contempt for the government."⁷ A few months later, Kautsky elaborated on this theme, stressing that "in Russia in 1905 the government was completely isolated. In Prussia today the proletariat is isolated whenever it undertakes an action to attack existing conditions energetically."⁸ He interpreted the strikes of the 1905 Revolution as a result of Russian backwardness, a model that could not and should not be followed in a country such as Germany with its highly developed capitalist industry and powerfully organized working class.⁹

By the standard of its time, imperial Germany was a highly industrialized country. Except in the period of Bismarck's anti-Socialist law (1878-90), its labor movement benefitted from far-reaching freedom of association, of speech, and of the press, and could develop a huge

organizational apparatus. By 1905, by far the largest trade union federation in the country (which was closely linked to the SPD) had nearly 1.5 million members. The Party itself grew rapidly; it won 124,700 votes in 1871, the first election to the new Reichstag; 3,259,000 votes in 1907, in the last election before *The Road to Power* was written; and 4,250,400 votes in 1912, in the last election held in imperial Germany.

On the other hand, as Kautsky stresses in chapter 8 of *The Road to Power*, the SPD was drastically under represented in the Reichstag as a result of the failure to redraw electoral district lines throughout the forty-eight-year history of the Empire, a period of rapid urbanization. In Prussia, which included nearly two thirds of the population of the Empire, the SPD held no seats at all in the legislature until 1908 (and only a tiny percentage thereafter), and the Conservative Party was firmly ensconced in power (and was therefore powerful in Germany) as a result of the three-class system of suffrage. That system divided the electorate, composed of about 20 percent of the population, into three equally represented classes, each paying one third of the direct taxes collected in the district and thus made a (publicly cast) vote of a member of the first class sixteen to twenty-six times as valuable as the vote of a member of the third class.¹⁰ Furthermore the imperial government was constitutionally not responsible to the Reichstag, and the governing regime was, in fact, one of the higher bureaucracy and the military that responded to the interests of the agrarian Prussian Junkers and of the big industrialists in their famous marriage of iron and rye.

The regime did, however, enjoy a great deal of popular support, especially from the middle classes of the shrinking petty bourgeoisie and the growing white-collar and professional strata, as well as from the still numerous peasantry. Although the Social Democrats had become the single largest party in Germany by 1890, they polled only 28.9 percent of the popular vote in 1907 and 34.8 percent in 1912. All the other major parties more or less supported the imperial government. As the only major party consistently opposed to the government, the SPD, though quite legal, was widely regarded as subversive, disloyal, and unpatriotic.

The formal prohibition of socialist activities had ended in 1890 but legal prosecutions, economic pressure and intimidation continued. And, less easily defined but none the less real was the general animosity which bourgeoisie and official society showed towards all those who identified with Social Democratic politics. During the

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period of the German empire to be a Social Democrat was to be regarded both as dangerous and amoral.¹¹

The Emperor himself, in a famous remark, referred to Social Democrats as "vaterlandslose Gesellen," that is, roughly translated, vagabonds or bums without a fatherland. Had the SPD ever seemed likely to acquire a popular majority, a coup d'état limiting the suffrage or the powers of the Reichstag was far more probable and imaginable than that the Emperor would appoint a Social Democrat as imperial chancellor.

The politically ambiguous environment of the German Empire, different from that of autocratic tsarist Russia and that of parliamentary-democratic Britain, yet containing elements of both autocracy and parliamentary democracy, accounts for the character of Kautsky's concept of revolution as it appears in his *Road to Power*. On the one hand, impressed by the growth of the labor movement, he was absolutely certain that his Party would come to power, that is, that the revolution would take place. On the other hand, he remained quite uncertain as to when and especially how this would occur; he did not know how the obstinate opposition of a powerful regime and its supporters could be overcome—perhaps because, in fact, it could not be overcome.

Kautsky opens *The Road to Power* by stating that the Social Democratic Party is a revolutionary party, both because it is committed to the social revolution of replacing capitalism with socialism, and because, to carry out the social revolution, it seeks to obtain political power, that is, to make a political revolution. He proceeds to explain how Marxian theory, confirmed by the actual development of capitalism and the labor movement, proves that the proletarian revolution is inevitable. On this conviction rests the indomitable optimism that pervades all of Kautsky's writings and that could not even be shaken by the rise of the Nazis to power in Germany and in Austria at the end of his life.

In *The Road to Power*, Kautsky takes the inevitability of the proletarian revolution for granted. Here he is concerned with how the proletariat (i.e., his Party) can come to power, but more especially with how it cannot come to power. As its ironic subtitle "Political Reflections on Growing into the Revolution" suggests, his book is an attack on Revisionism—his last one, as it turned out—whose reformist policies he had by then for a decade opposed in his role as the chief defender of "orthodox" Marxism in the SPD and the Second International.¹² In particular Kautsky objected to the Revisionists' hope to form a coalition government with relatively leftist "bourgeois" parties and to their confidence in advances by cooperatives and especially by trade unions and in continuing gains in

social and labor protective legislation that would constitute a gradual growth into socialism without any drastic changes in the political order.

Kautsky did not oppose limited socialist cooperation with left liberal parties, such as the Progressives, or *Freisinnige*, in the German Empire, to form electoral alliances in run-off elections.¹³ He had, however, opposed socialist participation in bourgeois coalitions under "normal circumstances," once the question arose when Millerand joined the Waldeck-Rousseau cabinet in France in 1899. "In Switzerland and in England, such participation seems possible to me, in Germany it is out of the question."¹⁴ There the class antagonism between proletariat and bourgeoisie would make fruitful collaboration of the Social Democrats with bourgeois parties in a coalition government impossible. Joining a bourgeois coalition would tend to discredit the Party with its working-class following (p. 8). The proletariat "can accomplish the conquest of political power only by itself, only when it is strong enough to take up the struggle with the entire bourgeois world victoriously."¹⁵

Especially during the first decade of this century, when he was engaged in his dispute with Revisionism, Kautsky had also argued that in imperial Germany, in contrast to Britain, merely economic growth into socialism without major political changes was impossible. The passage directed at Bernstein (quoted above), which states that in Germany the victory of democracy could only be brought about by the victory of the proletariat, ends with the following words: "Is there anyone who believes that this victory is possible without a catastrophe? I desire it, but I do not believe it."¹⁶ As capitalism develops, the power of both the proletariat and capital grows, "and the end of this development can be nothing but a great decisive struggle that cannot end until the proletariat has achieved victory."¹⁷ "The proletariat cannot be emancipated without the conquest of political power; all practical achievements attained through social reform and the organization of the proletariat strengthen the latter but do not reduce its antagonism to the capitalist class, which, rather, grows ever more until political power is wrested from that class in a great showdown."¹⁸

Long before he wrote *The Road to Power*, then, Kautsky had insisted on the inevitability of a political revolution in the German Empire, but his references to a "catastrophe," a "great decisive struggle," and a "showdown" had always been very general. Time and again he had insisted that it was impossible to predict when the political revolution would break out or what form it would take. In *The Road to Power*, he came a little closer to doing just that. Why the change?

II

In an autobiographical sketch written in 1923, Kautsky notes that the 1905 Revolution in Russia had

... reinforced the power of the struggle for the suffrage in Prussia. Together with the armament race, it created a state of insecurity in Europe that promised to bring the most surprising catastrophes. I developed this point in 1909 in my book *The Road to Power*.¹⁹

In the book itself, Kautsky refers explicitly to various factors that impressed him as leading to a revolutionary situation, such as growing expenditures for colonialism and armaments and the threat of a world war, the failure of trade unions to score successes and of welfare policies to expand, and rising food prices and growing corruption. In addition some specific developments not mentioned by Kautsky in *The Road to Power* affected the situation in which he wrote the book, particularly the Reichstag elections of 1907, the *Daily Telegraph* Affair, and the Harden-Eulenburg scandals. Kautsky hints at the latter two when he refers to "struggles against the personal regime and constitutional questions" in the first sentence of his preface to the first edition and to the possibility of "moral collapse of the ruling regime" at the end of chapter 6.

A constitutional crisis had developed over the "personal regime" of William II, when in October 1908 the London *Daily Telegraph* published an article reporting an interview with the Emperor revealing that he had personally carried on inept and indiscreet foreign policy discussions in England.²⁰ The prestige of the monarchy was also gravely damaged and the position of the Emperor and his Chancellor, Prince Bülow, was weakened by three trials in the period 1907-9, involving charges of homosexuality, slander, and perjury, which resulted from attacks by the writer Maximilian Harden on Prince Eulenburg, a close friend and confidant of the Emperor.²¹

One event that had certainly affected the position of the Social Democratic Party in the Empire and prevailing attitudes in the Party was the Reichstag election of 1907, the so-called Hottentot election. Fought by the government parties in the "Bülow Bloc" on the issue of support for German colonialism, "on a wave of nationalist sentiment and in a mood of all-out attack on the SPD"²² for its lack of patriotism, the election resulted in the loss of thirty-eight of the eighty-one seats the SPD had held in the Reichstag. This loss was due primarily to the failure of the left

liberals (*Freisinnige*), who supported the government in this election, to vote for Social Democrats in run-off elections.

In less than a quarter of a century, the SPD's popular vote had steadily risen and had increased nearly tenfold (from 312,000 votes in 1881 to 3,010,800 in 1903), and its share of the popular vote had steadily grown more than fivefold (from 6.1 percent in 1881 to 31.7 percent in 1903). In 1907 the SPD popular vote still grew but only by a quarter of a million over its 1903 level, the smallest increase since 1887, and the Party's share of the popular vote dropped by nearly 3 percent as against 1903, the first decrease since 1881, when the Party had been handicapped by the anti-Socialist law. The outcome of the 1907 election shook the SPD's faith in the inevitability and irresistibility of its electoral growth.²³

The Revisionists reacted with renewed emphasis on their policy of gradual reforms through trade union advances and coalition politics, because "in the foreseeable future, no period of revolutionary development is to be expected in Germany."²⁴ It was in response to this view, as expressed by Max Maurenbrecher, that Kautsky wrote the article that grew into *The Road to Power*.

In an article written five days after the first round of the 1907 election,²⁵ Kautsky explained the SPD's defeat by two factors. One was "the loss of some hundreds of thousands of fellow travellers from the intermediate strata" of the petty bourgeoisie and the new middle class of white-collar workers and professionals, who, suffering from the rise in food prices, had supported the SPED in 1903 because of its opposition to protective tariffs, but who now turned against labor's attempt to raise wages. Kautsky was not displeased that his Party's electorate had thus assumed a more exclusively proletarian character and demanded that this character must not be obscured to attract the intermediate strata, who would, in any case, in good part return to the SPED sooner or later.

The second factor that, in Kautsky's view, accounted for the great increase in the number of nonsocialist voters and of 1903 nonvoters who voted in 1907 – turnout increased by more than 15 percent – was fear of Social Democracy and "the attractiveness of the colonial idea in bourgeois circles.... The fact that the colonial state of the future fascinated the entire bourgeois world ... is closely linked to the growing fear of the state of the future of Social Democracy." But Kautsky predicted that German colonialism would merely result in higher taxes, more armaments, the isolation of Germany, and growing danger of a world war. And he concluded that the effects of this policy could "tremendously accelerate the course of development" and that it was therefore "not impossible that our defeat, which at first sight seems to have the effect of significantly

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postponing our victory, becomes a means to bring it about more quickly than we ourselves had suspected."²⁶

Diametrically opposed to the Revisionist view, it was this prediction of the development of a revolutionary situation resulting from growing antagonism between working class and bourgeoisie that Kautsky elaborates in his *Road to Power*. Here he repeats several times (on pp. 22, 89-90, 116, 118) that imperialism offers to nonsocialists their only and last hope for the future and that it serves the bourgeoisie as an ideal counterposed to socialism,²⁷ and he stresses the great costs imposed on the proletariat by ever growing expenditures for the army and navy (pp. 119, 121), which would be further increased by attempts to overcome growing native resistance in the colonies (pp. 125-126).

Kautsky also notes the regime's virtually complete failure to enact social and labor protective legislation since the early 1890s. He cites as the only change the reduction in 1908 of the working day for female workers from the eleven hours set in 1891 to ten hours and notes that male workers remained entirely unprotected (p. 91).²⁸ The proletariat's standard of living was further threatened by food prices that had been rising since the turn of the century, partly as a result of protective tariffs favoring agrarian interests (pp. 98-100).

In addition to these relatively long-term trends aggravated by the depression that began in 1907, Kautsky emphasizes, above all, changes that, as he saw it, had become apparent only more recently. No doubt they account for the somewhat more radical tone of *The Road to Power*, although these changes seemed to Kautsky merely to confirm the correctness of his objections to the Revisionist advocacy of policies relying on a gradual "growth into socialism," objections that he had been voicing for a decade.

Revisionist hopes and predictions in this regard had rested on the growth of the working class and its organizations, which Kautsky also emphasizes (pp. 28, 71-81), especially the very real advances made by the trade unions from the 1890s to about 1907 (pp. xlii, 92-93). Kautsky argues that it was exactly labor's advances, the result of what the Revisionists called "positive work," that aroused growing bourgeois resistance.²⁹ Now, he claims, these advances were therefore becoming rarer and more difficult to achieve, especially with respect to real wages, because of the resistance of rapidly growing cartels and, even more important, of increasingly powerful employers' associations (pp. 96-98).

In this connection, Kautsky also deals with the arrival in industry of cheap labor from agrarian areas (pp. 96-98). This is an aspect of the more general problem of the migration of rural people from underdeveloped countries into urban areas, both within these countries and in industrial

ones, a problem that has become prominent in the latter half of the twentieth century and will remain so in the twenty-first.

Finally the situation that provoked Kautsky to write *The Road to Power* allowed him to argue more strongly than ever that Social Democrats should not pursue a policy of coalitions with bourgeois parties.³⁰ He holds that the 1907 election and its aftermath, in which the left-liberal parties supported the government, made this obvious.³¹ That election, he says, marked "the complete collapse of German democracy" (p. 17), that is, of nonsocialist supporters of democracy. Petty-bourgeois, peasant, and bourgeois democrats were not even an opposition party any more (p. 72); only the Social Democrats still opposed militarism and armaments (pp. 90, 115–116).

Kautsky explains why the petty bourgeoisie and the peasantry have become more and more hostile to the working class (pp. 115) and argues that the latter cannot rely on them as allies, though he speculates that much of the petty bourgeoisie might one day, responding to high taxes and the corruption of the militarist regime, join the proletariat and thereby assure its victory (pp. 129–133). For the present, though, Kautsky argues in *The Road to Power* that the proletariat was isolated (p. 115), and he even says that the concept of the "reactionary mass," which, following Marx, he had always rejected as a dangerous oversimplification, had now become reality.³² Pursuit of a policy of coalition with bourgeois parties would now constitute political and moral suicide for Social Democracy (pp. 135–136).³³

Kautsky's analysis led him to conclude that, with the progress of the working class having come – or threatening to come – to a halt, Germany was entering "a period of general uncertainty" (pp. 134–135) and, more specifically, of growing class antagonism and therefore "a new age of revolutions." A revolution could no longer be regarded as premature when the proletariat "has drawn from the existing governmental framework as much strength as could be drawn from it, when a transformation of this framework has become a condition for its further advancement" (p. 84). Once it has become clear that changes in the political power relations and institutions are necessary if the proletariat is to continue its economic advance, political struggles are inevitable in which "the proletariat must grow immensely. It cannot be victorious in them, it cannot achieve democracy and the elimination of militarism ... without itself attaining to a dominant position in the state" (p. 111).

III

To Kautsky the political revolution is, then, the achievement of political power by the proletariat, through the Social Democratic Party. In *The Road to Power* that revolution is perhaps more clearly defined with respect to its immediate goals than in his previous writings, but as far as its timing and duration and especially its forms are concerned, Kautsky cannot be much more definitive than he was earlier.

The goals of the revolution first of all involved constitutional changes, including the attainment of the secret ballot and of equal suffrage through the abolition of the three-class system in Prussia and Saxony and the equalization of the electoral districts for Reichstag elections. The Reichstag had to be strengthened by making the government responsible to it and thus creating "a truly parliamentary regime" (p. 107) but also by strengthening the national government vis-à-vis the German states and particularly Prussia.

These changes would give the proletariat access to legislation but not the means to enact social reforms, for these means were then being consumed by military expenditures. Kautsky, therefore also demands disarmament and the abolition of the standing army, which, in turn, require an end of colonial and imperialist policies (pp. 108-109). In the preface to the second edition, he thus summarizes the immediate goals of the revolution:

Defeating the armaments policy, overcoming the domination of the state by the Junkers and the industrial barons [*Krautjunker* and *Schlotjunker*], that is to say, democratization of the Reich, these have now become the most important practical tasks of the German proletariat. They must be carried out if its advance is to continue. (p. lvi)

When does Kautsky expect the revolution to occur? On the second page of *The Road to Power*, he stresses that the proletarian revolution cannot be made at will ³⁴ and that it will be a response to certain conditions that the development of capitalism creates. It follows, as Kautsky sees it and as he said in an article of 1893,³⁵ which he quotes at great length in *The Road to Power* (pp. 54-67), that the Social Democratic Party was "a revolutionary party, but not a party that makes revolutions" (p. 54). This statement has often been cited as illustrating the quibbling or ambiguous nature of Kautsky's or his Party's revolutionism and as showing that they were only "pseudo-revolutionaries" and merely verbally radical.³⁶ As the context makes quite clear, however, it merely says that the Party is committed to both the social and the political

revolution, but that the revolution will come only when its prerequisites have matured – no sooner and no later.

To Kautsky this did not mean that, as is often suggested, he minimized or ignored the "subjective factor" in history, that he held the, literally nonsensical, view that will played no role in the revolution, that men would go to the barricades or the ballot box without wanting to do so. In chapter 4 of *The Road to Power* on "Economic Development and Will," he argues that the human will is the driving force of the economy and of politics, but that the will is not free; rather it is conditioned "in the last analysis" by economic development.

Because Kautsky could not predict just when conditions would be ripe for the revolution – is not a successful revolution the only clear indicator of their ripeness? – he stressed in his 1893 article that we "cannot say anything at all about when, under which conditions, and in which forms it will occur" (pp. 54–55), and in 1909 he repeats that the "forms and duration" of the revolution are unpredictable (pp. 68, 137). As to the timing of the revolution, however, Kautsky now feels that conditions have changed and that a period of struggle for governmental institutions and governmental power has begun that would "very probably in the foreseeable future bring about considerable shifts in power to the proletariat's advantage and could even lead to its exclusive rule in Western Europe" (p. 68). Kautsky suggests that his Party might come to power as a result of "the moral collapse of the governing regime" (p. 81) or – and here he proved right – of the defeat of that regime in a war (p. 128).

But even with respect to the forms to be assumed by the revolution, Kautsky is not as uncertain in *The Road to Power* as he sometimes professes to be. It is surely significant that he reprints several pages of his 1893 article with their heavy emphasis on "the democratic-proletarian method ... of class struggle which confines itself to the nonmilitary means of parliamentarism, strikes, demonstrations, the press, and similar means of exerting pressure" (p. 58), "at least in countries with reasonably democratic institutions," including "freedom of association, freedom of the press and universal suffrage" (pp. 57–58), all of which did exist in imperial Germany.

Far from seeing "nonmilitary" methods as nonrevolutionary, Kautsky argues that it was precisely the workers' belief in "the revolutionary character of our Party" and their "revolutionary enthusiasm" that made them adhere to these "civilized ... forms of struggle" rather than the more "brutal" ones of anarchism (p. 66). The possibility of an armed uprising is not even considered in *The Road to Power*. Kautsky also implies that the revolution will be a gradual process

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when he suggests that the coming struggles for power may, "accompanied by diverse vicissitudes.... drag on for decades" (p. 68) and even that the new revolutionary period might last as long as that of the bourgeoisie, which, he says, extended from 1789 to 1871 (p. 126).

A major new emphasis in *The Road to Power* is on the political role of the trade unions. Kautsky states repeatedly that the obstacles he sees as now blocking the continued advance of the working class "cannot be overcome by purely union methods but only by political struggle" (p. lvi) and that the unions could no longer expect to "advance the proletariat as powerfully by purely trade-union methods as they succeeded in doing in the last dozen years" (p. 73). He says that they now have more and more "political tasks" (p. 104), but he does not spell out what these tasks are beyond mentioning that strikes in industries dominated by the powerful employers' associations assume an ever more political character and that social reform and labor protective measures can only be achieved through political action (p. 104-105).

Kautsky also notes, however, that more and more often "in purely political struggles, e.g., struggles for the suffrage, the weapon of the mass strike can be used successfully" (p. 104). When at the end of his book he states that the immediate goals of the proletariat are the democratization of Germany and the fight against militarism, he adds: "Just as evident as these tasks are the means at our disposal for carrying them out. To those already employed has been added the *mass strike*" (p. 104).

Though barely made explicit in *The Road to Power*, Kautsky's call on the trade unions to accept the political mass strike as a weapon is an important element in his book.³⁷ In his preface to its second edition, Kautsky writes that one task he undertook in his book was to direct the attention of the trade unions "to the new functions that are arising for them in addition to the purely trade union ones and thus raise the significance of the trade unions" (p. xlv).³⁸ Here he is quite outspoken when he says that

... only *mass action*, and specifically the action of *organized masses*, can move us ahead today.... But proletarian mass organization and mass action mean *trade-union organization and action*.... We cannot win political victories without the help of strong unions that are capable of struggle and conscious of their strength. (p. lviii)

Yet, in April 1910, just two months before he wrote this preface, Kautsky, in a long article, rejected Rosa Luxemburg's call for a mass strike.³⁹ She wanted the Party to turn into political strike actions the

massive street demonstrations that had been held in February–April 1910 against the Prussian three-class suffrage. Following the model of the Russian Revolution of 1905 and in response to the negative attitude of the trade unions, she emphasized the role of the unorganized workers.⁴⁰ Kautsky, as I just quoted him, insisted that mass action had to be trade union action, and he had stated in *The Road to Power* that the mass strike was “not effective in every situation” and “that it would be foolish to want to apply it in all circumstances” (p. 134). With the union and Party authorities opposed to calling for mass strikes and in view of the power of the regime, he feared that the political mass strike was likely to fail and to endanger achievements and organizations of the Social Democratic Party and the trade unions.

In opposing Luxemburg, Kautsky argued that the Party should not risk defeat just when, he felt certain, it would win a great victory in the next Reichstag election, which would be “nothing less than a catastrophe for the entire ruling system of government.”⁴¹ In reaction to such a defeat, or possibly even before the election in order to avoid defeat, the regime was likely to resort to measures of brutal repression and a coup to abolish universal suffrage.⁴² Such actions, Kautsky thought, would mobilize a mass response; “a mass strike under such circumstances could very well be capable of sweeping the existing regime away.”⁴³ The political revolution would then be a reply to the unconstitutional, violent action of the regime and would be legitimated by the support of a majority of the population. As the author of an insightful study of Kautsky’s role in the SPED says: “The postponement of the political mass strike was thus not an expression of mere opportunism or weakness on Kautsky’s part, but was determined by the concern with democracy that had always characterized Social Democracy and also determined Kautsky’s thought.”⁴⁴

IV

The Road to Power is certainly an important work among Karl Kautsky’s many writings, particularly because he argued in it that the situation in the German Empire had changed so that the trade unions would have to become more directly involved in politics if they were to continue to advance the workers’ welfare. And having avoided predictions in the past about when the inevitable political revolution would occur, Kautsky now considered it very probable that major shifts in power in favor of Social Democracy would take place or at least begin “in the foreseeable future.”

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The Road to Power does not, however, mark a major departure from positions Kautsky had taken earlier, as has often been asserted,⁴⁵ nor did he abandon the positions he took in this book when he turned against Rosa Luxemburg's advocacy of the mass strike. The first interpretation sees Kautsky as more radical than he was and even, quite wrongly, as somehow similar to Lenin; the second one sees him as more moderate than he was and even, quite wrongly, as a renegade. Both ignore the fact that at different times he faced different circumstances from the same position, which he therefore expressed with different emphases.

That the working class, through socialist parties, would have to come to power in industrialized countries sooner or later, that is, that there would be a political revolution, had been an article of faith for Kautsky all along. He had stated many times that in Germany this revolution would have to consist of the replacement of the imperial regime by a parliamentary republic with universal suffrage.⁴⁶ Indeed Kautsky had already bluntly made one of the principal points of *The Road to Power* in a letter in 1893: "The struggle for a real parliamentarism will, in my opinion, become the decisive struggle for the social revolution in Germany, for in Germany a parliamentary regime is tantamount to the political victory of the proletariat and also *vice versa*."⁴⁷ With respect to the nature and immediate goals of the revolution, then, *The Road to Power* says nothing new, except to make more explicit, in response to current government policies, the additional goal of putting an end to colonial expansionism and militarism.

Kautsky had never predicted just what form the revolution would take, and he did not do so in *The Road to Power*. As he had earlier, he suggested here that it would probably be peaceful and gradual, though he always thought the imperial regime might provoke a violent confrontation. Some drastic political change toward democracy would certainly have to occur. By the time *The Road to Power* was published, Kautsky had been denouncing for a decade the Revisionist hopes for imperceptible growth into socialism without any such change in imperial institutions.

What had changed by 1909 was, however, not only the political situation in Germany, especially through and after the 1907 election, but also the political situation in the Social-Democratic Party, whose right wing had grown stronger, partly due to the SPD's loss of seats in that election. The trade unions had become more powerful in the Party, as they had grown stronger and enjoyed more successes. They were particularly cautious in a period of economic depression. Their leaders bitterly resented as a reflection on their past achievements Kautsky's prediction

that they would not be able to advance in the future by mere trade union methods, and they also interpreted his hope that they would turn to political methods as implying that the unions should be subordinated to the Party. The trade union leadership attacked Kautsky in its central organ,⁴⁸ and Kautsky responded in his preface to the second edition of *The Road to Power*.⁴⁹

The trade unions had never had much use or respect for Kautsky because he was a "theorist," but he had enjoyed considerable influence and respect with the Party leadership, at least since he authored the SPD's Erfurt Program in 1891. He was cast in the role of something like the principal official Party theorist, not because all Party leaders or intellectuals always agreed with him, but mostly because of his long-lasting close political relationship with August Bebel, the Party's unquestioned leader. With the huge growth of the Party and its numerous auxiliary organizations, it had become bureaucratized and, partly also because Bebel was ill, its leadership and Kautsky's relation to it had changed. To many full-time Party functionaries and leaders, he must have seemed to be an impractical theorist and a troublemaker.⁵⁰

This change became strikingly apparent when the Party Executive Committee (*Parteivorstand*), with only one dissenting vote (by Luise Zietz), after the first appearance of *The Road to Power*, prohibited its further distribution by the official Party publishing house "Vorwärts." The fascinating story of the ensuing complex dispute becomes clear from the selected letters in the Appendix to the present edition.

The cautious Party Executive Committee⁵¹ was, or at least claimed to be, concerned that the public prosecutor might charge Kautsky with high treason, though, in fact, nothing of the sort happened. Always worried about the legal status of the Party, some of the Executive Committee members, probably including Bebel, may have feared renewed repression after their losses in the 1907 election to the Bülow Bloc. Also, as Bebel wrote to Victor Adler (pp. 159), speaking as one Marxist practical politician to another, *The Road to Power* could provide an occasion for attacks on the SPD, which the regime could use to distract attention from its own troubles, a tactical consideration for which he said Kautsky had no appreciation.

Gary Steenson, the best biographer of Kautsky, lists as "an additional possible source for the hostility" of the Executive Committee "Kautsky's powerful assertion that without theory, both as a consciousness-raising tool and as a source of direction, the mundane work of the movement would lead nowhere. This struck deeply into the heart of the growing socialist bureaucracy and attacked the basic rationale for its existence."⁵²

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And Kautsky expressed his resentment of the Executive Committee for their resentment of him as an intellectual when he wrote to Adler: "The scoundrels want to let the intellectual [*den Literaten*] feel their power, to show him that he is only their coolie and has to shut up when they command" (p. 165).

Finally, as Kautsky notes in a letter to Hugo Haase (p. 150), there were also rumors that a "Revisionist intrigue" was behind the order to withdraw his book, and, according to Clara Zetkin, the Executive Committee was afraid of the Revisionists who had threatened to split the Party if Kautsky's "scandalous brochure" was given official sanction by its publication by the Party publishing house.⁵³

It would, indeed, be surprising if the principal reason for the opposition to *The Road to Power* had not been objections to its radical message and its radical tone. As a sophisticated student of German Social Democracy wrote: "At a time when the Party Executive had de facto reconciled itself to the existing order of state and society, the publication of Kautsky's theses about the political revolution were bound to meet with resistance from the responsible Party authorities.... The Executive regarded Kautsky's book as an offense against the peaceable tactics of the Party."⁵⁴

The bitter conflict ended in a compromise. The Party Executive Committee permitted the publication by "Vorwärts" of a second edition of *The Road to Power*, in which Kautsky had made certain changes from the first edition. Because Kautsky had proposed these conditions himself at the beginning of the controversy, he accepted the compromise. As his legal adviser in the matter, Hugo Haase, then a prominent Social Democratic defense lawyer in East Prussia and later chairman of the SPED and, beginning in 1917, of the Independent Social Democratic Party (USPD), wrote to Kautsky: "Substantively, you do not give up anything; the Executive Committee offers you what you demanded to begin with. You do not submit to a 'decree' of the EC; rather, you help the EC out of a difficult situation. That's how I see things" (p. 172).⁵⁵

The verbal changes Kautsky made in the text of the first edition of *The Road to Power* were minor, indeed, and did not significantly affect the substance or even the tone of his work.⁵⁶ Kautsky also agreed, however, to add a new final paragraph to his preface to the first edition in which he stressed that he alone, and not his Party, was responsible for what he had written, "insofar as it is not based on our program and on the resolutions of our Party congresses." This latter clause may have been meant by Kautsky to suggest that in some or much of what he said he was still

speaking for his Party even as he complied with the Party Executive's wish that he assume personal responsibility for *The Road to Power*.

Ingrid Gilcher-Holtey, whose entire book is a sensitive analysis of Kautsky's role as a Party theorist, is undoubtedly right in saying that the principal question at issue in the controversy over the publication of *The Road to Power* was whether the analysis of the situation and the strategy for the Party proposed there should be recognized as "official" ones by the Party. She concludes that in fighting the conflict over the issue of his freedom of opinion as a writer rather than over the political issue, Kautsky gave up his claim "as a theorist to provide to the Party a binding value and action orientation."⁵⁷ However that may be, it must be understood that Kautsky had always in his role as a theorist left the making of political decisions to the practical politicians,⁵⁸ and it is also clear from his letters in the controversy that he was anxious not to have the Party, which was, after all, his Party and not his enemy, placed in an embarrassing position.

In any case Kautsky's role in the Party had clearly changed. "He could no longer control the Party's policy alternatives, and the Party no longer needed him to interpret the times."⁵⁹ *The Road to Power* may have differed at most in tone and not in substance from what Kautsky had been saying repeatedly for some time, but under new circumstances it was received differently. That reception and particularly the attack directed at it by the now more powerful trade unions and the reformist wing of the SPED gave more prominence to the radical character of the work.

Similarly it was the situation and not Kautsky's position that had changed when he opposed Rosa Luxemburg on the question of the mass strike in 1910. The new situation was created by the emergence of a new radical wing on the left of the Party, which advocated political mass strikes that were quite different from the ones Kautsky had in mind in his *Road to Power*, especially with respect to their reliance on unorganized workers.

In his response to Rosa Luxemburg, Kautsky stressed the coming Reichstag election and the use of the mass strike to defend universal suffrage and to defeat any attempt by the regime to weaken or abolish existing electoral and parliamentary institutions. This is very much in line with his emphasis in *The Road to Power* on the importance of universal suffrage and parliamentarism, an emphasis that remained consistent through Kautsky's political writings for half a century.⁶⁰

Thus Kautsky's statement in *The Road to Power* that "it is the successful struggles for the control of parliaments and in parliaments that have mightily increased the proletariat's strength and its sentiment of

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strength" (p. 45) is reminiscent of what he had already written in 1892, in his commentary on the Erfurt Program of 1891, which he himself had drafted with Engels's approval:

When the proletariat participates as a self-conscious class in the struggles for control of parliament (particularly in electoral campaigns) and within parliament, parliamentarism ... ceases to be a mere means of domination of the bourgeoisie. It is just these struggles that prove to be the most powerful means to awaken those strata of the proletariat that are still indifferent and to give them confidence and hope; they prove to be the most powerful means to weld the various proletarian strata ever more firmly into a united working class; and finally they also prove to be the most powerful means at present available to the proletariat to influence the government and to extract from it those concessions that, depending on the circumstances, can for the present be extracted at all; in short, these struggles are among the most effective levers by which to raise the proletariat out of its economic, social and moral degradation.

The working class has, then, not only no reason to stay away from parliamentary activity, it has every reason to be decisively active everywhere to strengthen parliament vis-à-vis the executive and to strengthen its own representation in parliament through an independent socialist labor party.

Besides *freedom of association and freedom of the press, universal, equal and direct suffrage and the secret ballot* are a *vital condition* for the sound development of the proletariat.⁶¹

When Kautsky speaks in *The Road to Power* (on p. 107) of the growing political tasks of the trade unions and specifically of the mass strike, he stresses in italics that, in contrast to the antiparlamentarism of Syndicalism, "the 'direct action' of the trade unions can effectively serve only as a *supplement and reinforcement*, not as a *substitute* for the parliamentary activity of the labor parties."

Kautsky had also already written in *The Road to Power* what he said in 1910: "We must not be surprised when our next great electoral victory brings us an attack on the existing suffrage for the Reichstag" (p. 47; see

also p. 106). He had quoted his own article of 1893 stressing the danger that the ruling classes would, in response to the growing strength of the working class, resort to violence and counseling Social Democracy to postpone a confrontation, if it should be inevitable, as long as possible. It "must avoid, indeed, it must combat everything that would be a pointless provocation of the ruling classes" (p. 60).

Opposing Luxemburg, Kautsky took a position he himself called that of the "Marxist Center," for he felt that the greater threat to Marxism now came from the "rebellious impatience" of the radical left than from the "statesman-like impatience" of the Revisionists.⁶² Kautsky's shift from the left of the Party to the Marxist Center was thus only relative; it was due to the rise of a new force to the left of him. His position did not change, as has often been asserted.⁶³ Kautsky had always been a "centrist," for Marxism—as distinguished from what later came to be known as Marxism-Leninism—occupied a centrist position opposing both reformism and revisionism on the right and doctrines and movements like anarchism, Blanquism, and syndicalism on the left.

The Road to Power was Kautsky's last major work against Revisionism, and as such it sounded relatively radical, especially as his opponents on the right described it. "Was nun?" and Kautsky's subsequent polemics on the mass strike against Luxemburg and Pannekoek were his first writings against the new radical left, and as such they sounded relatively moderate, especially as his opponents on the left described them. In fact though differing in tone and emphasis, both relatively radical and relatively moderate works were, absolutely, written from the same point of view of the Marxist Center.

There is some disagreement in Communist literature as to whether Kautsky abandoned Marxism in 1910 when he became a "Centrist," or in World War I, beginning in 1914, when he opposed the SPED majority's support for the imperial government's war policies but also opposed Lenin's policy of turning the war into a civil war. But there is no question among Communists that by 1920 Kautsky had become a renegade, for he had attacked the new Bolshevik regime in Russia from its beginnings.⁶⁴ Yet in 1920 when Kautsky wrote the lengthy new preface, translated herein, to a third edition of *The Road to Power*, he could claim that he could reprint that book in unchanged form, "because I still stand by every sentence in this work today" (p. lxi-lxii). He conceded only that his language had changed.

Kautsky could (on pp. lxi-lxvii) present a dozen quotations from his book stating that he did not favor revolution "at any price"; that a violent revolution was neither desirable nor probable, "only Russia is an

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exception"; that socialism could be realized only in a "democratic republic"; that Russia was economically too "immature" for a revolution to establish a socialist regime; that, except in Russia, small minorities could no longer seize and maintain power; and that only a party representing "the great majority of the population" could do so. And he kept repeating that no "revolutionary Marxists" disagreed with him in 1909; if they did so now, it was they who had changed.

The Road to Power is a historical document important for an understanding of the history of German Social Democracy and of Kautsky's role in it. But as a historical document, it can itself be understood only with reference to its historical context in the German Empire. Kautsky's position in the Marxist Center between Bernstein's Revisionism and Luxemburg's radicalism corresponds, in a sense, to the locatio I of the Empire, not only geographically but politically, between Britain, where, it seemed to Kautsky, Bernstein's policy was appropriate, and tsarist Russia, where, he thought, Luxemburg's approach was suitable.

As in Britain, the socialist party had reason to hope for an electoral victory in the German Empire, but, as in tsarist Russia, there was every reason to doubt that it could come to power under the existing regime. Corresponding to this situation, Kautsky's concept of the political revolution involved great emphasis, on the one hand, on electoral participation and the reforms and the political education that would strengthen the workers' party in elections and, on the other hand, on extra parliamentary pressures, especially through the mass strike, to protect and extend the workers' right to vote and to defeat any attempt to limit or destroy what parliamentary institutions there were.⁶⁵

Electoral victories and, more generally, political action by the Social Democratic Party and by the trade unions, in ways not clearly specified in *The Road to Power*, and, if necessary, mass strikes were to serve to bring about parliamentary democracy in Germany. That goal is very clearly specified, for to Kautsky the achievement of parliamentarism and of working-class power through a parliamentary majority was the content of the socialist political revolution. He considered it the inevitable and necessary prerequisite of the future social revolution: To him it was the road to power.⁶⁶

Notes

A slightly modified version of this introduction appeared as a chapter, "The Road to Power," in my book *Karl Kautsky: Marxism, Revolution, and Democracy* (New Brunswick, N.J.: Transaction Publishers, 1994). It is reprinted here with the permission of Transaction Publishers. I thank Gary Steenson for his perceptive comments on an earlier draft.

1. Karl Kautsky, *The Social Revolution*, 3d ed. (Chicago: Charles H. Kerr, 1916).

2. Even after his open break with Kautsky in 1914, Lenin described *The Road to Power* as "a most complete exposition of the tasks of our times" that expressed "the undisputed opinion held by all revolutionary Social-Democrats." "Dead Chauvinism and Living Socialism," in V. I. Lenin, *Collected Works*, 45 vols. (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1960-70), 21:94, 98. See also "Under a False Flag," 21:147. In 1917 Lenin still called *The Road to Power* "the last and best of Kautsky's works against the opportunists," which "should serve as a measure of comparison of what the German Social-Democrats promised to be before the imperialist war and the depth of degradation to which they — including Kautsky himself — sank when the war broke out." "State and Revolution," *Collected Works*, 25:486, 487.

3. Thus Georg Fülberth, in his introduction to the most recent German edition of *The Road to Power*, refers to it as Kautsky's "last 'revolutionary' piece of writing, shortly before his open shift to 'centrist' positions in 1910." *Der Weg zur Macht. Politische Betrachtungen über das Hineinwachsen in die Revolution* (Frankfurt am Main: Europäische Verlagsanstalt, 1972), xvii. As recently as 1988, an East German Communist scholar wrote: "Kautsky's *Road to Power* constituted a convincing summary of the conception of revolutionary theory championed by the Marxists in the Party." "But when, with the rise of a mighty suffrage movement in 1910, a political crisis began to mature, Kautsky lost his courage and placed himself de facto in conflict with the theoretical views he had just propagated." Annelies Laschitzka, "Karl Kautsky im Widerstreit zwischen Marxismus und Opportunismus 1905 bis 1914," in *Marxismus und Demokratie: Karl Kautsky's Bedeutung in der sozialistischen Arbeiterbewegung*, eds. Jürgen Rojahn, Till Schelz, and Hans-Josef Steinberg (Frankfurt: Campus Verlag, 1992), 132, 135.

4. On the question of Fabian influence on Bernstein, see Bo Gustafsson, *Marxismus und Revisionismus* (Frankfurt am Main: Europäische Verlagsanstalt, 1972), 127-8. For a recent work stressing not only Bernstein's but also Kautsky's agreement with the Fabians on many issues in the 1890s, see H. Kendall Rogers, *Before the Revisionist Controversy*.

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Kautsky, Bernstein, and the Meaning of Marxism, 1895–1898 (New York: Garland, 1992), 121–29, 259–70.

5. *Protokoll über die Verhandlungen des Parteitages der Sozialdemokratischen Partei Deutschlands, abgehalten zu Stuttgart vom 3. bis 8. Oktober 1898* (Berlin: Vorwärts, 1898), 129.

6. Letter of 18 February 1898, International Institute of Social History (IISG, Amsterdam), Kautsky Nachlass, C 180, quoted in Hans-Josef Steinberg, *Sozialismus und deutsche Sozialdemokratie* 4th ed. (Bonn: J. H. W. Dietz, 1976), 80. In the same letter, Kautsky stressed that the proletariat's political revolution he considered inevitable in Germany would be a revolution not for socialism but for democracy, which Marx had associated with the bourgeoisie: "As the only opposition party, we have to fulfill the historical tasks of the bourgeoisie, not of the proletariat, to establish not the state of the future but the present-day English state."

7. Kautsky, "Was nun?" *Die Neue Zeit* 28/2 (1910): 36.

8. Kautsky, "Eine neue Strategie," *Die Neue Zeit* 28/2 (1910): 368.

9. *Ibid.*, 364–74, and Kautsky, "Zwischen Baden and Luxemburg," *ibid.*, 656–67. See also, *Der politische Massenstreik* (Berlin: Vorwärts, 1914), 198–203.

10. A similar system prevailed until 1909 in Saxony, the other major industrial state in the German Empire. On the Prussian and Saxon suffrage and its results, see Gerhard A. Ritter, *Wahlgeschichtliches Arbeitsbuch* (Munich: C. H. Beck, 1980), 132–49, 163–82.

11. W. L. Guttsman, *The German Social Democratic Party, 1875–1933. From Ghetto to Government* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1981), 132. See also *ibid.*, 4, and, for some striking illustrations, *ibid.*, 132–41.

12. See also Kautsky, *Bernstein and das sozialdemokratische Programm* (1899), 3d ed. (Bonn: J. H. W. Dietz, 1979), and Kautsky, *The Social Revolution* (1902). *The Road to Power* grew out of a polemic with the Revisionist Max Maurenbrecher, and part of chapter 2 and chapters 3 and 4 reproduce much of Kautsky's article "Reform and Revolution," *Die Neue Zeit* 27/1 (1908): 180–91, 220–32, 252–59.

13. For Kautsky's strong advocacy of SPD participation in elections to the Prussian parliament, which the Party was then boycotting, and in electoral agreements with left liberals, see Kautsky, "Umsturzgesetz und Landtagswahlen in Preussen," *Die Neue Zeit* 15/2 (1897): 275–82, where he wrote that his Party should not "declare war on any compromise in practical politics [nor] reject any planned cooperation agreed upon with neighboring parties on a particular occasion against a common enemy." Nonparticipation "might have seemed practical as long as we were a small party that had no influence on actual developments. This is different

today; we are now the largest party in Germany, and our passivity has equally practical effects as our activity" (pp. 279, 280). See also Kautsky, "Die Preussischen Landtagswahlen und die reaktionäre Masse," *Die Neue Zeit* 15/2 (1897): 580-90, on the same subject.

14. Kautsky, "Die sozialistischen Kongresse and der sozialistische Minister," *Die Neue Zeit* 19/1 (1900): 37.

15. Ibid., 44. See also Kautsky, "Zum Parteitag," *Die Neue Zeit* 21/2 (1903): 732-34, and Kautsky, "Bürgermeister and Minister," *Die Neue Zeit* 19/2 (1901): 796. Once the German Empire had been replaced by the parliamentary Weimar Republic with the SPD as its strongest supporter, but not strong enough to govern alone, Kautsky favored socialist participation in coalition governments, as he wrote in 1922, "not as a substitute for the proletarian revolution ..., but as an introduction to and preparation of this revolution, that is, the political rule by the proletariat alone through a purely socialist government supported by a proletarian majority [*Übermacht*].... Those who still reject the policy of coalitions on principle today are blind to the signs of the times in Germany." Kautsky, *The Labour Revolution* (New York: Dial Press, 1925), 53-54. See also Kautsky's preface to the third German edition of 1920 of *The Road to Power*, translated on pp. lxi-lxxxvi herein.

16. *Protokoll*, 129.

17. Kautsky, *The Social Revolution*, 82-83.

18. Kautsky, "Allerhand Revolutionäres," *Die Neue Zeit* 22/1 (1904): 590.

19. Kautsky, "Karl Kautsky," in *Die Volkswirtschaftslehre der Gegenwart in Selbstdarstellungen*, ed. Felix Meiner (Leipzig: Felix Meiner, 1924), 22; reprinted as "Mein Lebenswerk," in *Ein Leben für den Sozialismus. Erinnerungen an Karl Kautsky*, ed. Benedikt Kautsky (Hannover: J. H. W. Dietz, 1954), 25.

20. Johannes Ziekursch, *Politische Geschichte des Neuen Deutschen Kaiserreiches*, vol. 3 (Frankfurt am Main: Frankfurter Societäts-Druckerei, 1930), 191-96; Geoff Eley, *Reshaping the German Right* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1980), 285. For more detailed studies, see Wilhelm Schüssler, *Die Daily-Telegraph-Affaire; Fürst Bülow, Kaiser Wilhelm and die Krise des Zweiten Reiches 1908* (Göttingen: Musterschmidt, 1952), emphasizing the role of the chancellor and the emperor; Theodor Eschenburg, *Das Kaiserreich am Scheideweg* (Berlin: Verlag für Kulturpolitik, 1929), 131-75; and Erich Eyck, *Das persönliche Regiment Wilhelms II* (Erlenbach-Zürich: Eugen Rentsch, 1948), 492-503, emphasizing political and constitutional issues.

21. "The conviction grew in the population at large that their Kaiser had for years been under the influence of psychologically unbalanced and

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intellectually incompetent court advisers. In Kautsky's view this element of corruption would raise the revolutionary potential of the peasantry and lower middle class," Carl F. Schorske, *German Social Democracy, 1905-1917* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1955), 113. Both the *Daily Telegraph* Affair and the Harden-Eulenburg scandals are briefly discussed in Alex Hall, *Scandal, Sensation and Social Democracy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1977), 160-67.

22. Guttsman, *The German Social Democratic Party*, 90.

23. The membership of the free trade unions, that is, those close to the SPD, which had (with a minor exception in 1901) grown steadily from 223,530 in 1893 to 1,865,506 in 1907, actually declined slightly to 1,831,731 in 1908 and 1,832,667 in 1909. The membership of the much smaller "Christian" and "Hirsch-Duncker" trade unions also declined from 1907 to 1908 but grew again beginning in 1909. Wolfgang Hirsch-Weber, *Gewerkschaften in der Politik* (Cologne: Westdeutscher Verlag, 1959), 145-47.

24. Max Maurenbrecher, "Offener Brief an den Genossen Kautsky," *Die Neue Zeit* 22/1 (1908): 149, and Max Maurenbrecher, "Wo stehen wir?," *ibid.*, 395. Guttsman says: "The election of 1907, which reduced the size of the party's representation by thirty-eight, did not abate the strength of the belief in the values of reform within the group of deputies as against the greater radicalism of the party at large. Yet the response to a policy of coalition or mere collaboration was not really forthcoming from the Liberal parties." Guttsman, *The German Social Democratic Party*, 298.

25. Kautsky, "Der 25. Januar," *Die Neue Zeit* 25/1 (1907): 588-96. 26. *Ibid.*, 589, 596.

27. Kautsky had emphasized the attraction of imperialism to nonproletarian strata already in his first major article on imperialism, "Aeltere and neuere Kolonialpolitik," *Die Neue Zeit* 16/1 (1898): 812, and also in "Die kommenden Kongresse," *Die Neue Zeit* 18/2 (1900): 715. At the 1907 Stuttgart Congress of the Second International, he had opposed German and other socialist advocates of colonialism under capitalism and, in the future, under socialism. *Secretariat du Bureau Socialiste Internationale, VII^e Congrès Socialiste Internationale tenu à Stuttgart du 16 au 24 août 1907* (Brussels: Désiré Brismée, 1908), 313-16. See also Kautsky, *Sozialismus and Kolonialpolitik* (Berlin: Vorwärts, 1907.), and Brynjolf J. Hovde, "Socialistic Theories of Imperialism Prior to the Great War," *Journal of Political Economy* 36 (October 1928): 569-91. After the outbreak of World War I, Kautsky again attacked socialists who could not resist imperialist ideas. "Imperialistische Tendenzen in der Sozialdemokratie," *Die Neue Zeit* 34/1 (1915): 98; and *Sozialisten and Krieg*

(Prague: Orbis, 1937), 657. See also Hans Christoph Schröder, *Sozialistische Imperialismusdeutung* (Göttingen: Vanderhoeck & Ruprecht, 1973), 59–61.

28. According to Guttman, *The German Social Democratic Party*, 142, "up to 1900 a twelve-hour day was still quite common and ... by 1914 ... a ten-hour day and six-day week were general."

29. Kautsky, "Positive Arbeit and Revolution," *Die Neue Zeit* 27/2 (1909): 325–26, 337.

30. As he wrote in response to Ludwig Quessel, a Revisionist critic of his book: The Revisionists still expect that "the rule of the proletariat will be preceded by a victory of bourgeois democracy.... A new great revolution is still possible only as a proletarian revolution, a revolution carried from the beginning by the proletariat, even if it does not from its beginnings appear as a socialist revolution." Kautsky, "Ludwig unter den Propheten," *Die Neue Zeit* 28/1 (1909): 206.

31. After the 1903 Reichstag election, in which the SPD had been exceptionally successful and the left-liberals had registered losses, Kautsky had already written: "Imperial Germany is anything but a state governed by parliament. The conflicts between Social Democracy and the conservative parties become ever sharper. The dream of a 'great party of the Left,' which was to form a mass capable of governing, is definitely over. The bourgeois Left has been decimated and stands in decided opposition to Social Democracy.... Class interests are stronger than party interests. The political party interests of bourgeois and proletarian democrats may share ever so many points, the class antagonism between bourgeoisie and proletariat becomes ever deeper and drives the former the more into the camp of the opponents of democracy the stronger the proletarian democrats become.... It is simply impossible that strong bourgeois and proletarian democrats exist side by side. The one excludes the other." Kautsky, "Zum Parteitag," *Die Neue Zeit* 21/2 (1903): 734.

32. For an outspoken statement by Kautsky in an earlier period attacking the "principle" of opposition to one reactionary mass and advocating a policy of compromise and of electoral agreements with appropriate other parties, see his letter to Victor Adler of 5 May 1894 in Victor Adler, *Briefwechsel mit August Bebel and Karl Kautsky*, ed. Friedrich Adler (Vienna: Wiener Volksbuchhandlung, 1954), 152–54. Kautsky also sharply attacks the concept of the "one reactionary mass" and emphasizes conflicts among the opponents of Social Democracy in "Die preussischen Landtagswahlen und die reaktionäre Masse," *Die Neue Zeit* 15/2 (1897): 580–90. Twenty years later, Kautsky again voiced his opposition to the notion of one reactionary mass in "Der imperialistische Krieg," *Die Neue Zeit* 35/1 (1917): 450–54. There he quotes at length Engels's letter to him of 14

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October 1891, which also appears in *Friedrich Engels' Briefwechsel mit Karl Kautsky*, ed. Benedikt Kautsky (Vienna: Danubia, 1955), 309–11. See also Kautsky, "Imperialismus und reaktionäre Masse," *Die Neue Zeit* 35/2 (1917): 102–15, where Kautsky emphasizes the complexity of class interests and of their expression in the form of political tactics.

33. It is interesting to note that in rejecting a "bourgeois-proletarian coalition government ... as a means of developing proletarian power," Kautsky (p. 8) refers to the Marxian "phrase" of the dictatorship of the proletariat and interprets it as "exclusive political rule of the proletariat [as] the only form in which it would be able to wield political power," an interpretation he later elaborated in his attack on the Bolsheviks' use of the term as denoting a special form or style of government. Kautsky, *The Dictatorship of the Proletariat* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1964; reprint, Westport, Conn.: Greenwood Press, 1981), ch. 5. For other comments by Kautsky on the dictatorship of the proletariat, see his *Von der Demokratie zur Staatssklaverei. Eine Auseinandersetzung mit Trotzki* (1921), in *Demokratie oder Diktatur?* ed. Hans-Jürgen Mende (East Berlin: Dietz Verlag, 1990), 2:204–9; *The Labour Revolution* (New York: Dial Press, 1925), 59–89, where Kautsky takes issue with Lenin's *The State and Revolution*; and *Social Democracy versus Communism* (New York: Rand School Press, 1946), 29–47.

34. His words are close to those of Engels in "Grundsätze des Kommunismus," in Karl Marx, Friedrich Engels, *Werke*, 4 (East Berlin: Dietz Verlag, 1964), 372.

35. Kautsky, "Ein sozialdemokratischer Katechismus," *Die Neue Zeit* 12/2 (1893): 368. The title of this piece does not suggest that Kautsky presented a Social Democratic catechism but that he critically commented on a publication by that title.

36. Reinhold Hünlich, *Karl Kautsky and der Marxismus der II. Internationale* (Marburg: Verlag Arbeiterbewegung und Gesellschaftswissenschaft, 1981), 284, could, in his note 260, cite six works published between 1967 and 1975 using the passage in this manner. See also Marek Waldenberg, "Kautsky's Marx-Rezeption," in *Marxismus und Demokratie*, eds. Rojahn et al., 39–40, and my comments on the passage in my article on "Lenin and Kautsky on the Role of Intellectuals in the Labor Movement," in my book *Karl Kautsky*, 71.

37. For an excellent summary discussion of the evolution of Kautsky's thought on the mass strike in the context of debates on the subject among German Social Democrats, see Ingrid Gilcher-Holtey, *Das Mandat des Intellektuellen. Karl Kautsky und die Sozialdemokratie* (Berlin: Siedler, 1986), 184–204, 211, 219–22, 234. See also Dick Geary, *Karl Kautsky* (Manchester:

Manchester University Press, 1987), 60–72, who confuses Kautsky's failure to advocate specific tactics with fatalism and the advocacy of inaction. For a convenient collection of Kautsky's earlier statements on the political mass strike going back to 1891 (when he was the first German Marxist to see that strikes could serve to achieve political ends), see his *Der politische Massenstreik*, 23–24, 27, 68–103, 121–22, 127–28, 137–45, 148–55, 186. In that book, he refers to *The Road to Power* as stating that, given the possibility of revolutionary situations, one had to take into account "the possibility, indeed the necessity, of a political mass strike also in Germany, where in normal times the conditions for it are highly unfavorable" (p. 212).

38. Kautsky similarly states in his article "Nochmals die amerikanische Statistik," *Die Neue Zeit* 27/2 (1909): 832, that one of the principal tasks of his *Road to Power* had been to emphasize the need for a "common struggle of the Party and the trade unions."

39. Kautsky, "Was nun?" *Die Neue Zeit* 28/2 (1910): 33–40, 68–80, reprinted in Kautsky, *Der politische Massenstreik*, 224–45. The situation in which Kautsky wrote this article is well summarized in Gilcher-Holtey, *Das Mandat*, 234–37, 249.

40. Rosa Luxemburg, "Was weiter?" *Gesammelte Werke*, vol. 2 (East Berlin: Dietz Verlag, 1981), 289–99. Much of Kautsky's debate with Rosa Luxemburg and Anton Pannekoek on the mass strike is reprinted in *Die Massenstreikdebatte*, ed. Antonia Grunenberg (Frankfurt: Europäische Verlagsanstalt, 1970) and in *Kautsky, Luxemburg, Pannekoek. Socialisme: la voie occidentale*, ed. Henri Weber (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1983).

41. Kautsky, "Was nun?" 77.

42. Kautsky's prediction of an electoral victory proved accurate when, in 1912, the SPD increased its vote by nearly a million to 4,250,000, its share of the vote from 31.7 percent in 1903 and 28.9 percent in 1907 to 34.8 percent, and the number of its seats in the Reichstag from 81 in 1903 and 43 in 1907 to 110. On the other hand, Kautsky's prediction of a coup failed. He offered an explanation in *Der politische Massenstreik*, 247–55. We will never know whether Kautsky's prediction of a confrontation between Social Democracy and the imperial regime would have come true had it not been for the outbreak of World War I two years later (when, much to his chagrin, the majority of the SPD supported the regime) and the collapse of the imperial regime in November 1918.

43. Kautsky, "Was nun?" 80. Already in 1898, Kautsky had predicted a coup d'état by the government in response to socialist electoral advances. In the letter to Bernstein of 18 February 1898 cited in note 6 above, he wrote: "Even before we have a hundred deputies, the struggle against us

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will get started, not about socialism, but about democracy. Coup d'état, abolition of the franchise, emergency legislation will come then if not earlier." Steinberg, *Sozialismus*, 80.

44. Gilcher-Holtey, *Das Mandat*, 248.

45. This is implied when the book is called "by far the most radical of his works," as it is by Fülberth in his introduction to the German edition of 1972 (xvii).

46. Kautsky, "Ein sozialdemokratischer Katechismus," 368, reprinted on 34 herein; Kautsky, *Der Parlamentarismus, die Volksgesetzgebung und die Sozialdemokratie* (Stuttgart: J. H. W. Dietz, 1893), 155–56.

47. Letter of 8 July 1893 to Franz Mehring, quoted from the Introduction to Rosa Luxemburg, *Gesammelte Werke*, vol. 3, *Gegen den Reformismus* (Berlin, 1925), 23, in Gerhard A. Ritter, *Die Arbeiterbewegung im Willhelminischen Reich* (Berlin: Colloquium Verlag, 1959), 203, n. 170. Already in 1898, at the SPD Congress in Stuttgart, Kautsky had argued against Bernstein, just as he did against Ludwig Quessel in 1909 – see note 30 above – that in Germany it was hopeless to wait for "a victory of bourgeois democracy" to precede a Social Democratic victory: "If Bernstein believes that we must first have democracy in order then gradually to lead the proletariat to victory, then I say, here the matter is reversed, here the victory of democracy is dependent on a victory of the proletariat." *Protokoll*, 129.

48. "Sisyphusarbeit oder positive Erfolge?," *Korrespondenzblatt der Generalkommission der Gewerkschaften Deutschlands*, 9 (1909): 501–5, 517–19, 529–32, 545–48, 561–64, 577–80, 617–24, republished as *Sisyphusarbeit oder positive Erfolge?* (Berlin: Verlag der Generalkommission der Gewerkschaften Deutschlands, 1910).

49. Also earlier in Kautsky, "Leichtfertige Statistik," *Die Neue Zeit* 27/2 (1909): 517–24, and in "Nochmals die amerikanische Statistik," *ibid.*, 782–86, 821–32.

50. The growth of trade-union power in the SPD in the 1906–9 period and the bureaucratization of the Party were well analyzed in Schorske, *German Social Democracy*, 88–145. With respect to trade union power, he concluded: "The fear that trade-union leaders might withhold electoral support from the party made the executive acutely sensitive to the trade-unionists' demands. The unionists, with their anti-revolutionary attitude, may be presumed to have represented more accurately than the Social Democratic Party the mass of German workers in our period. By organizing these masses where the party could not, the union leaders were able to transmit the subjective attitudes of the politically passive workers into the Social Democratic Party itself, with the party executive as their

agent. In this sense the trade-union conquest made the party more representative of German labor than it had been before 1906. Yet herein lay the fatal difficulty: the trade-union bureaucracy was anti-revolutionary in Permanenz, by virtue of its corporate interest in the existing order. The working class was not similarly committed, and the party had therefore represented the proletariat's revolutionary potential as well as its reformist actuality. By capitulating before the trade-unions in our period, the party surrendered its political flexibility, and thus prepared the ground for its subsequent dissolution" (p. 110). On SPD-trade union relations, see also Guttman, *The German Social Democratic Party*, 279-87. As to bureaucratization, Schorske concluded: "The principal positive task of the bureaucracy, to build up the party for electoral victories, necessarily involved a negative attitude toward any pressure for a change in tactic which would either divide the party or alienate the non-socialist voter. What the party functionary wanted above all else was peace and unity in the organization. In the riven condition of the party this made him a natural opponent of both criticism and change. And as the pressure for change came increasingly from the left, the functionary identified himself increasingly with the right" (p. 127). "There is enough evidence to suggest that the defeat of radicalism within the party was aided by the establishment of the regional bureaucracy and regional institutions which based their power on the small-town worker and/or on the non-party trade-union member whose political attitudes toward the social order were not nearly so negative as those of the urban party member" (pp. 135-36).

51. A quick survey of the committee's membership suggests that four of its eight members – Ebert, Gerisch, Molkenbuhr, and Pfannkuch – were close to the trade unions, and a fifth, Müller, may also have been chiefly concerned with matters of organization and social policy. Bebel, the Party leader and Kautsky's old supporter, was sick and spent much of his time in Switzerland. Only the two remaining members, Singer and Zietz, were clearly identified with Kautsky's "radical" wing of the Party, but according to Hermann Brill, "Karl Kautsky. 16. Oktober 1854-17. Oktober 1938," *Zeitschrift für Politik* [Neue Folge] (October 1954): 221, Singer "in particular" opposed the distribution of *The Road to Power*, which seems confirmed by a remark in Bebel's letter to Adler of 28 February 1909, reprinted on p. 105.

52. Gary P. Steenson, *Karl Kautsky, 1854-1938. Marxism in the Classical Years* (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1978; paperback ed., 1991), 166-67.

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53. See Zetkin's letter to Kautsky of 24 February 1909, International Institute of Social History, Kautsky Nachlass, D XXIII 378, quoted in Ursula Ratz, "Karl Kautsky's Einschätzung von Krieg and Frieden im Zeitalter des Imperialismus," in *Marxismus and Demokratie*, eds. Rojahn et al., 190. See also August Bebel's *Briefwechsel mit Karl Kautsky*, ed. Karl Kautsky, Jr. (Assen: Van Gorcum, 1971), 203. Massimo Salvadori, *Karl Kautsky and the Socialist Revolution, 1880-1938* (London: NLB, 1979), 131 also states that "the revisionists threatened a scission if *Der Weg zur Macht* appeared under the imprint of the party."

54. Steinberg, *Sozialismus*, 82.

55. Haase says in this letter that he cannot understand how the compromise can be seen as a "disgraceful capitulation" on Kautsky's part, thus disagreeing with Clara Zetkin – see her bitter letter to Kautsky of 16 March 1909 (pp. 172-73). She was Kautsky's most fervent defender in the controversy and later a leading member of the USPD, the Spartacus League, and, from its beginnings until her death near Moscow in 1933, of the German Communist Party (KPD). Even an East German writer could conclude that "after much back and forth maneuvering, Kautsky succeeded in maintaining his position vis-à-vis the Party executive," and she quotes a letter of his of 27 March 1909 from the Moscow archives: "My *Road* will appear in the course of next week with a little addition to the preface, in which I alone assume all responsibility for its contents, and with several formal changes, in which not a single thought is being sacrificed." Annelies Laschitzka, "Karl Kautsky im Widerstreit," 134.

56. I have compared the first and second editions page by page and (aside from the addition of more recent figures or the replacement by them of older ones in the statistics on pp. 49, 55, 56, 58, 64, 71, 76, 78-80) have found the following changes of any significance: A reference to "revolution" as a real possibility in the foreseeable future is omitted in the final paragraph of the first chapter on p. 6, as is the phrase "to break the chains one had borne for so long" on p. 51. The word "revolution" is replaced by "decisive struggle" on p. 5, by "the proletariat's victory" on p. 51, and by the proletariat achieving "political power" on p. 51. On the same page, "times of revolution" become "times of revolutionary ferment," "such a situation" replaces a "revolutionary situation," "an interest in a revolution" becomes an interest in "gaining political power," and leading the "revolution to victory" becomes leading "the rising class to victory." On p. 44 the "overthrow" of a regime inimical to the people is replaced by it becoming "untenable." The phrase "in the foreseeable future" is omitted in the final sentence of chapter 6 on p. 51. On p. 84 "war also means revolution" is replaced by "the experience of the last decades

proves, that war means revolution, that it results in enormous shifts of political power." Also on p. 71 "peacefully" has been replaced by "without a struggle," and on p. 50 quotation marks are added to "soldiers of the revolution" and the same phrase is omitted in the next paragraph. Clearly, almost all changes merely eliminated the word "revolution," which would seem to make little difference as that word still appears over and over again throughout the second edition. It is also noteworthy that Kautsky did not change a number of passages, including the final sentence of the book, that had been considered possibly legally objectionable by Joseph Herzfeld, a socialist lawyer consulted by Bebel. See Ursula Ratz, "Briefe zum Erscheinen von Karl Kautskys 'Weg zur Macht,'" *International Review of Social History* 12/3 (1967): 453-55.

57. Gilcher-Holtey, *Das Mandat*, 232. Steenson, who does not analyze Kautsky's controversy with the Party Executive Committee as fully as Gilcher-Holtey, unlike her simply concludes that the committee "gave in." Steenson, *Karl Kautsky*, 168.

58. "Practical politics seeks power, theory seeks knowledge and understanding." Kautsky, "Der Parteitag in Lubeck," *Die Neue Zeit* 20/1 (1901): 19-20. See also Kautsky, "Vorwort," *General-Register des Inhalts der Jahrgänge 1883 bis 1902 der Neuen Zeit* (Stuttgart: Paul Singer, 1905), viii-ix. For Kautsky's view of the role of intellectuals and also of his own role in the Party, see my article on "Lenin and Kautsky" in *Karl Kautsky*, 59-66, 79-82.

59. Gilcher-Holtey, *Das Mandat*, 234. For a beautiful summary statement of the changes in the nature of the SPD and in Kautsky's relation to it, see pp. 250-51.

60. That consistency is a major theme of Salvadori, *Karl Kautsky*, particularly pp. 11-12.

61. Kautsky, *Das Erfurter Programm*, 19th ed. (Bonn: J. H. W. Dietz, 1974), 21617. The translation of this passage in *The Class Struggle* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1971), 188, is incomplete and inexact.

62. Kautsky, *Der politische Massenstreik*, 213-22.

63. "Centrism" as a new phenomenon has been emphasized particularly by German Communist writers in search of the origins of the "renegadism" that Lenin had attributed to Kautsky. They place it at the latest in 1910, when, it is intriguing to note, Lenin evidently tended to side with Kautsky against Luxemburg (see footnote 57 to my article on "Lenin and Kautsky"). See Hans-Jurgen Mende, *Karl Kautsky – vom Marxisten zum Opportunisten* (East Berlin: Dietz Verlag, 1985), 99-104, 111-28, and the following earlier articles, all in *Beiträge zur Geschichte der deutschen Arbeiterbewegung* (East Berlin): Ulla Plener, "Karl Kautskys

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Opportunismus in Organisationsfragen (1900–14). Zur Entstehung des Zentrismus in der deutschen Sozialdemokratie," *ibid.*, 3 (1961): 349–70; Gerd Irrlitz, "Bemerkungen über die Einheit politischer and theoretischer Wesenszüge des Zentrismus in der deutschen Sozialdemokratie," *ibid.*, 8 (1966): 43–59; and Annelies Laschitzka, "Karl Kautsky und der Zentrismus," *ibid.*, 10 (1968): 798–832; she says *ibid.*, 831–32: "The fact that centrism represents bourgeois ideology and bourgeois politics in the labor movement ... and was therefore a particularly dangerous opportunistic tendency is for the Marxist-Leninist science of history incontrovertible." See also Laschitzka, "Karl Kautsky im Widerstreit," 134. Georg Fülberth, in his introduction to the 1972 German edition of *Der Weg zur Macht*, xvii, calls the book Kautsky's "last 'revolutionary' work, shortly before his open shift to 'centrist' positions in 1910." Hünlich, who is as critical of Leninist interpretations as he is of Kautsky, entitles his section on *The Road to Power* "a swan song of doctrinaire Marxism?" (*Karl Kautsky*, 153) and sees Kautsky's "shift to the position of centrism" as involving a "deep-going change" (p. 170).

64. Kautsky, *The Dictatorship of the Proletariat* (1918); Kautsky, *Terrorism and Communism* (1919) (London: National Labour Press, 1920; reprint, Westport, Conn.: Hyperion Press, 1973).

65. As Hans-Josef Steinberg wrote: "Kautsky believed in principle in a peaceful development to socialism, but as a condition for it democracy or a parliamentary system appeared to him necessary.... The difference with Bernstein consisted in Kautsky having doubts as to whether democracy could be achieved in Germany on a road other than that of a political revolution to which a Social Democratic majority would be forced by the resistance to democratization of a reactionary government." Steinberg, *Sozialismus*, 81.

66. In 1893 when Kautsky was generally regarded as — next to Engels, who was still alive — the prime voice of orthodox Marxism, Kautsky made statements in two letters to Franz Mehring that he could have repeated at any time in the remaining forty-five years of his life. On 8 July he wrote: "But for the dictatorship of the proletariat I cannot imagine any other form than that of a powerful parliament on the British model with a Social Democratic majority backed by a strong and conscious proletariat." On 15 July he repeated: "Only the parliamentary republic can in my judgment form the basis on which the dictatorship of the proletariat and the socialist society can grow. This republic is the 'state of the future' we must strive for." Quoted in Steinberg, *Sozialismus*, 81, footnote 233, and in Karl Renner, *Karl Kautsky* (Berlin: J. H. W. Dietz, 1929), 86.

Preface to the First Edition

It seems to me that a new discussion of the question of political revolution, of the great shifts of political power, is extremely timely just now, when everyone is concerned with the struggles against personal rule and the questions concerning the constitution. There is the dangerous possibility that the difficulties of the situation will be attributed merely to a single individual, that everyone's attention will be concentrated on this person. For that reason it is necessary to show the deeper social interrelations, out of which the unrest and uncertainty of the present time arise, and which account for the fact that the accidental peculiarity of a single individual is able to bring forth movements that shake our political conditions to their deepest foundations and prepare the way for their radical change.

Although this situation is the internal cause of the present work, its external cause lay in a polemic to which Maurenbrecher's attacks had provoked me and which was carried on in *Die Neue Zeit*. [Max Maurenbrecher, "Offener Brief an den Genossen Kautsky" (Open letter to comrade Kautsky), *Die Neue Zeit*, 27/1 (1908): 148-53; Kautsky, "Reform and Revolution," *Die Neue Zeit* 27/1 (1908): 180-91, 220-32, 252-59.] In that polemic I already felt myself compelled, because of the present conditions, to develop more fully my views regarding revolution. Called upon from various quarters to make this discussion available to a wider audience in a separate publication, I set about reworking the series of articles into a pamphlet. In this work, I, of course, omitted any polemic directed specifically against Maurenbrecher, as there is no general interest for this personal side of the matter. The introduction was therefore given a completely new form. On the other hand, the format of the pamphlet freed me from the need to observe the constraints imposed by the limited space of *Die Neue Zeit* and the framework of the polemic. What I had been able to touch on only briefly in my final chapter, namely the present-day situation, its peculiar features, and its tasks, I could now develop in more detail and it has become the principal topic of this work. Of its nine chapters, only the third and the fourth, as well as the second, half of the second, reproduce what was contained in the series of articles in *Die Neue Zeit*. Everything else is new.

In its entirety the work is a supplement to my pamphlet on social revolution that was published in 1902. [Kautsky, *The Social Revolution* (Chicago: Charles H. Kerr, 1916)]

Because it can be expected that the polemic which gave birth to this pamphlet will draw new fuel from it, I want to state here that I alone, and not my party, am responsible for what I have written, insofar as it is not

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based on our program and on the resolutions of our Party congresses. That is self-evident for every publication not issued officially by the Party, but it can do no harm to make a special point of calling this fact to the attention of critics and polemicists.

Karl Kautsky

Preface to the Second Edition

[of 1909]*

The admittedly not difficult "prophecy" of the preface to the first edition, that the present work would occasion lively rejoinders, has been fulfilled. Nevertheless I see no reason to alter even a single word of any significance in the second edition. I have replaced some statistics by more recent ones; otherwise the new edition is an unchanged reproduction of the first one.

Among the responses a series of articles in the *Korrespondenzblatt der Gewerkschaften* particularly stood out. ["Sisyphusarbeit oder positive Erfolge?" (Sisyphean labor or positive successes?), *Korrespondenzblatt der Generalkommission der Gewerkschaften Deutschlands* 9 (1909): 501-5, 517-19, 529-32, 545-48, 561-64, 577-80, 617-24.] They were then published in an offprint under the same title. This series of articles distinguishes itself by its length but also by the particular irritation of its language, which became intentionally offensive. My work did not give the least reason for such a tone, as anyone can see who takes the trouble to read it. It contains not one word that might be insulting to a trade unionist. I have already refuted this publication in a series of articles in *Die Neue Zeit* [Kautsky, "Leichtfertige Statistik" (Irresponsible statistics), *Die Neue Zeit* 27/2 (1909): 517-24; "Nochmals die amerikanische Statistik" (Once again, the American statistics), *Die Neue Zeit*, 27/2 (1909): 782-86, 821-32], and I consider it superfluous to repeat what I said there. If I speak here again of that attack on me, I do so only to eliminate every possibility of a misunderstanding of my intentions.

The very title of that rejoinder publication clearly indicates that it accuses me of depreciating the trade unions' successes. Indeed it goes even further; it accuses me of hostility to trade unions and maintains that "the development of the trade unions into powerful organizations in economic life is not important" to me.

That is an out-and-out untruth. In the present work (ch. 8, pp. 103 and 106), I explicitly emphasize just the opposite; I point out the *importance* and the *indispensability* of the trade unions. Nor have I ever spoken of the "Sisyphean labor" of the trade unions, or denied their "positive successes," but rather I have spoken expressly about the German trade unions' "magnificent development" and recognized that they "have succeeded in obtaining considerable improvements with respect to wages and hours and other working conditions" (ch. 7, pp. 95-96). My interest in the trade unions' advance has also been recognized by a number of unbiased unionists, for example, the journal of the Austrian metal workers.

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I will, however, concede that some passages might give a *cursory* reader the impression that I deny the positive successes of the unions. Certainly, the reader would have to be in a great hurry not to notice that I stress that from the beginning of the 1890s, the German unions were for many years able to make astonishing advances. If factors are becoming effective that are resisting this advance of the unions ever more strongly, then that is a development of the last three to four years. These factors, however, are the grounds for my belief that we must not expect that "the end of the crisis will bring back the progress of the period from 1895 to 1907... As important, indeed indispensable, as the unions are and remain, we must not expect that they will again, using purely *trade-union methods*, advance the proletariat as powerfully as they succeeded in doing in the last dozen years" (ch. 8, p. 103).

That is my contention. It is, as anyone can see, something quite different from a denial of the successes of the trade unions, of which I say explicitly that from 1895 to 1907, they powerfully advanced the German proletariat.

It is, then, not a matter of the successes of the past. They are unquestioned. Rather, it is a question of the successes of the present and the future. Of course, there can be very different opinions about these. But when the pamphlet *Sisyphean Labor* believes it is refuting me by setting forth how much was achieved by the unions in the different branches of industry from 1895 to 1907, then it is only breaking down doors that are already open; it is merely illustrating what I maintain, but is doing me a bitter injustice by leading its readers to believe that I deny the most obvious facts, and that I do so in order to disparage the unions.

Against such an untruthful kind of polemic — putting it less harshly than I might — I must protest in the strongest terms.

Things are different with regard to my expectations about the trade unions' future successes. In this connection, I have encountered from even very benevolent and knowledgeable critics the objection that my discussions could dishearten the union members and diminish the attraction of the unions.

The objections of those critics were of two kinds. First, they assumed that my understanding of the economic situation of the working class in the last three to four years and in the immediate future was too pessimistic.

However, the development of conditions in the year since the first publication of my *Road to Power* has destroyed all doubts that could still be advanced against my understanding. The increase of prices has become a scourge under which the proletariat has suffered terribly everywhere,

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not just in America, but in Great Britain too, in Austria as well as in Germany.

Today that is also recognized by men whom no one will accuse of underestimating the unions' successes. Thus Professor Staudinger wrote in no. 29 of *Die konsumgenossenschaftliche Rundschau* about the employers' associations and their effects:

In the earlier economic period, then, prices rose, certainly, during periods of prosperity, but wages usually rose more than prices did, and in times of crisis, although wages fell, prices fell even more. On the whole, the years from 1860 to 1900 were characterized by the rise of incomes from wages, the fall of prices, and the increase of purchasing power. *In the present-day economic period of rings and cartels, as well as of agrarian monopolies, it is true that wages still rise during periods of prosperity, but prices often rise relatively more. During a period of depression, incomes decline, but prices fall only for some goods; to a large extent, they continue to rise. Thus a period is beginning that is marked by decline of the masses' purchasing power – stagnation.*

The question is treated more thoroughly by Otto Bauer in his excellent work *Die Teuerung* [The rise of prices] (Vienna: Volksbuchhandlung). He arrives at the conclusion:

As much as the trade-unions' struggle has raised the level of monetary wages, the level of real wages has nonetheless risen much more slowly. *In recent years, it has undoubtedly fallen.* In point of fact, the rise of prices is at the present time the worst obstacle to the advance of the working class; the struggle against the increase of prices, one of our most important tasks. (Otto Bauer, "Die Teuerung," in O. Bauer, *Werkausgabe* [Vienna: Europa-verlag, 1975], 1:755.)

There is, however, no need at all for these facts to make us pessimistic. I had neither reason nor the intent to be pessimistic about the capability of the unions. I maintained only that we must not expect them, by means of *purely trade-union methods*, to once again move the proletariat in Germany ahead as powerfully as they succeeded in doing in the years

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from 1895 to 1907. It is not the *moving ahead*, but the *method* that is thereby called into question.

It is only natural that trade unions, with purely trade-union methods, achieve the greatest and the fastest improvement in the situation of the working class when the latter has been hitherto unorganized and then becomes organized and active in labor unions.

The organized worker is vastly superior to the unorganized worker. In trades and in regions where previously no or only weak unions existed, and where a strong union organization is successfully created, this necessarily leads to a rapid advancement of the member workers. Comparison of the situation of workers who were formerly unorganized and are now organized will generally show a considerable improvement.

But it would be wrong to expect, because the transition from the unorganized to the organized stage meant a great leap forward, that within the organized stage there must always continue to be progress in the same kind of leaps. Once unions have become universal in a branch of industry and in a region, they soon obtain from the enterprises everything that can be gotten for the workers through the simple power of the unions. All further advances beyond this stage depend on numerous circumstances that cannot be calculated ahead of time. Generally, however, progress by means of purely trade-union methods will tend to slow down after unions have been in existence for some time. Great Britain gives us clear evidence of this.

The union's importance for the worker is not lessened by this fact, however. While it was inestimable for the unorganized worker because it permitted him to gain a great deal, the union is no less important for the worker who has been organized for a considerable time. For he won so much through the union that he will lose much if it declines. And he has no possibility of further progress without the union.

When strong unions have existed for years in a branch of industry or in a region, the workers' interest in the union becomes different, but no less significant than when the union is still young. In that case, the union becomes more a force for holding fast than a conquering one, more a conservative than a revolutionary force.

That is true, though, only with regard to its purely union functions. At the same time, conditions are coming into being that in this later stage assign to the trade union new functions, which give the union even greater importance, but also shape it again into a revolutionary force, that is, into a force that does not just hold fast to what has been gained, but also conquers new gains.

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It has often been pointed out that the relative importance of the political and the economic struggle within the labor movement changes in the course of capitalist development. In Germany, the importance of the political struggle predominated until 1890, not owing to a lack of appreciation of union activity, but because the conditions for political activity were better developed and more could be attained through it. From the beginning of the 1860s into the first years of the 1870s, Germany was in a revolutionary stage; the old political system was overthrown and a new one created, with universal suffrage, freedom of association and of movement, and some protection for workers. Then, at the end of the 1870s, part of these achievements was wiped out by the anti-socialist law and, at the same time, by a long-lasting crisis. Both the economic and the political conditions for the trade-union movement were unfavorable; the political struggle against the anti-socialist law was the most important thing.

The revocation of the anti-socialist law was a turning point. The way was then open for the unions' development. Their development was favored also by the economic upswing that was starting.

In politics, on the other hand, the last great struggles between the possessing classes in defense of their interests had been concluded. The Social Democrats became more and more the only party that wanted to go beyond the existing conditions. All other parties in fact became conservative, and a general political stagnation began.

The splendid advances of the unions were in striking contrast to that stagnation. For some years, however, growing obstacles to these advances have been appearing, obstacles that cannot be overcome by purely union methods, but only by political struggle, and that absolutely must be eliminated if the working class's advance is to continue.

These obstacles are visibly expressed in the increasing rise of prices, which is due in part to the growing power of the large agricultural land owners, that is, of private ownership of the land, which is using its monopoly to increase ground rent. In part, the rise of prices is a result of [the German government's] armaments policy – a natural consequence of [its] expansionist policy – and the new taxes arising from that policy. Lastly, a third source of the rise of prices is to be found in the increasing concentration of capital, which favors the employers' associations and makes the government more and more dependent on them.

Defeating the armaments policy, overcoming the domination of the state by the Junkers and the industrial barons, that is to say, democratization of the Reich, these have now become the most important

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practical tasks of the German proletariat. They must be carried out if its advance is to continue.

They certainly cannot be carried out by means of purely trade-union methods. Just as certainly, though, they cannot be carried out without strong unions that are capable of fighting and conscious of their strength.

If today, as in the period from 1862 to 1890, politics has again moved into the foreground of the labor movement, that can no longer mean a withdrawal of the unions, for the situation has changed greatly.

Then there were still strong strata of the propertied classes [i.e., owning income-producing property] that had an interest in a thoroughgoing radical change of the political conditions. In their efforts to achieve that change, these strata sought to have as their ally the proletariat, which was already strong enough to be a political factor, but not yet strong and independent enough to appear as a dangerous enemy in all circumstances.

After 1864, the young labor movement remained divided for a long time, not over of the question whether the proletariat had anything to expect from one of the parties of the propertied classes, but over of the question of which party it could expect more from, from the followers of Bismarck and Wagener or from the bourgeois democrats. Today things are completely different. If voices are still raised here and there in our ranks calling for a policy of alliance, those urging this policy might seem to themselves frightfully modern; in fact, they are nothing but an atavism, a return to ideas whose real foundation was already eliminated in the period from 1866 to 1870, ideas for which there is no longer any foundation other than pious wishes. For at the present time, it could not possibly occur to anyone who is to be taken seriously to consider an alliance of the Social Democratic Party with one of the existing bourgeois parties. To make such a policy of alliance possible, our party would itself first have to create the necessary bourgeois democratic party — and provide its voters. Its leaders could surely be found.

No, for energetic political action the Social Democratic Party can today no longer find an ally in another party in Germany. However, that is made up for by the fact that the class from which the Social Democratic Party is recruited has today become the most numerous, economically the most indispensable, the most zealous, the most intelligent, the most independent of the classes that make up the mass of the population.

Not a *policy of alliance*, but only *mass action*, and specifically the action of organized masses, can move us ahead today. *Massiveness of scale and organization* — those are the weapons suitable to the proletariat's economic situation. Only with them can it stand its ground and gain victory. But

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proletarian mass organization and mass action mean *trade-union* organization and action.

We make no advances without political conquests. But we cannot win political victories without the help of strong unions that are capable of struggle and conscious of their strength.

When in all regions and branches of industry where strong unions have been in existence for a long time, their responsibilities in the area of *purely union* activity are more and more limited to retaining what has been gained; when large advances by means of purely trade-union methods become ever more difficult and rarer there, then an immense field of the most fruitful activity is opened up for the unions by the co-operation of party and union, by actions that are fruitful for both union and political activity at the same time.

In view of this prospect, it is worse than ridiculous to accuse those social democrats holding such a view of having no interest in the strengthening of the unions. Those who make this accusation are not merely asserting an untruth, but also thereby sowing the seeds of mistrust and estrangement between the party and the unions, at a time when each must rely on the other more than ever.

One of the tasks that I set for this pamphlet was to direct the attention of union members to the new functions that are arising for them in addition to the purely trade-union ones and thus raise the significance of trade unions; it was not to diminish their significance and to fill their members with pessimism.

I hope that, despite the misrepresentations in the pamphlet with which the general commission [of the trade-union federation] has replied to it, my pamphlet will find among unionists enough readers who grasp its true meaning and recognize the author's good intentions, even when they cannot agree with his conclusions.

Berlin-Friedenau, 1 July 1910

Karl Kautsky

EDITOR'S NOTE: There were two issues of the second edition. The first was published in April 1909 without this preface, and the second was published in July 1910 and included this preface.

Preface to the Third Edition [of 1920]

This, the third edition of my *Road to Power*, is an unaltered reprint of the second edition. To be sure an entire decade, one filled with gigantic wars and upheavals such as the world had never seen, lies between the two. Nevertheless or rather for that very reason, I could not make any change to this work. For if I attempted to bring it up to date and to incorporate into it the results of the last ten years, then I would have had to write something wholly new and different, because the most important of the problems that I treat of in the following work no longer exists. The events have swept it away, along with so much else.

In 1909, I considered here the question whether it was possible that we might grow into socialism peacefully and imperceptibly, or whether we were heading toward great catastrophes, wars, and revolutions. Since then, the question has been answered by world history, and indeed, in the same way that I had in the following pages on the basis of theoretical reflections. If a re-writing of my pamphlet would have to create something fundamentally new, that is not because the course of events proved my views untenable, but because it confirmed them in the swiftest and most thorough manner.

It could be said, certainly, that if that is the case, if the problem no longer exists that my pamphlet treated of, has it not then become a mere historical document which can only serve to characterize our way of thinking before the war? Has it not lost all significance for the present? Not at all. Its current relevance has only become one of a different kind.

What my pamphlet treated theoretically in 1909 has now become highly practical: the revolution. Only a few had expected it. For the great majority it came as a surprise, as a raging floodtide that carried everything away with itself, in which only a very few managed to see their way, in which most, lacking anything to hold on to, were buffeted about.

Such a lack of steady support and such uncertainty can be best opposed by directing one's attention not solely to what is nearest at hand and to what exists or is happening in the present moment and by not letting oneself be guided solely by them, but instead by striving to gain a farther reaching outlook, and in so doing comparing what is closest at hand with what is at a distance, measuring the events of the moment by theoretical conceptions based on the lessons learned from many centuries of experience, and finally by not listening merely to the voice of the passions, which summons up a desperate and stubborn struggle for life and death, but rather listening also to cooler reflections from a more tranquil era.

When my *Road to Power* appeared in 1909, it was precisely the revolutionary elements of our party who greeted it with unanimous applause. Even now, the men of the extreme left still love to i

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authority of my *Road to Power* to justify their position. They do so even though a great antagonism has admittedly arisen between us. The reason for this is supposed to be that I abandoned the views that I presented and defended in the present work. According to this explanation, I deserted my convictions in the very moment when they were proved correct; I had held fast to them as long as they were jeered at and opposed in the ranks of my own party, and betrayed them just when they were gaining victory. What strange behavior! The weakling who despairs of his cause, the scoundrel who sells it out – no one will deny that they become “renegades” and “Judases” only when this cause is being defeated, not in the hour of its victory.

Whoever claims to find that I have made an about-face since the revolution, and advances *The Road to Power* as evidence supporting that claim, has either not read or not understood my 1909 pamphlet. My standpoint today is still the same as it was then. Only my language has changed. There are times of faint-heartedness when it is necessary to encourage those who are losing heart and to drive them forward; and there are times when our forces are storming blindly forward, when it is necessary to admonish the illusionists and the fanatics to prudence. But this change in language is evidence only of a change of the historical situation, not of my fundamental view.

I have the right to publish the new edition as an entirely unaltered reprint, if for no other reason than because I still stand by every sentence in this work today. If many of those who cheered me in 1909 are now stoning me, then the change of mind on which this antagonism is based is not on my part, but on theirs. Their conception of the revolution as it has taken shape in the wild chaos of the last years has become incompatible with the conception of the revolution that had gained general acceptance among the radical Marxists in the period before the war.

They all shared my opinion when I wrote in the present pamphlet:

We are neither men of legality at any price, *nor are we revolutionaries at any price*. We know that we cannot create historical situations as we would like to have them, that our tactics must be adapted to them. (ch. 5, p. 69)

And a few pages earlier, I called for a

... revolutionary passion, which is not the mindless excitement of surprise, but rather the product of clear understanding. (ch. 4, p. 48)

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Even then, I was not an admirer of the use of physical violence in the revolution. I wrote:

Since we know nothing about the decisive battles of the social war, we can, of course, say just as little whether they will be bloody, whether physical force will play a significant role in them, or whether they will be fought exclusively with the means of economic, legislative, and moral pressure.

But one can surely say that, in all likelihood, in the proletariat's revolutionary struggles, the latter kind of means will predominate over those of the physical sort, that is, military force, more than was the case in the revolutionary struggles of the bourgeoisie. (ch. 5, p. 57)

My expectation was based on the fact that

... the revolutionary strata have today better weapons of economic, political, and moral resistance at their disposal than did the revolutionary strata of the eighteenth century. *Only Russia is an exception.* (ch. 5, p. 57)

For Russia, then, I feared that the revolution would assume a bloody form. But I was far from regarding it as the normal form of the modern revolution. In my *Road to Power*, Russia already seemed to me an exception that could not serve as a model for us.

Wherever there was no democracy, in Russia and elsewhere, I considered the immediate goal of the revolution to be the conquest and consolidation of democracy. I declared:

... the particular form of government in which alone socialism can be realized, is the republic, and by that I mean 'republic' in the most common meaning of the term, namely *the democratic republic*. (ch. 5, p. 34)

At the time I assumed that I was speaking in the name of revolutionary Marxism. And not a single Marxist revolutionary repudiated me, neither Rosa Luxemburg nor Klara Zetkin, neither Lenin nor Trotsky. They all shared with me then the same democratic conviction. It is a bit much when elements, who since then have disdainfully tossed democracy on the scrap heap, calling it "formal" or

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"bourgeois democracy," criticize me, of all people, for defecting from the old conviction.

In 1909, the revolutionary Marxists protested neither against my proclamation of democracy, nor against my view, which was self-evident from the Marxist standpoint, that not all countries had already matured to the point of being ready for socialism, above all Russia.

In chapter 2 of my 1909 pamphlet, I quoted one of my earlier articles, written in 1904, with which I still agreed. In that article I said:

A revolution in Russia could not, for the present, establish a socialist regime. The country's economic conditions are too immature for that. Initially, it would be able only to bring into being a democratic regime, behind which, however, a strong and impetuous proletariat would stand, pressing forward. Through its efforts, this proletariat would be able to achieve considerable concessions. (ch. 2, p. 17)

However, the future of democracy in Russia and in Eastern Europe did not appear to me at all as an idyll.

In chapter 9, I described the "revolutionary period beginning for the East" as

... a period of conspiracies, coups d'état, uprisings, reactions and renewed rebellions, continuous upheavals, that will last until the conditions required for a tranquil development and secure national independence of that world have been achieved. (ch. 9, pp.129)

We have, in fact, now entered this troubled stage. For those who expected that, it seemed only reasonable to count on the appearance of tendencies that have been realized in the present-day Bolshevik dictatorship. As early as 1909 I rejected those tendencies. In chapter 6 of my pamphlet, I said:

The times are past when small minorities could overthrow the government with a surprising, energetic action and put a new one in its place.

That was possible in centralized states, in which the entire political life was concentrated in a capital city that dominated the whole country, in the villages and towns of which there was no trace of political life and of connections between them. Whoever succeeded in paralyzing or winning over the

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military and bureaucracy of the capital could seize control of the government and, if the general situation called for a social revolution, work toward that end. (ch. 6, p. 44)

Today, however, I continued, we have, with the exception of Russia, gone beyond this stage. In a modern great power, a party can gain power through a revolution and stand its ground only when it

... represent[s] the interests of the great majority of the population and [has] its trust. (ch. 6, p. 74)

With those words I rejected the idea of a dictatorship of a minority of the people as early as 1909. For Russia I considered such a dictatorship possible, but not as the means for attaining to socialism, for which Russia is by no means ready.

To this last view, too, there was not the least objection from the ranks of the revolutionary Marxists.

It was merely another way of expressing the same thought when I declared that only states at a high level of industrial development were ready for socialism:

In an industrially highly developed country, like Germany or Britain, it probably possesses even now the strength to gain control of the government, and would probably find that the economic conditions are such as would allow using the government to supplant capitalist enterprises with socially owned and operated ones. (ch. 4, p. 46)

In 1909 this expectation was judged to be very optimistic by the majority of my readers. Since 1918, however, many have easily slipped over to the opposite extreme.

In 1909 I declared that in Germany and Britain, the only thing the proletariat was still lacking in order to conquer political power and to begin to establish socialism was consciousness of its strength. Since then, owing to the Russian and German revolutions, the proletariat has everywhere gained an enormous awareness of its strength, by which it has often allowed itself to be misled into considering the other conditions of socialism – advanced development of industry and maturity of the proletariat – of secondary importance and into believing that wherever there is a socialist party, that party can also immediately conquer political

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power and establish socialism. Where that does not happen, it is due solely to the leaders' cowardice and incompetence.

As far as these elements are concerned, my standpoint is still the same as it was in 1909: the proletariat has now already reached the point where it can conquer political power and use it in the manner envisaged by socialism; but for the time being, only "in an industrially highly developed country, like Germany or Britain."

Then I put Germany first, because I believed that it was nearest to socialism. Today I would have to put Britain first.

The war led to Germany's frightful collapse and hence to the revolution, but it did not improve the conditions for socialism in Germany. Of its three conditions, the war enormously improved only one: the workers' consciousness of their strength. It was strongly detrimental to the other two, however: the material basis of industry and the intellectual and moral maturity of the proletariat.

Before the war, we knew very well that socialism can only arise on the rich material basis created by capitalism. Thus I also stated in the present work:

... if the transformation of Germany into a democratic state succeeds in this manner, that does not yet suffice to help the proletariat to move forward. The German proletariat, which already makes up the great majority of the population, will certainly then be able to control legislation, but this will not avail it much *if the state does not have at its disposal abundant funds, which are indispensable for social reforms.* (ch. 8, p. 110)

That has now often been forgotten. Not a few of us believe that, in order for us to arrive at socialism, capitalist wealth must first be ruined; that socialism will thrive all the better, the less it finds available to be socialized. Their way of thinking is reminiscent of the ingenious youth who thought that the quickest way for him to inherit his rich uncle's legacy was to set fire to the uncle's uninsured factories and to drive him into bankruptcy and to a miserable death from starvation.

The war with its consequences has made Germany exceedingly poor and by that fact alone has slowed the pace of the possible social advances. However, the moral and intellectual retrogression of the population contributed even more to bring about that result.

I would like to discuss this point in more detail.

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The most important condition of socialism is a strong industrial proletariat. Among the laboring classes, the wage-earning working class is the one having the greatest interest in socialist production. It is also the only one among them that is capable of developing, through its class struggles, tight-knit, widespread class organizations, political knowledge of a higher level, and a quite comprehensive sense of community, whereas the other laboring classes, such as the peasants, the artisans, and also the agricultural workers, go beyond the limitations of guilds and of locality only with difficulty.

It was not least of all the strength of the proletarian organizations, the vitality of their political organizations, the highly developed sense of community, that led me to see in Germany and Britain the countries that were already ripe for socialism before the war.

I did not name the United States, although there, too, capitalism had raised the forces of production to the highest level. But in the United States, a tightly organized, homogeneous working class was lacking. Their proletariat is divided into native and immigrant workers; the natives, into whites and Negroes; the immigrants, into numerous nations communicating among themselves with difficulty and having little in common with one another.

The strength of Britain's and Germany's working class was also weakened by internal division. Both here and there, we find a minority of Catholics who feel themselves discriminated against in the state, and who thus occupy a special position also in the labor movement, with the result that they can be brought into the whole movement only with difficulty. Even though the Centrist workers here and the Irish in Britain were at times a very disagreeable hindrance to the development of the proletariat's power, they were not able to noticeably impede the progress of the working class either here or there.

In both countries, the wage-earning working class already made up the great majority of the population. In Britain, where there was no peasantry worth mentioning, even more than in Germany. Here as well as there, the urban proletarians were powerfully organized, politically trained, and familiar with the problems of the state, of the communes, and of the national and international economy, as a result of the class struggles of a century and of their use of democratic institutions gained through hard struggle.

However, the German proletariat stood in the forefront. It had outstripped the British, who had been the vanguard of the workers of all lands until the last quarter of the nineteenth century. It surpassed them by means of the unity and closeness of its organizations. The British trade

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unions were fragmented; the German unions were concentrated in a few powerful federations. The German socialists united themselves in a single mass party; the British socialists succeeded only in establishing a number of diminutive organizations at odds with each other, finally founding, it is true, a large labor party, but one without firm cohesion, without a program, and without explicitly formulated tactics.

Most important, however, the British workers remained completely dependent intellectually on the bourgeois radicalism that made not inconsiderable concessions to them. No such radicalism existed in Germany; there the mass of politically-minded workers – except for those of the Center Party tore themselves free from bourgeois leadership at an early stage. In exchange, they gained the guidance of a socialist theory, that of Marx, which was so superior that it began to influence even bourgeois thinking. The intellectual independence of the masses of German workers was demonstrated best by the enormous development of their daily press, which Britain could not even come close to matching. Only shortly before the war was a daily workers' newspaper established there – just a single one, that never did well and never quite failed.

The German proletariat was the most advanced in the world. Then came the war and the collapse, and hurled us far back. Granted, they brought us the revolution and thus apparently the fulfillment of our most ardent longing.

We had, however, always regarded revolution resulting from war with some anxiety. In 1902 I made the following observations on this subject in my work entitled *The Social Revolution*:

If I speak of war as a means of revolution, that should not be understood to mean that I want war. Its horrors are so terrible that today only military fanatics can still find the sad courage to yearn for a war in cold blood. But even if a revolution were not a means to an end, but an end in itself, for which no price, even the bloodiest, would not be too dear, a war could not be desired as a means of unleashing the revolution. For it is the most irrational means to this end. A hostile invasion causes such horrible devastations, makes such monstrous demands on the state, that it burdens a revolution arising out of it most heavily with tasks that are not proper to the revolution and that temporarily absorb all its resources and energy. Furthermore, a revolution arising out of a war sometimes coincides with a failure of the revolutionary class, when

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the latter is *prematurely summoned by the war to carry out tasks* for which it is still too weak. The war itself can increase this weakness even more just through the sacrifices that it exacts, *as well as through the moral and intellectual degradation* that a war usually causes. Thus, an enormous multiplication of the revolutionary regime's tasks and at the same time a weakening of its forces. (Kautsky, *Die Soziale Revolution* [1902], 3d ed. [Berlin: Vorwärts], p. 58; *The Social Revolution* [Chicago: Charles H. Kerr, 1913], pp. 97-98.)

As early as 1887, Engels gave a grandiose description of the coming world war and its aftermath in his preface to Borkheim's *Mordspatrioten* [Murderous superpatriots]. Among other things, he called attention to the "universal lapse into barbarism, both of the armies and the people, in the wake of acute misery." (Frederick Engels, "Introduction to Sigismund Borkheim's Pamphlet *In Memory of the German Blood-and-Thunder Patriots. 1806-1807*," Marx, Engels, *Collected Works*, 26:451.)

Even such a brief war as that of 1870-71, which called only an inconsiderable fraction of the population to the front, which resulted not in "acute misery," but instead in an era of prosperity, produced a strong growth of criminality. What effect, then, could the world war have in this regard, a war that for four years placed the vast majority of [Germany's] adult male population in conditions that heightened to the utmost brutality, ruthlessness toward the misery of others, selfishness, and dissipation in all classes.

Like the lumpenproletarian, the soldier is, economically speaking, a parasite, accustomed to living at society's expense. The war has introduced the lumpenproletarian's attitude into broad sectors of the working proletariat.

The wage-earning proletariat, which in large part originally came out of the lumpenproletariat, had to work its way out of this morass in a long, tenacious struggle through the last centuries, in order to become capable of carrying out its great historical task. Because of the war, many parts of the wage-earning proletariat were, in their attitude, thrust back into that morass. Criminality, corruption, dissipation in the midst of misery, brutality to the point of bestiality, irresponsible living for the moment, with no concern for later consequences — this complete degeneration of morals and intellect took hold of all sectors of the population, the upper perhaps more than the lower. Capitalism, however, is suffering less from

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this degeneration than socialism, which is impossible without a superior, morally pure proletariat.

Before the war, the German proletariat was certainly capable of establishing socialism. That is my conviction. Even the frightful degradation caused by the war has not been able to take from it all its socialist capabilities. But it has temporarily weakened them.

In Britain, on the other hand, the degrading effects of the war on the proletariat were less pronounced, and its wealth also suffered less. Deprivation did not reach such a high level, and the working class was not exposed in such a high degree to the morally degenerative effects of the business of war. First, because at the outbreak of the war there was as yet no universal compulsory military service in Britain; it did not become effective until quite some time later. Further, because the British armies fought for the greatest part on allied territory, France and Belgium, whereas the German armies fought on enemy territory. There, the soldier lets himself go with regard to the civilian population in a completely different manner than on the soil of his own or of an allied country — except in a civil war.

In addition, the war did not cause so much deprivation and misery in Britain that it completely disrupted the production process, but did so enough to intensify the class antagonisms to the extreme. The war resulted in the British workers' extricating themselves from bourgeois leadership and in their heading ever more consciously toward socialism.

And the British proletarians are joining together in their great labor party ever more firmly and with ever greater unity, while many German workers have lost, in the war and because of the war, their trust in the old labor party and in its views, without finding another firm base. Hence there is division and uncertain wavering, which are pernicious to no class more than to the proletariat, which for its effectiveness depends on the weight and force of its unified mass.

Britain will therefore assume leadership on the road to modern socialism.

Nevertheless, what I wrote in 1909 still remains true even today. Even at the present time, Britain and Germany are the two countries that have achieved the greatest degree of readiness for socialism. Only the relationship between the two has changed: Britain now stands at the fore. But after Britain, no other country is so close to socialism as Germany.

That is to say, to modern socialism, which means the liberation of the proletariat from any and all tutelage and servitude. We have always rejected state socialism, which replaces servitude to capital with servitude to the state.

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It is not surprising that, under certain circumstances, autocracy, particularly military autocracy, is readier to nationalize means of production or transportation than many democracies. Bismarck's militarist Prussia nationalized its railways, in contrast to democratic Britain, France, and the United States. We have always refused, however, to see this nationalization as socialism, as it is understood by the modern proletariat.

And for that reason, we can also not recognize the Bolshevik state economy as socialism in this sense. In its beginnings syndicalist-anarchist (in practice, not in theory), it became, through the force of circumstances, a gigantic system of barracks socialism.

No other kind of socialism is yet permitted by Russia's degree of development.

We stand by our opinion: Britain and Germany are the countries in which we will first arrive at a modern socialism, one that satisfies and liberates the proletariat. Even now, they possess the requisite elements for attaining to socialism. True, two factors of socialism have been temporarily weakened in Germany by the war: its capitalist wealth and the unity and moral superiority of its proletariat. But the third requisite factor, the proletariat's awareness of its strength, has grown enormously. If it recovers its former unity, then socialism's march to victory in Germany will advance irresistibly.

* * *

I believe that the preceding discussion sufficiently shows that the standpoint I now hold is completely identical with that of revolutionary Marxism before the war; that I have revised nothing and that there is nothing I have to revise. The revolution did not overturn the standpoint I held before the war, but confirmed it.

In one point, though, I appear to have changed. I must still discuss it before I conclude, as it concerns the central problem of practical politics at the present time: the question of the participation of socialists in a coalition government.

I have frequently been reproached with my supposed change in this point in the Independent [Independent Social-Democratic] and Communist press. The mere fact that I had given up an opinion would, of course, of itself not prove anything against me, assuming that I gave it up for good reasons. In the course of their lives, Engels and Marx recognized that a good many of their earlier views were untenable and also candidly admitted it. The esteem in which they were held was not thereby diminished. Thus, I, too, would calmly admit it if I had changed my

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opinion about coalitions. It would certainly not have happened without reasons that appeared plausible to me.

But, of course, one only wants to take responsibility for changes that one has really made. With regard to the coalitions, there is, however, no change of the standpoint I hold on principle, but rather only of the historical character of coalitions and the situations in which they appear. Given this latter change, my assessment of coalitions also had to change, if it were not to amount to a mindless template, applied indiscriminately under all circumstances.

In the present work, I reject repeatedly and very decidedly any coalition policy. Most decidedly in chapter 1, where I say, among other things:

A proletarian party in a bourgeois coalition government will always become complicitous in the actions aimed at repressing the proletariat. These actions will gain for the party the proletariat's disrespect, while it remains continuously constrained by the mistrust of its bourgeois brothers-in-alliance and is thereby constantly prevented from taking any beneficial action. No regime of this kind can strengthen the proletariat – no bourgeois party will lend itself to that. Such a government can only compromise a proletarian party, only confuse and split the proletariat. (ch. 1, p. 8)

In contrast, I have very recently acknowledged that there can be exigencies that make the participation of socialists in a coalition government indispensable.

These two positions are supposed to be in unbridgeable contradiction with each other. In fact, I had already provided the bridge exactly two decades ago, in my Paris resolution, in which I described the "entry of an individual socialist into a bourgeois ministry" as a "dangerous experiment" that was not to be sought and was permitted only as a "temporary expedient, adopted in exceptional cases under the force of circumstances."

At that time, in 1900, as in 1909 in my *Road to Power* and now in my article published in the Vienna *Arbeiterzeitung* on 18 June 1920, and entitled "Klassenkampf and Koalition" [Class struggle and coalition], I rejected any coalition government as a normal and long-lasting means for exercising the proletariat's political power. Even in 1900, however, I

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foresaw constraining circumstances that could nevertheless make a coalition necessary as the smaller evil, in order to avoid a greater one.

That alone sufficed to distinguish me from those who rejected any participation in a coalition government, no matter what the circumstances. As early as 1900, I declared that the problem was "a question of tactics and not of principle."

And this view was shared by my friends among the revolutionary Marxists. When the great battle between the partisans and the opponents of socialist ministerialism was fought out at the 1904 International Congress in Amsterdam, it did not occur to even the most radical of the Marxists in attendance to declare that the partisans of ministerialism had ceased to be socialists and ought to be expelled from the International. This view is entirely new. Before the war, everyone of us would have categorically rejected it.

The Amsterdam congress adopted the resolution of the 1903 Dresden party congress, which stated:

... that the Social Democratic Party, in accordance with the Kautsky resolution of the 1900 international congress of socialists in Paris cannot strive for a share of governmental power in bourgeois society.

The verb "strive for" was chosen advisedly. In the French translation, it was rendered with "accept" (*accepter* instead of *rechercher*). In Amsterdam I explicitly pointed out that the German delegation had to reject the greater stringency of the translation in comparison with the meaning of the original text. We could not condemn every entry of a socialist into a bourgeois cabinet.

However, the (Paris) resolution says explicitly that such an acceptance of office is a sacrifice that the Social Democratic Party makes, a source of embarrassments and dangers, which sometimes cannot be avoided, but is never to be striven for. (Protokoll des Amsterdamer Kongresses, p. 60)

Jaurès was the great champion of the idea that the participation of a socialist in a bourgeois government was the beginning, for which one must strive, of the proletariat's conquest of political power. This view was perhaps the most pronounced characteristic of the political activity engaged in by Jaurès in our party. He never abandoned this idea, even

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when, after 1905, he forwent in practice the policy of coalition under the pressure of events.

In 1915 Rappoport published a biography of Jaurès in which an entire chapter is devoted to the coalition policy. In that biography Jaurès is apotheosized; however, Rappoport is now in the extreme left wing of the French Social Democratic Party and has declared a social traitor not only anyone who pursues a policy such as was championed by the Jaurès whom he glorified, but even anyone who is willing to tolerate such Judases in the socialist party.

The French Social Democratic Party has now withdrawn from the Second International because it cannot possibly remain together with people who are guilty of a coalition policy and have thereby ceased to be socialists. That does not prevent them from continuing to practice the cult of the greatest and most energetic representative of the coalition policy, Jaurès. Renaudel was correct to declare (in *L'Humanité*, 28 July 1920) that the French socialists now have to choose between Lenin and Jaurès. It is nonsense, he said, to argue for the ideas of both of them at the same time.

Before the war revolutionary Marxism steered clear of such contradictions. We fought against Jaurès's coalition policy, but we never refused to collaborate with him in the International.

We demanded that coalitions not be sought. When a socialist, with the approval of his party, took a post in a bourgeois cabinet, we did not immediately declare that this party had thereby ceased to be socialist; rather we investigated whether the political situation compelled the taking of that step. And through these enquiries, I found that, indeed, up to the revolution, nowhere had the entry of a socialist into a bourgeois cabinet been justified. And I continue to be convinced that I was right in that assessment.

In *The Road to Power*, I examined the question whether it was possible to avoid the revolution by means of a coalition government:

... they believe it possible that the proletariat will attain to political power without a revolution, that is, without a considerable shift of political power in the state, simply through a clever tactic of co-operating with the bourgeois parties that are closest to the proletariat. With these parties, they would form a coalition government, a feat that none of the participating parties would be able to accomplish by itself. (ch. 1, p. 6)

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It was principally this aspect of coalition government that I had in mind when I examined its prospects. I came to the conclusion that, until the revolution, every bourgeois-socialist government must come to grief, and that none would be able to render the proletarian revolution superfluous.

I consider this view correct even at the present time. The events have justified it.

Now, however, the revolution has broken out, and therefore the question of a coalition government has acquired an entirely new appearance. I have already pointed out that two of the three pre-conditions of socialism have been temporarily harmed by the war: capitalist wealth and the high intellectual and moral development of the proletariat, along with its unity that is, its political maturity. The third of those pre-conditions, however, was enormously strengthened: the proletariat's awareness of its strength.

In civilized Europe, the whole population, of all classes and regions, is already participating in political life in the most active fashion, and no autocracy is possible there anymore, neither that of a party nor that of a bureaucracy and its heads. Now, in many parts of this civilized Europe, the mighty advance of the proletariat that we are now experiencing arose out of the collapse of the old authorities, which brought a significant expansion of democratic rights in its train. In these countries, the proletariat can come to power only on the basis of democracy, not through the replacement by a socialist party of the old dynastic autocracy with a new one buttressed by a new militarism and a new bureaucracy.

Under these conditions, the socialist parties had gained a dominant position in most of those countries through the revolution, but nowhere had they yet won over the majority of the population. No socialist party has yet reached the point where it, alone and by its own strength, could have formed an enduring government. Almost everywhere, though, the socialists are strong enough so that it is no longer possible, within the framework of democracy, to govern against their opposition.

This situation has led to bourgeois-socialist coalition governments in various countries. But they are of a completely different kind than those I had in mind in 1909 in my *Road to Power*. Then, the coalition cabinets originated from the plight of a ruling bourgeois party that was threatened by reactionary elements and for its rescue needed proletarian assistance. To this end, a socialist was taken into the government. The prime minister belonged to a bourgeois party. He was the one who selected his ministers. In every case it was only a single socialist whom he took into the cabinet. The socialist was not given a position of power and had no influence on

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the government's policies overall. Along with the *appearance* of power, he was given the *responsibility* for it, without any real means of exercising it. He did not serve to keep the government dependent on the proletariat, but instead served the opposite end: ensuring the proletariat's obedience to the government. He was a tool of the bourgeois government within the proletariat, not an instrument of the proletariat within the bourgeois government.

Present-day bourgeois-socialist coalition governments could assume a completely different form.

They do not arise from the need of a ruling bourgeois party to keep itself at the helm, but out of the total collapse of those in power, thus out of the revolution, which at first brings the proletariat to power, or rather a socialist party. For, in point of fact, states are governed not by classes, but by parties representing certain class interests. If this socialist party does not have the majority of the people behind it, and if the people are too advanced politically to acquiesce in the autocracy of a minority, then only three possibilities remain to a purely socialist government: either the attempt to hold its own against the majority of the population in a civil war; or the *formation of a coalition* with a bourgeois party that for this or that reason prefers securing the state's newly established framework to civil war, or abdication without a fight when faced with the counterrevolution.

Whoever considers this situation will admit that, no matter what objections one might make to a coalition government, among the possibilities from which one has to choose, it is by far the smallest evil. That is so all the more inasmuch as a coalition cabinet originating from the revolution is composed very differently than the pre-revolutionary ones were.

In the coalitions of the revolutionary period, the leadership is in the hands of the socialists. They are represented in the governments not merely by a single member having a post of minor importance, but by several members who hold the most important positions of power: prime minister, minister of foreign affairs, minister of internal affairs, minister of war.

Granted, even such a coalition cabinet can still not pursue clearly socialist policies. It remains a poor stopgap measure full of strong internal contradictions, which can be temporarily bridged over only with difficulty. Great deeds cannot be expected from such a government, and it has no prospect of long enduring. But what I wrote in 1909 about the coalition governments possible at that time, does not need to be true of them now:

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A proletarian party in a bourgeois coalition government will always become complicitous in the actions aimed at repressing the proletariat. These actions will gain for the party the proletariat's disrespect. (ch. 1, p. 8)

That was true then; it is no longer true today. The socialist parties in coalition governments are now strong enough to prevent such actions, and just this function would be one of their most important tasks in, and the best justification of such a government.

Even now, a coalition government will seldom be able to do much for the proletariat that is positive. But it will accomplish a great deal if it only prevents the proletariat's loss of what it has gained through the revolution, and if it safeguards for it the advantageous use of these gains so that it can continue to work successfully on strengthening itself and on making further progress in winning over the majority of the population and thereby gaining complete political power.

If a coalition government can do that, then it is more than merely justified. Then it can become an urgent necessity, and he sins grievously against the proletariat who prevents a coalition government of this kind and thereby delivers up the country in question to civil war or the counterrevolution.

No coalition government lasts a long time. However, as long as we are still in the revolutionary stage, as long as the revolution's gains have not yet been made secure, as long as the transfer of the government to the bourgeois parties conjures up the danger of a counterrevolution and the demise of the democratic republic, then the Social Democratic Party may not categorically reject the idea of participating in a bourgeois coalition government.

If this viewpoint is seen as an about-face on my part, then I call attention to the fact that, as early as 1900, I said that the question of coalition governments was not a matter of principle, but of tactics, a question to be answered differently, depending on different conditions. We have also seen, however, that the present-day coalition governments are totally different from those that were possible in 1909.

At most, I could be criticized for not already foreseeing in 1909 this change in the character of coalition governments. I have often pointed out, however, that the only thing that can be ascertained about the future with some degree of certainty, given the present state of science, are the directions of development. With regard to the forms that the developments assume, the same certainty of knowledge is not yet

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possible. I am content if in *The Road to Power*, I succeeded in correctly foreseeing the direction of the development from 1909 to the present.

No matter what one might think about the purely personal question whether in 1909 I demonstrated sufficient foresight, much more important and of decisive significance for the matter under discussion is the question whether the arguments against a coalition policy in 1909, which I continue to regard as compelling for that time, are still valid under present conditions for the more recent coalition policy. To this question I respond with an emphatic "no."

Of course, that is not to say that henceforth every kind of coalition policy is justified, or that it is even a blessing. The best designed policy can be ruined in its implementation. The class antagonisms, which before the war made bourgeois-socialist coalitions such a dangerous experiment, have lost nothing of their intensity. The situation has changed to the extent that, owing to the strength of the working class and its consciousness of that strength, the coalition policy no longer "*always*," as previously, *necessarily* leads to a proletarian party's becoming "complicitous in the actions aimed at repressing the proletariat." But it *can* still lead to that result, and when it does, then, of course, it deserves our emphatic condemnation.

The difference between then and now is that the complicity in the bourgeois policy of repression prior to the revolution lay in the nature of things, so that even the greatest strength of character, expert knowledge, and intelligence on the part of the socialist ministers could not alter it. Whereas today this complicity, when it arises, is, as a rule, to be ascribed to a personal insufficiency of the socialist ministers. Socialists who let themselves be intimidated, duped, and confused by their bourgeois colleagues or by old generals and privy counselors, certainly have no business being in a coalition government. However, it would be quite wrong to brand in advance every coalition policy as an abandonment of all socialist principles just because it presupposes strength of character, intelligence, and expert knowledge on the part of the socialists.

If I have advanced here the view that, in the present stage of the revolution, a policy of socialist-bourgeois coalition is at times unavoidable, that does not at all mean that I am defending the policy of this kind that we have had in Germany.

It was built on a basis that was completely untenable from the start, if only because it meant the coalition of a socialist party with bourgeois parties in opposition to another socialist party.

The split in the Social Democratic Party has made any reasonable coalition policy impossible. Not just such a policy, however. This split has

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condemned any kind of socialist policy to sterility and failure in advance. Even if the diametric opposite of the coalition policy, namely the dictatorship of workers' councils, were possible under present conditions in Germany, it would come to grief if only because in the workers' councils, the two great socialist parties would counterbalance and thus paralyze each other.

As long as the split in the Party lasts, no successful socialist political activity can be expected in Germany. However, if the split is overcome, then the united Party can pursue whatever tactics it will, and if only these tactics are somewhat reasonable, they will in any case advance the German proletariat further than will the present state of affairs.

If the Social Democratic Party is united, then its appeal will be so enormously increased that it can surely be expected that in new elections, it will receive the majority of votes and thereby make a wholly socialist government possible.

Should that not happen, and should the united Party abandon the field to the bourgeois parties, as indeed the two socialist parties are now doing, it would have at its disposal such moral and political strength that the great dangers accompanying such a situation would most likely be diminished thereby.

A united socialist party could, however, also form a coalition with a bourgeois party without having to fear that, in doing so, it was playing the game of the proletariat's opponents. It would demonstrate such strength, maintain such preponderance, and find so many strict monitoring organs in its own ranks that the coalition could never subserve the repression of the proletariat, but only its protection and advancement, as well as the consolidation of the democratic republic and making it into an instrument that would immediately, and with all its might, promote the cause of socialist progress, as soon as the majority of the population had been won over to it.

As long as it is divided, the German proletariat remains condemned to impotence and to failure in all the efforts of both its left and its right wing. If it overcomes its division, there is no power in Germany that can resist it.

The unification of the two great socialist parties – for the German proletariat that is now the true

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1

The Conquest of Political Power

Friend and foe of the Social Democratic Party are agreed that it is a revolutionary party. Unfortunately, though, the term "revolution" has quite a few meanings, and so the views on the revolutionary character of our party are widely divergent. Not a few of our opponents want to understand by revolution nothing other than anarchy, bloodshed, pillaging, and arson. On the other hand, there are party members to whom the social revolution toward which we are headed appears merely as a quite gradual, hardly noticeable, although ultimately profound change of social conditions, like the change brought about by the steam engine.

This much is certain: the Social Democratic Party, as the champion of the proletariat's class interests, is a revolutionary party, because it is impossible to help the proletariat to attain to a satisfying existence in capitalist society, because its liberation requires supplanting private property in the capitalist means of production and power with social ownership and the replacement of private production with social production. The proletariat can find satisfaction only in a social order that is profoundly different from the existing one.

However, the Social Democratic Party is revolutionary in yet another sense, since it recognizes that the government is an instrument of class rule, indeed, its mightiest instrument, and that the social revolution for which the proletariat is striving cannot be carried out as long as it has not conquered political power.

This conviction, the reasons for which Marx and Engels give in the *Communist Manifesto*, distinguishes the Social Democratic Party from the so-called Utopian socialists, such as, for example, the followers of Owen and Fourier in the first half of the last century, but also from those of Proudhon, who either attached little importance to political struggle or even rejected it and believed they could carry out the economic transformation [of society] in the interest of the proletariat by means of purely economic measures, without changing the government and without intervention by the government. In their belief in the necessity of conquering political power, Marx and Engels were in agreement with Blanqui. But, whereas the latter believed that the government could be conquered by means of a conspiracy, through a coup d'état by a rather small minority, and made to serve the interests of the proletariat, Marx

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and Engels recognized that revolutions cannot be made as one wishes, but that they occur of necessity under certain conditions and remain impossible as long as these conditions, which are formed only gradually, do not exist. Only when the capitalist mode of production has reached a high level of development, they explained, does there exist the economic possibility of transforming, by means of the government, capitalist ownership of the means of production into social ownership. On the other hand, the possibility of conquering and keeping a firm grip on the government arises for the proletariat only when it has grown enormous in size and is economically indispensable, is in large part solidly organized, and has gained understanding of its situation as a class and of the nature of the state and society.

These conditions, say Marx and Engels, are being created to an ever greater extent by the development of the capitalist mode of production and the resulting class struggles between capitalists and workers. Just as the continuous expansion of capitalism proceeds necessarily and irresistibly, so too is the counteraction that will finally occur against this expansion, the proletarian revolution, inevitable and irresistible.

This revolution is irresistible because it is inevitable that the growing proletariat will defend itself against capitalist exploitation, that it will organize itself in trade unions and co-operatives, as well as politically, and that it will seek to achieve better working and living conditions and greater political influence. The proletariat is engaging in these forms of activity everywhere, whether its thinking is socialist or not. It is the task of the Social Democratic Party to integrate all the proletariat's different counteractions against its exploitation into a purposeful and unified action that culminates in the great final struggles to conquer political power.

This view, whose foundations were laid in the *Communist Manifesto*, has today been accepted by the socialist movements of all countries. The entire international socialism of our time is based on it.

Yet it was not able to triumph without meeting with doubters and critics within the Social Democratic Party itself.

The development of events did in fact follow the direction predicted by Marx and Engels. And, aside from the expansion of capitalism and consequently of the proletarian class struggle, the victorious advance of international socialism is due above all to the deep understanding of the conditions and the goals of this struggle provided by Marx and Engels.

They were, however, mistaken in one point: *they expected the revolution to occur too soon ...*

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Thus they said in the *Communist Manifesto* (written at the end of 1847):

The Communists turn their attention chiefly to Germany, because that country is on the eve of a bourgeois revolution that is bound to be carried out under more advanced conditions of European civilisation and with a much more developed proletariat than that of England was in the seventeenth, and of France in the eighteenth century, and because the bourgeois revolution in Germany can therefore only be *the prelude to an immediately following proletarian revolution*. (Kautsky's italics)

The *Manifesto* was right to expect the German revolution. But its authors deceived themselves when they believed that it would be the prelude to a proletarian revolution that would immediately follow.

Another prediction by Engels is more recent. He published it in 1885, in his introduction to the second edition of Marx's pamphlet on the Cologne Communists' trial. There he said that the next European upheaval was "now soon due (the European revolutions, 1815, 1830, 1848-52, and 1870, have occurred at intervals of fifteen to eighteen years in our century)" (Engels, "On the History of the Communist League," in Karl Marx, Friedrich Engels, *Collected Works* [New York: International Publishers, 1990, 26:327).

This expectation, too, was not fulfilled, and so far the revolution that was expected then has not taken place.

Why is that so? Was Marx's method, on which the expectations were based, wrong? Not at all. But one factor in the calculation was incorrect; a much too great magnitude was ascribed to it. As early as ten years ago, I wrote the following about this matter: "Both times, the revolutionary, oppositional strength of the *bourgeoisie* was overestimated" (Kautsky, "Bernstein and die Dialektik," *Die Neue Zeit*, 17/2 [1899]: 45).

In 1847, Marx and Engels expected a revolution of enormous extent in Germany, a revolution similar to the great French catastrophe that began in 1789. Instead, there was only a miserable uprising that immediately frightened almost the whole bourgeoisie back under the wings of the governments. As a result, these again became strong, while any rapid development of the proletariat was forestalled. The bourgeoisie then left it up to the individual governments to continue the revolution for it, to the extent that it still had need of the revolution. Bismarck, in

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particular, was the great revolutionary who unified Germany, at least partly, toppled German princes from their thrones, promoted the unification of Italy and the dethroning of the Pope, defeated the empire in France and brought about the establishment of the republic there.

It was in these forms that the German bourgeois revolution proceeded, whose imminent beginning Marx and Engels had prophesied in 1847, and which did not end until 1870.

Nevertheless, even in 1885 Engels was still expecting an "upheaval" and assumed that "the petty-bourgeois democracy is even now the party which must certainly be the first to take the helm in Germany [... on the occasion of the next European upheaval] (Marx, Engels, *Collected Works*, 26: 326-27).

This time, too, Engels prophesied correctly when he foresaw a "shaking of political foundations." But again he miscalculated when he expected something from the petty-bourgeois democrats. They failed utterly when Bismarck's regime collapsed. The chancellor's fall was thereby reduced to a dynastic affair, without any revolutionary consequence.

It is becoming ever clearer that a revolution is still possible only as a *proletarian* revolution; that it is impossible as long as the organized proletariat is not a power that is great and solidly united enough to carry along with itself, under favorable conditions, the majority of the nation. If it is true, on the one hand, that only the proletariat is a revolutionary class in the nation, then, on the other hand, it follows that any collapse of the existing regime, be it moral, financial, or military in nature, will imply the bankruptcy of all the bourgeois parties, who have all become responsible for this regime. It follows also that the only regime that can succeed the existing one in such a case is a *proletarian* one.

Not all members of the Social Democratic Party draw these conclusions, however. If the revolution that has already been expected a number of times still has not arrived, they do not by any means conclude that the conditions and forms of the coming revolution have been shaped differently by the economic development than has been assumed on the basis of what has been learned from the bourgeois revolutions that have occurred up to now. Instead, they conclude that, in the altered circumstances, a revolution is not to be expected at all, is not necessary, and, indeed, would be harmful.

On the one hand, they assume that the further extension of what has already been achieved – worker-protection laws, trade unions, cooperatives – suffice to force the capitalist class out of one position after the other and imperceptibly to expropriate it, without a political

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revolution, without changing the nature of the government. This theory of gradually growing economically into the state of the future is a modernization of the old, anti-political utopianism and Proudhonism.

On the other hand, however, they believe it possible that the proletariat will attain to political power without a revolution, that is, without a considerable shift of political power in the state, simply through a clever tactic of co-operating with the bourgeois parties that are closest to the proletariat. With these parties, they would form a coalition government, a feat that none of the participating parties would be able to accomplish by itself.

In this way, maintain those who hold this view, it is possible to avoid the revolution, which is a completely obsolete, barbarian means that has no place in our enlightened century of democracy, ethics, and love of humanity.

If they gained widespread acceptance, these views would knock the entire social-democratic tactics founded by Marx and Engels into a cocked hat. They are incompatible with the latter. Of course, that is no reason for assuming in advance that they are wrong; but it is certainly understandable that everyone who has recognized that they are wrong after subjecting them to careful examination should vigorously oppose them. For it is not a matter here of unimportant opinions, but of the weal and woe of the militant proletariat.

However, it is all too easy to get onto the wrong track when discussing these differences of opinion if the controversial views are not clearly delineated.

For that reason I will say again here, as I have already said so often, that it is not a question of whether or not worker-protection laws and other laws that benefit the proletariat are necessary and useful, or whether or not trade unions and co-operatives are necessary and useful. On this question there is only one opinion among us. What is disputed is solely the view that the exploiting classes, which have control of the government, could permit a development of these factors that would amount to liberation from the pressure of capitalism, without first having put up, with all its instruments of power, such resistance that it could be overcome only through a decisive struggle.

Further, it is not a question of whether or not we should exploit the disagreements among the bourgeois parties to the benefit of the proletariat. Not without reason did Marx and Engels always fight against the phrase "the reactionary mass" because it concealed too much the antagonisms that exist between the different factions of the propertied classes, and that have sometimes been very important for the

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advancement of the proletariat. It owed both the worker-protection laws and the broadening of political rights in largest part to such antagonisms.

What is being disputed is only the possibility that a proletarian party together with bourgeois parties can form a government or a governing party in a normal fashion without thereby entangling itself in insurmountable contradictions on which it must founder. Everywhere the government is an organ of class rule. The class antagonism between the proletariat and the propertied classes is, however, so enormous that the proletariat can never govern jointly with a propertied class. The propertied class will continuously demand, and in its own interest will have to demand, that the government continue to repress the proletariat. In contrast, the proletariat will always demand from a government in which its own party is participating that the government stand by it in its struggles against the capitalists. On the antagonism of these interests every proletarian-bourgeois coalition government must come to grief.

A proletarian party in a bourgeois coalition government will always become complicitous in the actions aimed at repressing the proletariat. These actions will gain for the party the proletariat's disrespect, while it remains continuously constrained by the mistrust of its bourgeois brothers-in-alliance and is thereby constantly prevented from taking any beneficial action. No regime of this kind can strengthen the proletariat — no bourgeois party will lend itself to that. Such a government can only compromise a proletarian party, only confuse and split the proletariat.

But the very factor that since 1848 has postponed the revolution again and again, the political degeneration of the bourgeois democrats, is what really precludes a profitable cooperation with them for the purpose of gaining and jointly exercising political power.

As much as Marx and Engels were in favor of using the disagreements between the bourgeois parties to further proletarian aims, as much as they fought against the phrase "reactionary mass," they nonetheless coined the phrase "*dictatorship of the proletariat*," which Engels was still advocating in 1891, shortly before his death. [Engels's introduction to Marx, *The Civil War in France*, in Marx, Engels, *Collected Works*, 27:191] This phrase implies that exclusive political rule of the proletariat is the only form in which it would be able to wield political power.

However, if a bourgeois-proletarian coalition government is not possible as a means of developing proletarian power, and if the advance of social reforms and of the proletariat's economic organizations faces limits under the presently existing relations of power, there is then not the

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least ground for concluding from the fact that the political revolution has not yet occurred, that such revolutions took place only in the past, that there will be no more in the future.

Other doubters about the revolution are not so absolutely certain. They consider it possible that a revolution will occur again, but if it happens, then it will take place in the unforeseeably distant future. For at least one generation, they believe, a revolution is entirely impossible; it is irrelevant to our practical politics. In the next decades, we will just have to adapt ourselves to the tactics of peaceful growth into the revolution and of proletarian-bourgeois coalition politics.

And yet facts are just now appearing that must lead us more than ever to declare that this view is mistaken.

The Prophecy of the Revolution

To discredit Marxists' expectations of a coming revolution, the criticism is frequently made of us that we love to make prophecies, but prove to be bad prophets.

We have already seen the reasons why the proletarian revolution expected by Marx and Engels has not yet occurred. If, however, these disappointed expectations are left aside, then it is astonishing, not that not everything they hoped for came to pass, but that so many of their predictions have been fulfilled.

We have already seen, for example, that in November 1847 the *Communist Manifesto* announced the coming revolution of 1848. That happened at the same time that Proudhon proved that the era of revolutions was forever past.

Marx was the first socialist to point out the importance of trade unions for the proletariat's class struggle. He did so in his polemic against Proudhon, *The Poverty of Philosophy* (1846). In his preparatory writings for *Capital* in the 1860s, he already foresaw the present-day system of joint-stock ownership and of cartels. During the war of 1870-71, he prophesied that henceforth the socialist movement's center of activity would shift from France to Germany. In January 1873 he prophesied the crisis that began a few months later, etc.

It is the same with regard to Engels.

And even when they were wrong, the mistake contained a very important kernel of truth. Recall what was said earlier about Engels's expectation, stated in 1885, that in the next years a political convulsion would occur.

It is, I think, appropriate to confront here a legend that is threatening to take root. In his *Arbeiterfrage* [The worker question], the fifth edition of which has just appeared [Berlin, 1908], the Berlin professor H. Herkner writes in his report on the 1899 Party congress in Hannover:

In the heat of battle, Kautsky let himself be carried away to the point of branding straight-out as idiocy the hope for a catastrophe that would soon occur and would fulfill

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all wishes, thus attacking such a hope much more sharply than Bernstein himself had done. If Engels had really prophesied that the great bang would happen in 1898 (said Kautsky), then he would not have been the great thinker that he was; he would have been such an idiot that not a single constituency would have elected him to be its delegate at the Party congress. Engels only meant that in 1898 the present-day political system in Prussia could perhaps collapse.

We can leave aside the question of what Engels assumed. However, Bebel's remark at the 1891 Party congress in Erfurt, that only a few members of this congress would not see the attainment even of the final goals, does not permit any saving interpretation. To use Kautsky's expression of 1899, they were idiotic. In this intermezzo, the change that had taken place even in the minds of the devoted admirers of the old tactics was expressed with a clarity that left nothing to be desired. (p. 379)

Unfortunately, the esteemed professor's clarity leaves very much to be desired. Not with a single word did I characterize "the hope for a catastrophe that would soon occur and would fulfill all wishes(!)" as idiocy, for the simple reason that such a catastrophe was not being discussed. I would, though, have been entirely justified in also calling an idiocy the hope for a catastrophe *that would fulfill all wishes*. I chose the term "idiocy" for the belief that Engels had set a *certain date* for the outbreak of the revolution, namely the year 1898. A prophecy of that kind did, indeed, seem idiotic to me. But Engels was never guilty of it. And just as little was Bebel. Even at the Erfurt Party congress in 1891, he did not set a definite year for the coming of the revolution.

Already there, his "prophecies" had been ridiculed a little. His reply was:

One may laugh and mock at making prophecies; thinking men cannot manage without them. Today's cool, pessimistic moderation was still alien to Vollmar a few years ago. In 1844, Engels, whom he attacked, predicted quite correctly the revolution of 1848. And has not that which Marx and Engels predicted at the time of the Commune's uprising about the future constellation of

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things in Europe in the well-known address to the general council of the International Working Men's Association been realized right down to the dot on the i ? (Very true!) Liebknecht, who also made fun of me a little, prophesied a lot himself. (Laughter) Like me, he predicted in the Reichstag in 1870 what today has completely come to pass. Read his and my speeches of 1870-1871, and you will find that confirmed. But here comes Vollmar and cries: Stop talking about these old stories and give up making prophecies. However, he himself prophesies, too. The difference between him and me is only this: he possesses the most wonderful optimism with respect to our opponents, but the most frightful pessimism with regard to the efforts our Party is engaging in as a matter of principle and to the future of those efforts. (*Protokoll über die Verhandlungen des Parteitag der Sozialdemokratischen Partei Deutschlands, abgehalten zu Erfurt vom 14. bis 20. Oktober 1891* [Proceedings of the congress of the German Social Democratic Party, held in Erfurt from 14-20 October 1891] [Berlin: Vorwärts, 1891] , 283)

One of Bebel's most important prophecies, which was fulfilled, is the one he made in 1873 that the Center would soon go from sixty seats in the Reichstag to one hundred and that Bismarck's *Kulturkampf* would come to a wretched end and contribute to Bismarck's downfall.

Recently, I was done the honor of being placed in the rank of these "prophets." I could not be in better company.

The criticism was made of me that what I had said about the Russian revolution in my series of articles in *Die Neue Zeit*, entitled "Allerhand Revolutionäres" [All kinds of revolutionary things], and in the preface to my *Ethics*, had been thoroughly refuted by historical experience. Is that true?

In the preface to *Ethics*, I wrote:

We are approaching a time when, who knows for how long, for every Social Democrat undisturbed work will be impossible, when our work will be a continual struggle.... At this very time the myrmidons of the Czar are zealously at work to rival the deeds of the Albas and Tillys during the religious struggles of the sixteenth and

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seventeenth centuries not in military achievements, but in brutal murder and arson. The west European champions of culture and order and other sacred values of humanity greet this with enthusiasm as the restoration of legality. But just as little as the mercenaries of the Habsburgs succeeded, despite temporary successes, in conquering North Germany and Holland for Catholicism, will the Cossacks of the Romanoffs succeed in restoring the rule of absolutism. It has sufficient strength remaining to lay its country waste, but no longer has strength to rule it.

In any case, the Russian Revolution is far from over — it is not likely to end as long as the peasants of Russia are not satisfied. The longer it lasts, the greater will be the agitation of the proletarian masses in Western Europe, the closer the danger of financial catastrophes, the more probable that in Western Europe, too, a period of sharp class struggles would begin. (Kautsky, *Ethik und Materialistische Geschichtsauffassung* [1906] [Bonn: J. H. W. Dietz Nachf., 1973], vii-viii. *Ethics and the Materialist Conception of History*. Chicago: Charles H. Kerr & Co., 1914, 4th ed., revised. Trans. by John B. Askew, pp. 5-7)

What is it about these words, written in January 1906, that I should be ashamed of? Is it, perhaps, believed that Russia has already acquired the basis for developing further calmly and lawfully? And, since I wrote the lines quoted above, has not the whole world in fact entered into a state of the greatest unrest?

And now for my "failed prophecy" in the article "Allerhand Revolutionäres." I was then polemicizing against Lusnia (Michael Lusnia, "Unbewaffnete Revolution?" [Unarmed revolution?], *Die Neue Zeit*, 22/1 [1904]: 559-67), who had declared it impossible that a war for Korea would lead to a revolution in Russia, and was of the opinion that it was an overestimation when I said that the Russian workers were a much more real political factor than the British workers. I answered him in the beginning of February 1904, at the start of the Russo-Japanese War:

There is no doubt that Russia's economic development is far behind that of Germany or England, and that its proletariat is much weaker and more undeveloped by far

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than, say, the German or British proletariat. But everything is relative, even the revolutionary strength of a class. (Kautsky, "Allerhand Revolutionäres" *Die Neue Zeit* 22/1[1904]: 623-24).

I then showed the reasons why the Russian proletariat possessed at that time an extraordinary revolutionary strength, and went on to explain:

The struggle will be decided to absolutism's disadvantage all the more speedily, the more vigorously Western Europe denies it its help. To work toward this end, to discredit czarism to the greatest extent possible is today one of the most important tasks of international social democracy....

Despite all his valuable friendships in Western Europe, the difficulties of the autocrat of all Russians are worsening visibly. The war with Japan can hasten mightily the victory of the revolution in Russia.... What happened after the Russo-Turkish War would repeat itself, but this time on a greater scale: a mighty flaring up of the revolutionary movement. (*Ibid.*, 624)

Having given the reasons for this, I continued:

A revolution in Russia could not, for the present, establish a socialist regime. The country's economic conditions are too immature for that. Initially, it would be able only to bring into being a democratic regime, behind which, however, a strong and impetuous proletariat would stand, pressing forward. Through its efforts, this proletariat would be able to achieve considerable concessions.

Such a regime would of necessity exert a powerful influence on the countries neighboring on Russia. First, through invigoration and encouragement of the proletarian movements there, which would thereby receive the strongest impetus to undertake themselves an assault on the political obstacles to true democracy. In Prussia, that would mean an assault, first of all, on the three-class system of suffrage. Second, through the unleashing of the most diverse national questions of Eastern Europe. (*Ibid.*, 625)

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I wrote that in February 1904. In October 1905 the Russian revolution had become a reality and the proletariat its vanguard, and the effects on the adjacent countries began immediately. In Austria, the suffrage struggle gained an irresistible momentum and soon achieved victory. Hungary came almost to the point of actual insurrection. The German Social Democratic Party accepted the general strike and threw itself with all its might into the suffrage struggle, especially in Prussia. In January 1908 this struggle led to demonstrations in the streets, the likes of which Berlin had not seen since 1848. And in 1907 there came the surprising "Hottentot elections" and the complete collapse of German democracy [i.e., of liberal democrats]. If, however, I had also expected the unleashing of the national movements of Eastern Europe, these expectations were vastly exceeded by the rapid awakening of the entire Orient, in China, India, Egypt, Morocco, Persia, and Turkey, which has already resulted in victorious revolutionary uprisings in the last two countries.

This has been accompanied by a continuous heightening of international antagonisms, which have already twice brought Europe close to war, first because of Morocco, second because of Turkey.

If ever a "prophecy of the future," should one want to use that expression, has been fulfilled, it is this one that anticipated the coming of the Russian revolution and, in its train, an era of intensified political unrest and heightening of all social and national antagonisms.

To be sure, I will not deny that I did not predict the temporary quelling of the Russian revolution. But if someone predicted in 1846 the coming revolution of 1848, was he mistaken because this revolution was suppressed in 1849?

Of course, we must also allow for the possibility that any great movement and uprising will be suppressed. He is a fool who, before an impending battle, feels assured that he already has the victory in his pocket. We can only try to determine whether we are heading toward great revolutionary struggles. That can be recognized with some degree of certainty. Nothing can, however, be foretold about the outcome of any one of these struggles. We would be sorry specimens, indeed outright traitors to our cause and incapable of any struggle, if we were convinced in advance of the inevitability of defeat, if we did not allow for the possibility of victory.

Of course, not every expectation can be fulfilled. Anyone who claimed to be an infallible prophet or demanded infallible prophecies from others, would be presupposing supernatural powers in human beings.

Every politician must allow for the possibility that his expectations will not be fulfilled. Nevertheless, "prophesying" is not idle play; rather,

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when done cautiously and methodically, it is an activity indispensable for every thinking and forward-looking politician, a point Bebel has already made.

Only the dull-minded and routine-bound will be content with the belief that things will continue the way they are now. A politician who is also a thinker will always weigh all the possibilities that an event might carry in its womb and think them out to their farthest consequences. It is true that the forces of inertia in society are enormously great; in nine out of ten instances, the routine-bound person will therefore apparently turn out to be right when he continues on in the old way of doing things, without giving much thought to new situations and possibilities. But still the time will come when an event occurs strong enough to overcome the forces of inertia, which have already been severely shaken inwardly by previous events, even though to outward appearances things have remained as before. Now matters suddenly begin to develop along new pathways, and the reaction of all the routine-bound is to lose their heads. Only those politicians hold their own who have thoroughly familiarized themselves with the new possibilities and their consequences.

It would be wrong, though, to believe that, at least when things are running their usual course, the dull-minded, routine-bound person is superior to the politician who carefully considers the future or "prophecies." That could only be true if the politician took the possibilities whose consequences he thinks out, for realities, according to which he organizes and directs his immediate actions. Does anyone perhaps want to maintain that Engels and Bebel and any of the other "prophesying" politicians who are under discussion here, ever understood their prophecies in this way?

The dull-minded and routine-bound will never feel compelled to study the present, which appears to them as mere repetition of situations they are already acquainted with, situations in which they have previously found themselves. In contrast, someone who, in a particular situation, thinks through all its possibilities and consequences, can only do that by studying the existing forces and powers, and he will be especially impelled to direct his attention to the factors that have newly arisen and so far received little notice.

What appears to many Philistines as useless, haphazard prophesying is, in reality, the result of profound study and is thus always accompanied by increased knowledge of reality. An attack on the Engels and the Bebels because of their "prophecies" would be justified only if they had shown themselves to be unrealistic dreamers. In point of fact, no one has yet advised the proletariat better and more usefully in all difficult situations

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than these very "prophets," and that is so precisely because they were willing to engage in the work of "prophesying." The ones who hitherto have only too often led the rising classes down the wrong road, have not been the politicians who have constantly striven to see to the farthest horizon, but the "realist" politicians, who see no farther than the tips of their noses, who consider a reality only what they run into with their noses, and who declare any obstacle to be unending and insurmountable that they have bloodied their noses against.

But there is another kind of "prophesying" than the one just described. The development of a society is conditioned in the final analysis by the development of its mode of production, the laws of which we already know precisely enough to be able to recognize with some certainty the direction of the necessary social development and also to draw from the latter conclusions about the necessary course of the political development.

This kind of "prophesying" is frequently confused with the one that has just been presented, and yet the two are fundamentally different from each other. In the case of the one, it is a matter of very diverse possibilities that a particular event or a particular situation can contain in its womb and the probable consequences of which we must seek to understand. In the case of the other, it is a matter of a necessary, uniquely possible direction of development, which we must seek to understand. In the case of the first, we start out from determinate, concrete facts; the second can reveal to us only general tendencies, without telling us anything definite about the forms that they will assume. The two kinds of investigation must not be confused with each other, even when they apparently yield the same result.

For example, if someone states that a war between France and Germany will lead to a revolution, and if someone else declares that the growing intensification of the class antagonisms in capitalist society will lead to a revolution, then the latter assertion seems to be a prophecy of revolution of the very same kind as the former. Yet each of them means something different. If I speak of a war between France and Germany, that is not an event whose occurrence I can predict with the certainty of a natural law. Science is not that far advanced yet. War is only one of many possibilities that can occur. On the other hand, the revolution that can develop out of a war is tied to certain forms. It can happen that in the one of the two warring nations which proves to be the weaker, the impulse to unleash all the powers of its people against the external foe summons to the nation's fore the most ruthless and energetic class, the proletariat—similar to what Engels, in 1891, thought might happen in Germany if it

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had to wage war simultaneously against France, the size of whose population had not yet fallen so far behind that of Germany, and Russia, which had not yet been defeated or disorganized by revolution.

The revolution that occurs because of a war can, however, also result from an uprising of the broad masses of the people, if the army is broken and fed up with the sufferings of war, and the government is toppled, not in order to continue the war more vigorously, but instead to bring a futile and ruinous war to an end and make peace with an enemy who, too, wants nothing better.

Lastly, revolution as a consequence of a war can result from a general indignation about a disgraceful and disadvantageous peace agreement, an indignation that unites army and people against the government.

If, for the case under consideration here, certain forms of revolution are given in advance, the image of revolution remains, on the other hand, entirely undefined when I consider it as the consequence of the growing intensification of class antagonisms. I can very definitely assert that a revolution resulting from a war will break out either during or immediately after the war. However, when I speak of revolution as the result of the growing intensification of class antagonisms, that says nothing at all about the time of its occurrence. With regard to a revolution resulting from war, I can maintain with certainty that it will be a single event. As for the revolution resulting from the growing intensification of class antagonisms, it is not possible to say anything at all about this aspect of it. It can be a very long drawn-out process; a revolution resulting from a war might play in it only the role of an episode. It cannot be said with certainty in advance that a revolution resulting from a war will succeed. In contrast, the revolutionary movement springing from the intensification of class antagonisms can suffer defeats only temporarily; it must finally triumph.

On the other hand, however, the precondition of revolution in the first case, war, is, as we have already seen, something that might or might not happen. It would not occur to anyone to want to say anything definite about whether it will happen or not. The intensification of class antagonisms, however, arises necessarily out of the laws of the capitalist mode of production. If, then, revolution as a consequence of a war is only one of many possibilities, revolution as a consequence of the class struggle is an inevitability.

It is clear that each of the two kinds of "prophecies" has its own particular methods, requires its own particular studies, and the significance of the "prophecies," which seem empty, wild fantasies to

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those who have no notion of such studies, depends on the depth of these studies.

It would, though, be a great mistake to believe that we Marxists are the only ones who "prophesy." Even bourgeois politicians, who are firmly rooted in the status quo, cannot manage without looking far into the future. The entire strength of colonial policy, for example, is due to this practice. If it were only a matter of the present-day colonial policy, it would be very easy to deal with it. For all countries, with the exception of Great Britain, it is a wretched business. But this policy is the only area where, at least apparently, great hopes for the future still beckon within capitalist society. And it is because of the brilliant future which our colonial enthusiasts prophesy, not because of the miserable present, that the colonial policy exercises such a fascinating attraction on all spirits that are not convinced of the coming of socialism. Nothing could be more wrong than the view that in politics only the interests of the moment are decisive, that distant ideals have no practical importance, that we will obtain all the better results in our electioneering, say, the more "practically," that is, the more soberly and pettily we comport ourselves, the more we speak only of taxes and customs duties, of police chicanery and health insurance and the like, and the more we treat our great future goals like a past love of our youth, on which we still gladly look back in our hearts, but with whom we prefer no longer to have any connection in public.

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Politics is simply impossible without prophecies. Only, those who prophesy that for a long time to come things will stay the way they have been, do not feel that they are prophesying.

Of course, there can be no proletarian politician who is satisfied with the existing conditions and does not seek their thorough-going transformation. And there is no intelligent politician, regardless of orientation, who is free of prejudice even a little, and who does not admit that it would be absurd to expect the profound economic transformation of society to continue at its present rapid pace and everything to remain politically as it is for a long time to come.

If, however, a politician nevertheless chooses not to face up to the political revolution, that is, an energetic shifting of power relations in the state, then the only thing he can do is look for forms in which the antagonisms of the classes are slowly and imperceptibly eliminated, without a great, decisive struggle.

The liberals dream of the establishment of social peace between the classes, between the exploiters and the exploited, without elimination of exploitation, simply by each of the classes imposing on itself a certain self-limitation vis-à-vis the other and refraining from all "excesses" and "exaggerated demands." There are people who believe that the antagonism existing between the individual worker and the individual capitalist can be overcome if workers and capitalists confront each other in *organizations*. The *wage agreements* were supposed to be the beginning of social peace. In reality, the effect of organization is only to concentrate the way the antagonisms are expressed. The struggles between the two sides become less frequent but more powerful, and they convulse society far more than the earlier small isolated struggles. Because of organization, the antagonism of the opposing interests itself becomes much more clear-cut. Owing to organization, it is felt less and less as an *accidental* antagonism of single *individuals*, and more as a *necessary* antagonism of entire *classes*.

A socialist cannot share the illusion of the reconciliation of classes and of social peace. Indeed, he is a socialist precisely because he does not share this illusion. He knows that not a chimerical *reconciliation*, but only

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the *abolition* of social classes can establish social peace. If, however, he has lost faith in the revolution, then nothing remains for him but the expectation of the peaceful and imperceptible elimination of social classes through economic progress, through the growth in size and strength of the working class, which gradually absorbs the other classes.

That is the theory of *growing* into socialist society.

This theory contains a core of unquestionable reality. It is based on facts of the actual development proving that we are in point of fact growing toward socialism. It was none other than Marx and Engels who described this process and demonstrated that it unfolded as though a matter of natural law.

We are growing into a socialist society from two sides. First, through the development of capitalism, through the concentration of capital. It is a result of business competition that the larger capital, since it is superior to the small capital, threatens, presses hard, and finally drives the latter from the field. That fact alone, entirely leaving aside the mad pursuit of profit, drives every capitalist to enlarge his capital, to expand his enterprises. Businesses become more and more enormous; more and more firms are joined together in a single hand. Today, we have already reached the point where banks and entrepreneurs' organizations control and organize the largest part of the capitalist enterprises of the most diverse nations. Thus the way is increasingly prepared for the social organization of production.

With this centralization of enterprises, there goes hand in hand a growth of the great fortunes, which is in no way hindered by the form of the joint-stock company. On the contrary, not only is the joint-stock company necessary for the present-day control of production by just a small number of banks and entrepreneurs' organizations; it is also a means for transforming into capital small and very small fortunes and thereby delivering them up to capitalism's process of centralization.

By means of the system of joint-stock ownership, the savings of the little people are made available to the large capitalists, who use them as though they were their own funds and thereby enhance still further the centralizing force of their own large fortunes.

The system of joint-stock ownership makes the capitalist himself completely superfluous to the functioning of the capitalist enterprise. The exclusion of the capitalist's person from economic life ceases to be a question of economic *possibility* or *expediency*. It becomes merely a question of *power*.

The creation of necessary conditions for socialism through the concentration of capital is, however, only one side of the growth into the

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state of the future. In addition, there occurs within the working class, too, a development signifying a growth in the direction of socialism. As capital increases, the number of proletarians in society also grows. They become its most numerous class. And at the same time, their organizations grow. The workers found co-operatives that exclude intermediary commerce and organize production for their own needs. They establish trade-unions that seek to set limits to the absolutism of employers and to gain influence on the production process. They elect deputies to the representative bodies of local communities and states, who there strive to force through reforms, to gain acceptance of laws protecting workers, to re-shape the enterprises owned by the state and by local communities into model enterprises, and to constantly increase the number of such enterprises.

This movement is proceeding without interruption. As our reformists say, we are already in the social revolution; indeed, according to some, already in socialism. All that is needed is a further development on the given base, not a catastrophe. The latter can only disrupt the process of growing into socialism so away with all thought of it; let us concentrate on "positive" work.

This prospect is certainly very alluring, and a person would really have to be diabolical to wish to disrupt such a splendid "gradual reformist advance" with a catastrophe. If the wish were the father of our thoughts, we Marxists would all have to be enthusiastic about this theory of growing into socialism.

It has just one small defect: the growth that it describes is not the growth of a *single* element, but of *two* elements, and indeed of two very *antagonistic* elements: capital and labor. What appears to the "reformists" as a peaceful growth into socialism is only the growth in strength of the two antagonistic classes which confront each other in irreconcilable hostility. It means merely that the antagonism between capital and labor, which began as an antagonism between a number of individuals constituting a small minority within the state, is now growing into a struggle of gigantic, tight-knit organizations, which condition the whole life of society and state. Thus growing into socialism means growing into great struggles that will convulse the entire political system, that must continually become more powerful and can end only with the defeat and expropriation of the capitalist class. For the proletariat is indispensable to society; it can be beaten for a time, but never destroyed. In contrast, the capitalist class has become superfluous; the first great defeat in the struggle for control of the government suffered by this class must lead to its complete and permanent collapse.

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Whosoever refuses to recognize these consequences of our continuous growth into socialism must be blind to the fundamental fact of our society: the class antagonism between capital and labor. Growth into socialism is only another expression for the continuous intensification of class antagonisms, for growth into an epoch of great, decisive class struggles, which we may collectively call the "social revolution."

Of course, the revisionists reject the truth of this contention, but they have not yet succeeded in advancing a cogent rebuttal of this view. The objections they make against it are all facts that, if they were of significance and proved anything, would demonstrate not society's "growth into," but instead its "growth away from" socialism, such as the assumption that capital is not becoming centralized, but rather decentralized. This logical contradiction is grounded in the very nature of revisionism: it must accept the Marxist theory of capitalism to be able to prove that society is growing into socialism; and it must repudiate this theory to be able to make the peaceful further development of society, the mitigation of class antagonisms, believable.

However, even while they are doing this, a suspicion is beginning to dawn in the heads of the revisionists and their neighbors that there is something amiss in the idea of growing peacefully into the state of the future.

Typical of this incipient realization is an article entitled "Das Schicksal des Marxismus" [The fate of Marxism] that [Friedrich] Naumann published in the October issue of *Die Neue Rundschau* (1908) [19, no. 4:1393-1410] and then in *Die Hilfe*. The account of this fate given us there by the former leader of the National-Social Association is a quite confused one. He supposes that the concentration of capital, the formation of employers' associations, is something that surprises us Marxists and puts us in an awkward position, something that we did not expect. And on the other hand, he maintains that it was only the revisionist trade unionists who, in opposition to the Marxists, insisted on the importance of legal protection of workers and of the organization of workers in trade unions. The good man has no inkling that it was Marx who first propagated both of these things on the European continent and that he recognized their importance, as well as that of the employers' associations, much earlier than the other socialists.

But one is accustomed to these gentlemen's ignorance of such matters. There is really no longer any need to take notice of it. It is, however, worthy of comment that in his article, Naumann discovers the superior strength of concentrated capital, with the result that, according to him, economic development leads not into socialism, but to "a new

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feudalism with unprecedentedly strong economic resources." Co-operatives and trade unions, he says, are no match for the employers' associations.

For the foreseeable future, the leadership of industry is located where cartels and banks are working together. There centers of domination have come into being that cannot be toppled by any social revolution, as long as no horrible periods of unemployment and hunger cause mass rancor, which then simply destroys everything blindly without being able to construct something better. Objectively, the idea of the social revolution is at an end. That is all very distressing for all socialists of the old stamp, also for us ideologists concerned with social justice and amelioration, who hoped for a more rapid march of the workers' successes, but it does no good to fool ourselves. The coming period belongs to the industrial combines.

The last thing the foregoing looks like is a growth into socialism, and least of all, a peaceful growth into socialism. Naumann himself can propose no other means for overthrowing the new feudalism than a "mass rancor" that "destroys everything," that is to say, a revolution – but then he suddenly turns a logical somersault. First he admits that the employers' associations can now be toppled only through a revolution. Then, however, he puts an end to the thought of such a revolution with the simple assertion that it would have to be a hunger-driven revolt that "simply destroys everything blindly without being able to construct something better." Why that must be so, why the revolution is condemned to sterility from the outset, remains Naumann's secret.

However, after he has, without any justification, killed the idea of the revolution with a stroke of the pen, he does not at all fall prey to complete hopelessness, but draws himself erect full of gladsome faith. For he discovers that the employers' associations are irresistible only for Marxists, who recognize economic necessity and deny free will. We need only recognize this will, then we, too, will be able to deal with the employers' associations; then the "unprecedentedly strong resources" of the "new feudalism" will lose their irresistibility.

What the outrage of the masses is not able to do, recognition of the free will of the individual, the outstanding "personality," is supposed to

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accomplish. Calling attention to this is "practical" "Realpolitik." Naumann tells us:

Marx did not place much store in the appeal to free will because he regarded everything as happening of natural necessity. At least that is how it sounds in his theory. Of course, as an individual he was a strong-willed personality and an awakener of energies. At the present time, though, among the thoughtful members of the Social Democratic Party, a certain return from a doctrine of natural determination to one of determinative efficacy of will [*von der Naturlehre zur Willenslehre*] and thereby to the fundamental doctrine of all liberal movements is taking place. Eduard Bernstein has spoken most clearly of our need to sit at Kant's feet again. Also in the anarchist or semi-anarchist movements on the margin of the Social Democratic Party, there is the same movement away from belief in a blindly governing natural fate in the economy to recognition that the will shapes things this way or that. This return to a doctrine of will is a result of the consolidation of the new dominance of industry. It has been observed that it will not tumble down of its own accord, but that concessions must rather be wrested from it through acts of the will.

The ones who are only now observing that are the admirers of peaceful growth into socialism. We Marxists really have no need of this insight. In contrast, it is a tremendous discovery for the revisionists, as well as for their anarchist and national-social relatives. But they are bees who know how to suck honey from any flower, and thus they also see in this discovery a refutation of Marxist views – just as their liberal, national-social, anarchist, and semi-anarchist spiritual brothers do. They all accuse Marx of recognizing only a "blindly governing" "automatic" economic development and of being unaware of the human will. And, they say, our chief task is nothing else but to engender this will.

Thus teaches not just Naumann, but also [Raphael] Friedeberg. Thus teach those elements who within the Social Democratic Party shift back and forth between Naumann and Friedeberg, like [Kurt] Eisner and [Max] Maurenbrecher. Thus teach also the theoreticians of revisionism, such as Tugan-Baranovsky:

Growing into the State of the Future

The author of *Capital* overestimated the significance of the elementary side of the historical process and did not grasp the enormous creative power of the *living human personality* in this process. (Translated by John H. Kautsky; see also M. Tugan-Baranowsky, *Modern Socialism* [London: S. Sonnenschein, 1910], 97)

All of that demonstrates clearly that the theory of peaceful "growth into" socialism has a gaping hole, which is to be plugged up by the enormous creative power of the living human personality and its free will. But this free will, which is to supplement society's growth into socialism, in reality means its abolition. If Naumann is right that the will is free and "shapes things this way or that," then it can also shape the direction of economic development "this way or that"; then it is absolutely incomprehensible what guarantee we have that we are growing into socialism and not into something else. Then it is altogether impossible to recognize any direction of social development; then no social scientific knowledge is possible.

Economic Development and Will

To the preceding exposition, the revisionists will reply that a much greater contradiction is revealed by Marx himself, who, as a thinker, did not recognize a free will, expecting everything from necessary economic development that proceeds automatically, but who, as a revolutionary fighter, always displayed will in the strongest manner and appealed to the proletariat's volition. That — revisionists, anarchists, and liberals in closest fellowship proclaim to us — is an insurmountable contradiction in the theory and the practice of Karl Marx.

In reality, no such contradiction can be found in Marx. It is a product of his critics' confusion — of an incurable confusion, since it re-occurs again and again. For one thing, this confusion rests on the equation of will with free will. Marx never failed to recognize the importance of the will and the "enormous power of the human personality" for society. He denied only the freedom of the will, and that is something quite different. That has already been explained often enough, so that there is no need to discuss it once again here.

In addition, though, this confusion is based on a very odd idea about what economy and economic development are. Because economic development takes place according to certain laws, all these learned gentlemen suppose that it proceeds automatically, spontaneously, without willing human individuals, so that human volition appears as a separate element *alongside of* and *above* the economy, an element that supplements the economy and causes the things conditioned by the economy to be shaped "in this way or that." This view is possible only in brains that conceive of the economy in a completely scholastic manner, that have adopted their notions from books and then operate with them as mere ideas, without having gained the least direct and concrete perception of the actual economic process. In that respect the proletarians are, at any rate, superior to them, and therefore they are, Maurenbrecher and Eisner notwithstanding, better qualified to grasp this process and its historical role than are the bourgeois theoreticians, to whom the economic practice is foreign, but also than the bourgeois practitioners, who lack any theoretical interest, any urge to understand more of the economy than is required for successful profiteering.

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All of economic theory becomes an empty conceptual game for any one who does not begin with the recognition that the motive force of any economic process is the human will. Not, however, a *free* will, not a volition as such, but a *determinate* volition. In the final analysis, it is *the will to live* that underlies all economy, that indeed comes into being with the very life of organisms endowed with locomotion and cognition. Every form of volition is, in the last analysis, traceable to the will to live.

Which particular forms the organism's will to live assumes in every individual instance depends on the particular conditions of its life — the word "conditions" understood in its broadest meaning, which includes also the threats to and the hindrances of life, not solely the means of its preservation. The living conditions determine the nature of its volition, the forms of its activity, and the success of that activity.

This recognition constitutes the starting point of the materialist conception of history. But it is certainly true that, simple as the circumstances are that are to be explained in this way in the case of the simpler organisms, the intermediate links are correspondingly many that are interposed between the mere will to live and the diverse forms that the volition of more highly developed organisms can assume. It cannot be my task to demonstrate that in greater detail here. But a few comments by me would not, I think, be out of place.

An organism's living conditions are of two kinds: for one thing, there are those that always recur and do not change in the course of many generations. A purposive volition that is adapted to these conditions becomes then a habit that is passed on to offspring and is strengthened by natural selection; it becomes an instinct, a drive, that the individual ultimately obeys in all circumstances, even in extraordinary conditions, in which obeying the drive does not benefit and preserve life, but does it harm, perhaps even; causing death. Nonetheless the primal source of this will is always the will to live.

However, in addition to the living conditions that always recur in the same way, there are also those that occur only rarely or in a variable manner. With regard to these, instinct fails; the preservation of life then depends for the greatest part on the organism's cognitive capability, which is able to apprehend the given situation and adapt the organism's behavior to it. The more an animal species lives in rapidly changing conditions of life, the more will it develop its intelligence, partly because greater demands are made on the organs of intelligence, partly because the individuals having weaker intelligence are more likely to be eliminated.

Finally, man's intelligence becomes so great that he is able to make artificial organs for himself, weapons and tools, to be able to sustain himself better in the given conditions of life. But at the same time, he thereby also creates new living conditions for himself, to which he has to adapt himself. In this way, the development of technology, a product of higher intelligence, becomes itself an impetus to the further development of intelligence.

The development of technology, too, is a product of the will to live, but it results in a significant modification of that will. The animal wants to live as it has lived hitherto. It does not ask for more than that. The invention of a new weapon or a new tool creates the possibility of living better than before, of obtaining more abundant food, more leisure, more safety, or, finally, of satisfying new needs and desires that until then were unknown. The more technology is developed, the more does the will to live become the will to live better.

This will distinguishes civilized man.

Technology, however, changes not only the relationship of men to nature, but also the relationship between one man and another.

Men are among the social animals, those animals whose conditions of life do not permit them to live in isolation, but only joined together in societies. In this case, the will to live assumes the form of the will to live with the members of society and for them. As it changes the other conditions of life, the development of technology also changes the conditions of living and acting together in society, chiefly by conferring on man organs separate from his body. Natural tools and weapons: nails, teeth, horns, and the like, are equally proper to all individuals of the same species (assuming they are of the same sex and age). In contrast, artificial tools and weapons can be possessed by certain men alone and denied to others. Those who alone have such weapons and tools at their disposal live in other conditions of life than do those who lack them. In this manner different classes are formed, in each of which the same will to live assumes different forms.

A capitalist, for example, cannot exist in the conditions under which he lives if he does not make profits. His will to live drives him to gain profits, and his will to live better drives him to strive to increase his profits. That alone presses him to increase his capital, but the competition that threatens him with ruin if he is not able to continuously increase his capital is working in the same direction and even more strongly. The concentration of capitals is not an automatic process occurring without the will and the consciousness of the participants in it. It would not be possible at all without the capitalists' very energetic will to become rich

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and drive their weaker competitors from the field. What lies outside their will and their consciousness is merely the fact that the results of their will and their striving create the conditions of socialist production. The capitalists surely do not intend that. But that does not mean that men's volition and the "enormous power of the creative personality" do not play a part in the economic process.

The same will to live that animates the capitalist operates also in the workers. In accordance with their different living conditions, however, among them it assumes different forms. They do not strive for profits, but to sell their labor power; they strive for high prices for labor power and low prices for food. Out of these interests arise their founding of co-operatives and trade unions, their striving for worker-protection laws, and, finally, the second tendency, besides that toward the concentration of capital, which is referred to as growing into socialism. Here, too, this does not mean the involuntary, unconscious process usually understood by the phrase "growing into."

Lastly, there is yet another side of the will to live that is relevant to the social process. Under certain conditions, the will to live of an individual or a society can only be activated by overcoming the will to live of other individuals. The predatory animal can only live by destroying other animals. Often its will to live requires that it drive away fellow species members who contest its prey or diminish the food available to it. This does not require the destruction of others, but certainly necessitates the bending of their will through stronger nerves or superior muscular strength.

Such conflicts occur also among men, less between individuals than between societies, for the means of obtaining what is required to live, from hunting grounds and fisheries to markets and colonies. Such conflicts always end either with the destruction of the one party or, and more frequently, with a breaking or bending of that party's will. Each time this is only a transitory occurrence. But, in addition, men develop a lasting bending of the will of others by developing lasting relations of exploitation.

Class antagonisms are antagonisms of volition. The capitalists' will to live meets with conditions that drive them to bend the workers' will and make it subservient to themselves. Without this bending of the will, there would be no capitalist profits; no capitalists could exist. On the other hand, though, the workers' will to live drives these to rebel against the capitalists' will. Hence the class struggle.

Thus we regard the will as the motive force of the entire economic process. It constitutes its starting point; it pervades every one of its

expressions.. There is nothing more absurd than to see in the will and the economy two factors that are independent of each other. Behind this view stands the fetishistic conception that confuses the economy, that is, the forms of men's working with and against one another in society, with the material objects of this work, the raw materials and tools. This conception supposes that, as men use raw materials and tools to form certain objects according to their discretion, so does the "creative personality" use the economy with free will to shape certain social relations "in this way or that" according to his needs and desires. Because the worker stands outside the raw materials and tools, because he stands above them and controls them, the economic fetishist believes that man stands outside the economy, that he stands above it and controls it in accordance with free will. And because raw materials and tools have no will and no consciousness, he believes that in the economy everything happens automatically, without will and consciousness.

There is no more ridiculous misunderstanding than this.

Economic necessity does not mean absence of will. It originates from the necessity of living beings to want to live, and from the inevitability of using for that purpose the conditions of life that they find themselves in. It is the necessity of determinate volition.

Nothing, then, is more preposterous than the notion that recognition of economic necessity means a weakening of volition; that the latter must first be awakened in the workers, namely by means of biographies of generals and other strong-willed men and of lectures about freedom of the will! When people have been persuaded that something exists, then, supposedly, just in virtue of that fact, it should exist and be possessed by them. Whoever believes in free will should thereby acquire will, and indeed free will! Just take a look at our professors and other bourgeois intellectuals who have, on the one hand, been students of Kant and, on the other, have been formed by veneration for the strong-willed Hohenzollerns; what an abundance of indomitable will they have thereby acquired!

If the primal source of all economic necessity, the will to live, did not operate in the workers in the strongest manner, if this will had to be first artificially awakened in them, then all our efforts would be in vain.

That is not to say, however, that men's volition has no connection with their consciousness and is not determined by it. The energy of the will to live is certainly not dependent on our consciousness, but the latter does determine the *forms* assumed by that will in particular instances, and the energy given by it to certain ones among such forms. As we have seen, in addition to instinct, consciousness guides the will, and the forms of the

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latter are dependent on the manner in which and the degree to which consciousness recognizes the living conditions. Since the cognitive capability is different in different individuals, even their same will to live can react in different ways to the same conditions of life; and it is this difference that creates the appearance of freedom of the will, as though the nature of the individual's volition were dependent not on his living conditions, but on his will.

The forms of the proletariat's volition and the energy that it bestows on certain of those forms can be influenced in the proletariat's interest not by edifying legends and speculations about freedom of the will, but only through broadening the proletariat's understanding of social conditions.

The will to live is the fact that we must begin with, that we must presuppose as given. The forms it assumes and the intensity with which it expresses itself then depend, for certain individuals, classes, and nations, etc., on their recognition of the given conditions of life, which are, when they engender in two classes an antagonistic will, also *conditions of conflict*.

We are concerned here only with the last-named conditions.

Will as desire to engage in conflict is determined: 1) by *the prize contended for*, that beckons to the combatants; 2) by the combatants' *sentiment of strength*; and 3) by their *actual strength*.

The more valuable the prize of the struggle, the stronger is the will, the more is ventured, the more energetically are all forces brought to bear on gaining the prize. But that is true only when one is convinced that one possesses the strength and the abilities required for winning the prize. If one does not have the necessary self-confidence, then, no matter how alluring the goal of the struggle might be, it does not trigger volition, but only wishing, longing, that might be very ardent, but does not bring forth deeds and is, practically speaking, completely pointless.

The sentiment of strength, now, is worse than useless if it is based not on real knowledge of one's own forces as well as those of the opponent, but on mere illusions. Strength without the sentiment of strength remains dead, produces no volition. The sentiment of strength without strength can, in certain circumstances, lead to deeds that surprise and intimidate the opponent, that bend or paralyze his will. Without real strength, though, enduring successes cannot be achieved. Enterprises accomplished successfully not through real strength, but only through deception of the opponent about one's own strength, must always sooner or later come to grief and result in discouragement that is all the greater, the more brilliant the initial successes were.

If we apply what has been said to the proletariat's class struggle, it becomes clear what are the tasks of those who also want to take part in and advance that struggle, and how the Social Democratic Party influences it. Our first and most important task is to increase the proletariat's strength. Of course, we cannot augment this just as we like. In a determinate state of capitalist society, the proletariat's forces are determined by that society's economic conditions and cannot be arbitrarily increased. But the effect of the given forces can be intensified by counteracting their squandering. The mindless processes in nature amount to an infinite squandering of forces, if we consider them from the standpoint of our goals. For nature has no purpose that it subserves. Man's conscious volition sets goals for him, but also shows him the ways to achieve those goals in the appropriate manner, without wasting his forces, with the least expenditure of strength.

This is also true of the proletariat's class struggle. From the very outset, certainly, it does not proceed without the consciousness of those participating in it. In this struggle, however, their conscious volition encompasses only their immediate personal needs and desires. At first, the social transformations resulting from their concern with these needs and desires remain hidden from the combatants. Therefore, as a social process, the class struggle is, for a long time, an unconscious process, and as such is endued with all the waste of force inherent in all unconscious processes. Only the recognition and understanding of the social process, of its tendencies and goals, can put an end to this squandering, can concentrate the forces of the proletariat and join them together in large organizations that are united by great goals, and that methodically subordinate individual actions and actions of the moment to enduring class interests, which, for their part, subserve the whole social development.

In other words, theory is the factor that increases to the highest degree the possible actualization of the proletariat's strength by teaching how to make the most appropriate use of the forces given to it by the economic development and by counteracting the squandering of these forces.

Theory, however, increases not only the proletariat's effective strength, but also its belief in its strength. And that is no less necessary.

As we have seen, the will is determined not merely by consciousness, but also by habits and instincts. Circumstances that for decades, indeed for centuries, are always repeated, produce habits and instincts that still continue to operate even after their material foundations have disappeared. A class that previously ruled by virtue of its superior strength, can have been weak for a long time, and a class exploited by it,

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that earlier was weak and therefore was overcome by an exploiting class, can have been strong for a long time. But the belief in the strength of a class that has been handed down from the past continues to be operative on both sides for a long time until a test of strength takes place, for example, a war, that reveals all the weakness of the ruling class. Now the dominated class suddenly becomes aware of its strength; the point is reached when a revolution, a sudden collapse, occurs.

Thus, in the proletariat, too, the feeling of its original weakness and the belief in the invincibility of capital remain effective for a long time after the fact.

The capitalist mode of production originated in an era when masses of proletarians were helplessly unemployed, parasitical wretches superfluous to society. The capitalist who took them into his service became their savior, the one who "gave them bread," or, as one now says, "gave them work," which does not sound much better. Their will to live drove them to sell themselves. Other than this, they saw no possibility of existing; nor did they see any possibility of offering resistance to the capitalist. But gradually the relationship changed. The proletarians change from annoying beggars, who were given employment out of pity, into the working class, from which society lives. In contrast, the individual capitalist becomes increasingly superfluous to the process of production, as the joint-stock companies and the trusts clearly demonstrate. From an economic necessity, the relationship between the wage worker and the capitalist changes more and more into a mere power relationship, maintained by the power of the state. But the proletariat becomes the most numerous class in the state and also in the army, on which the government rests. In an industrially highly developed country, like Germany or Britain, it probably possesses even now the strength to gain control of the government, and would probably find that the economic conditions are such as would allow using the government to supplant capitalist enterprises with socially owned and operated ones.

What the proletariat lacks, though, is awareness of its strength. Only some particular strata possess it; in its entirety, the proletariat lacks it. What the Social Democratic Party can do to impart this awareness to the whole of the proletariat, it does. Here again, through theoretical education, but not only by this means. Always more effective than all theory for molding consciousness of strength is the deed. Its successes in the struggle against its opponent are the means whereby the Social Democratic Party most clearly shows the proletariat its strength and, by so doing, increases the latter's sentiment of strength most effectively. Successes that the Party, here again, owes to the fact that it is guided by a

theory which enables the conscious, organized part of the proletariat to bring to bear at any time the maximum of the forces at its disposal.

Outside the Anglo-Saxon world, trade-union activity, from its very beginning, arose from and was made fruitful by the insights of social democracy.

In addition to the successes of that activity, it is the successful struggles for the control of parliaments and in parliaments that have mightily increased the proletariat's strength and its sentiment of strength. Not only by means of the material advantages thereby gained for certain strata of the proletariat, but chiefly through the fact that the propertyless, heretofore intimidated, and hopeless popular masses saw here a force enter upon the scene that boldly did battle with all the ruling powers, that won victory after victory, and yet was nothing other than an organization of these very propertyless masses.

Therein lies the great importance of the May Day celebrations and of electoral campaigns, as well as of the struggles for the suffrage. They do not always gain considerable material advantages for the proletariat; the latter are often out of all proportion to the sacrifices of the struggle, and yet, when they end in victory, they always bring about an enormous growth of the proletariat's effective forces, because they powerfully spur on its sentiment of strength and thereby the energy of its volition in the class struggle.

Our opponents, however, fear nothing more than the growth of this sentiment of strength. They know that the giant will not be a danger to them as long as he does not become aware of his strength. Their greatest concern is to suppress his sentiment of strength; even material concessions are less hateful to them than the moral victories of the working class that increase its self-confidence. That is why they often fight much more energetically for autocracy in the factory, for the power of the "master in his own house," than against wage increases; that is the reason for their stubborn hostility to celebrating May Day with a holiday from work; that is the reason for their efforts to throttle universal and equal suffrage everywhere it has become a means to manifestly demonstrate to the populace the victorious, irresistible advance of the Social Democratic Party. It is not fear of a social-democratic majority that drives them to such efforts — they would not have to worry about that for quite a few elections. No, it is the fear that the Social Democratic Party's continuous electoral victories would necessarily confer on the proletariat such a sentiment of strength and so intimidate its opponents that it would become irresistible, the government's instruments of power would prove inadequate, and the relations of power in the state would be completely transformed.

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Therefore we must not be surprised when our next great electoral victory brings us an attack on the existing suffrage for the Reichstag – by that I do not at all mean to say that this attack will succeed. It can, rather, set off struggles that ultimately result in defeats for the powers that be which are graver and more dangerous than our electoral victories.

True, our party has not only victories to show, but also defeats. These will be all the less disheartening, though, the more we accustom ourselves to lifting our gaze above the limitation of a particular locality and of a particular moment, to follow our movement in its total context through two generations in all nations. The irresistible and rapid progress of the whole proletariat, despite some very serious defeats, then becomes so obvious that nothing can cripple our confidence in victory.

The more we attempt, however, to consider our individual struggles in their relationship to the total social development, all the clearer and more powerfully does there arise before our eyes the final goal of all our striving, the liberation of the working class and thus of humanity from every kind of class rule; all the more noble become the small tasks that we perform everyday, which the will to live imposes incessantly and necessarily on the proletariat; all the more does the greatness of the prize rouse the proletariat's will to the highest degree into revolutionary passion, which is not the mindless excitement of surprise, but rather the product of clear understanding. That is why the Social Democratic Party has exerted influence on the proletariat's volition up to now, and it has achieved such brilliant results in this fashion that there is not the least reason for it to exchange its method for another.

Neither Revolution nor Legality at Any Price

On the one hand, we Marxists are reproached with eliminating will from politics, making the latter into an automatic process. On the other hand, however, the same critics maintain the exact opposite, that our volition is more important to us than understanding reality. The latter, they say, would necessarily teach us the impossibility of any revolution; but we cling to the idea of revolution out of sheer emotional fanaticism and intoxicate ourselves with that idea. We strive for the political revolution at any price, for its own sake, even if we were more likely to advance on the given legal basis.

Among other things, they attempt to place me in opposition to *Friedrich Engels*, who, as is said, certainly at one time also had very revolutionary feelings, but who, shortly before his death, became reasonable and recognized as well as acknowledged the untenableness of his revolutionary position.

Now it is correct that Engels in 1895, in his well-known preface to Marx's *Class Struggles in France*, pointed out how greatly the conditions of the revolutionary struggle had changed in comparison with 1848. In order to gain victory, we needed to have great masses behind us who "understand what is to be done," and we, the "revolutionaries," the "rebels," thrived far better on legal methods than on illegal ones and revolt. However, it should not be forgotten that he meant that only for the situation at that time. Anyone who wants to know how Engels's statements should be understood, must compare them with the letters from Engels that I recently called attention to in *Die Neue Zeit* (27/1[1908]:7). These clearly show that he energetically sought to dispel the appearance of being "a peaceable worshiper of legality at any price." In that article in *Die Neue Zeit*, I wrote:

The introduction to Marx's *Class Struggles* is dated March 6, 1895. The book appeared a few weeks later. I had asked Engels to allow me to print the introduction in *Die Neue Zeit* before it was published.

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He replied to my request on March 25:

Your telegram answered immediately: "With pleasure." The text in proof sheets with the title: Introduction to the Reprint of Marx's *The Class Struggles in France 1848-1850* by F.E., follows by book post. It is stated in the text that the content consists of reprints of old articles from the review of the N.Rh.Z. (*Neue Rheinische Zeitung*). My text suffered somewhat from the misgivings of our Berlin friends, arising from their apprehensions about the anti-subversion bill, which, under the circumstances, I of course had to take into account. (Friedrich Engels's *Briefwechsel mit Karl Kautsky* [Friedrich Engels' correspondence with Karl Kautsky], ed. Benedikt Kautsky [Vienna: Danubia, 1955], p. 426)

In order to understand that, it is necessary to recall that the so-called anti-subversion bill, which proposed making existing laws considerably stricter in order to hinder socialist propaganda, was presented to the German Reichstag on 5 December 1894, which referred it to a commission on 14 January, where it was discussed for more than three months (until 25 April). It was just in this period that Engels's introduction was written.

A later passage of the same letter makes plain how seriously he considered the situation to be. There he wrote:

I believe an electoral reform bringing us into parliament to be absolutely certain in Austria, unless a sudden general period of reaction begins. In Berlin, they appear to be working mightily to bring such a period about, but unfortunately they do not know even from one day to the next what they want. (*Ibid.*, p. 427.)

Even earlier, on 3 January, right before he began to compose the introduction, Engels had written to me:

It looks like you will be having a quite lively year in Germany. If Herr von Köller [the Prussian minister of the interior] continues to do as he has been, nothing is impossible: conflict, dissolution of parliament, coup d'état. One will also be content with less, of course. The Junkers would be satisfied just with an increase of the charitable gifts [premiums for exports and privileges with

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respect to taxes on brandy and grain] to them, but to receive these they will have to appeal to certain cravings of personal lust for power, will have to yield to them to a certain degree, at which point the factors of resistance also begin to play a role, and then accident, the unintended, the unpredictable, comes into play. In order to make sure of the charitable gifts, they will have to threaten with conflict—but if they go a step farther, the original purpose, the charitable gift, becomes of minor importance; then crown is ranged against the Reichstag; bend or be broken; then things can become very interesting. At the moment, I am reading Gardiner's *Personal Government of Charles I*. The matters recounted there often correspond with present-day Germany to the point of ridiculousness. For example, the arguments about the immunity of actions performed in parliament. If Germany were a Latin country, *then revolutionary conflict would be inevitable*; but as it is ... we don't know nothing for sure, as Jollymeier (Schorlemer) says. (*Ibid.*, pp. 419–20)

That is how serious and fraught with conflict Engels believed the situation to be at the time when the Revisionists are having him proclaim that the era of unconditional legal and peaceful development had dawned and was ensured forever, that the era of revolutions lay behind us.

It is clear that Engels, having such a view of the situation, avoided everything that could be turned to account against the Party by its opponents; that he of course remained inflexible in the substance of his position, but expressed himself as guardedly as possible.

However, when Vorwärts, probably in order to influence favorably the commission's discussions of the anti-subversion bill, published some pieces of the introduction that were patched together in such a way that, read by themselves, they created the impression which, according to the later assertions of the Revisionists, had been intended by Engels, then the latter blazed up in pure wrath. In a letter dated 1 April, he wrote:

To my astonishment, I have seen today in *Vorwärts* an excerpt from my introduction printed without my knowledge and consent and so trimmed to fit that I look there like a peaceable worshiper of legality *quand même* (at any price). I am all the gladder that the whole thing is

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now going to appear in *Die Neue Zeit*, so that this disgraceful impression will be effaced. I shall tell Liebknecht my opinion about the matter in no uncertain terms, and also those, whoever they may be, who gave him this opportunity to misrepresent my opinion. (*Ibid.*, pp. 429-30.)

He did not suspect that soon thereafter trusted friends, who should have felt the most responsibility for protecting his opinions from misrepresentations, would come to take the view that this distorted opinion had been his true one, and that which seemed disgraceful to him was the most magnificent achievement of his life: the view that, at the end of his life, the revolutionary fighter had become a "peaceable worshiper of legality at any price."

Should these explanations not suffice to characterize Engels's standpoint with regard to the revolution, then let me also refer to an article entitled "Socialism in Germany" that he published in *Die Neue Zeit* in 1892[10/1: 580-89], a few years before the introduction to Marx's *Class Struggles*. There he wrote:

How many times have the bourgeois called on us to renounce the use of revolutionary means under all circumstances, to remain within the law, now that the exceptional law has been dropped and the common law has been re-established for all, even for the socialists! Unfortunately, we are not in a position to oblige *messieurs les bourgeois*. Be that as it may, *for the time being* it is not we who are being destroyed by legality. On the contrary, it is working so well for us that we would be mad to violate it as long as we advance in this way. The real question is whether it will be the bourgeois and their government who will violate the law in order to crush us by violence. We shall wait and see. In the meantime, you shoot first, *messieurs les bourgeois*!

No doubt they *will* shoot first. One fine day the German bourgeois and their government will tire of watching with their arms folded the ever growing flood of socialism; they will resort to illegality and violence. To what avail? With force it is possible to crush a small sect in a restricted space, but the force is yet to be discovered that can wipe out a party of two or three million men

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spread out over a large empire. The temporary superiority of counter-revolutionary forces can perhaps delay the triumph of socialism by a few years; but only in order to make it all the more complete and final when it comes. (Marx, Engels, *Collected Works*, 27:240-41)

This passage, as well as the pertinent letters, must be taken into account by anyone who wants to understand correctly the remarks in Engels's introduction about the legality within which we thrive. They mean anything but a renunciation of the idea of revolution.

Of course, they do mean the emphatic rejection of the view that we should wager everything on the card of the coming revolution, and that this will simply repeat the model of 1830 and 1848. But whoever for that reason believes that in this regard my standpoint is opposed to that of Engels is mistaken. In point of fact, even before Engels wrote his introduction, I had developed, in another connection and another form, the same train of thought that we find there.

In the twelfth volume of *Die Neue Zeit*, I published in December 1893 [12/1:361-69, 402-10] an article about a "social-democratic catechism," in which I also discussed at length the question of the revolution. There I said:

We are revolutionaries, and are such not merely in the sense in which the steam engine is a revolutionary. The social revolution that we are striving for can only be achieved by means of a political revolution, through the conquest of political power by the militant proletariat. And the particular form of government in which alone socialism can be realized, is the republic, and by that I mean 'republic' in the most common meaning of the term, namely the democratic republic.

The Social Democratic Party is a revolutionary party, but not a party that makes revolutions. We know that our goals can be reached only through a revolution; however, we also know that it lies just as little in our power to make this revolution as it lies in the power of our opponents to prevent it. Thus it does not even occur to us to want to foment a revolution or to prepare the conditions for one. And since the revolution cannot be made by us at will, we also cannot say anything at all about when, under which conditions, and in which forms

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it will occur. We know that the class struggle between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat will not end until the latter has attained to full possession of political power, which it will use to introduce socialist society. We know that this class struggle must become ever more extensive and intensive; that the proletariat is growing ever greater in size and ever stronger morally and economically; that therefore its victory and the defeat of capitalism are inevitable. However, we can have only extremely vague surmises about when and how the final decisive battles in this social war will be fought. All of that is nothing new.

Since we know nothing about the decisive battles of the social war, we can, of course, say just as little whether they will be bloody, whether physical force will play a significant role in them, or whether they will be fought exclusively with the means of economic, legislative, and moral pressure.

But one can surely say that, in all likelihood, in the proletariat's revolutionary struggles, the latter kind of means will predominate over those of the physical sort, that is, military force, more than was the case in the revolutionary struggles of the bourgeoisie.

One reason why the coming revolutionary struggles will probably be fought more seldom with military means, and this has already been explained often, is the colossal superiority of the armaments of the present-day governmental armies over the weapons that are available to the civil population, and that ordinarily make any resistance of the latter futile in advance.

In contrast, the revolutionary strata have today better weapons of economic, political, and moral resistance at their disposal than did the revolutionary strata of the eighteenth century. Only Russia is an exception.

Freedom of association, freedom of the press, and universal suffrage (maybe also universal compulsory military service) are, however, not merely weapons, in the possession of which the proletariat of the modern states is superior to the classes that fought the revolutionary struggles of the bourgeoisie. These institutions also shed light on the relations of power of

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the individual parties and classes and on the spirit animating them, a light that was lacking during the period of absolutism.

Then both the ruling and the revolutionary classes were feeling their way in darkness. As any expression of opposition had been made impossible, neither the governments nor the revolutionaries could know their strength. Each of the two parties ran the risk, one just as much as the other, of overestimating itself, as long as it had not tried its strength in struggle with its opponent, as well as the risk of underestimating itself as soon as it had suffered a single defeat and of giving up the struggle. This is certainly one of the most important reasons why, in the era of the revolutionary bourgeoisie, there were so many coups d'état that were crushed with one blow, so many governments that were toppled with one blow, why there was the succession of revolution and counterrevolution. Today things are completely different, at least in countries with reasonably democratic institutions. These have been called society's safety valve. If that is supposed to mean that in a democracy the proletariat ceases to be revolutionary, that it is content to express publicly its outrage and its sufferings, and that it renounces the political and social revolution, then this appellation is wrong. Democracy cannot eliminate the class antagonisms of capitalist society, nor can it stop their necessary final result, the overthrow of this society. But there is one thing it can do: it can prevent not the revolution, but many premature, futile attempts at revolution, and it can make many revolutionary insurrections superfluous. It furnishes clarity about the relations of strength of the different parties and classes; it does not eliminate their antagonisms, nor does it change their final goals. In its functioning, it tends to prevent the rising classes from sometimes undertaking to carry out tasks they are not yet capable of, and it tends also to deter the ruling classes from refusing concessions that they no longer have the strength to refuse. The direction of the development is not thereby changed, but its progress becomes more constant, more tranquil. The advance of the proletariat in the states with reasonably

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democratic institutions is not characterized by such striking victories as was the advance of the bourgeoisie in its revolutionary period, but also not by such great defeats. Since the awakening of the modern social-democratic labor movement in the 1860s, the European proletariat has had only one great defeat, in the Paris Commune in 1871. At the time, France was still suffering from the effects of the empire, which had withheld truly democratic institutions from the people; only a very small part of the French proletariat had attained to self-awareness and the uprising had been forced on it.

The democratic-proletarian method of struggle might appear to be more boring than that of the bourgeoisie's revolutionary period. It is certainly less dramatic and impressive, but it also requires many fewer sacrifices. That might be a matter of great indifference to *bel-esprit* literati, who regard socialism as an interesting sport and interesting material, but not to those who really have to wage the struggle.

This so-called peaceful method of class struggle, which confines itself to the non-military means of parliamentarism, strikes, demonstrations, the press, and similar means of exerting pressure, has all the more prospect of being retained in a given country, the more effective the democratic institutions are there, and the greater the population's self-control and political and economic understanding is.

In conditions that are otherwise the same, of two opponents the one most likely to remain cool is the one who feels himself superior to the other. In contrast, whoever does not believe in himself and his cause, loses his calm and self-control only too easily.

In all countries having modern civilization, however, the proletariat is the class that believes most in itself and its cause. To do that, it has no need at all to indulge in illusions; it only has to consider the history of the last generation to see that it has been advancing everywhere without interruption; and it needs only to follow the present-day development to draw therefrom the certainty that its victory is inevitable. Therefore it is not to be expected that in one of the countries where it is more

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highly developed, the proletariat will so easily lose its calm and self-control and commence a politics of adventurers. All the less will that be expected, the greater the education and the political understanding of the working class is, and the more democratic the state is.

In contrast, one cannot have the same confidence in the ruling classes. They feel and see that they are becoming weaker from day to day; they are becoming increasingly on edge and anxious and thus also more unpredictable. More and more they are being overcome by a mood in which it should surprise no one when they are suddenly seized by an attack of frenzy, in which, filled with blind fury, they hurl themselves at their opponent, to strike him down, heedless of all the wounds that they thereby inflict on all of society and themselves, and of all the terrible destruction they cause.

In view of the proletariat's political situation, it can be expected that this class will attempt to make do solely with using the afore-mentioned "legal" methods as long as possible. The danger that this effort will be thwarted lies chiefly in the jittery mood of the ruling classes.

For the most part, the statesmen of the ruling classes wish that such an attack of frenzy, if possible not only of the ruling classes, but also of all the indifferent masses, would occur very soon, before the Social Democratic movement is strong enough to put up resistance to it. That offers them the only prospect they now have of postponing the latter's victory for at least a few years. In this case, they are, to be sure, playing *va banque*, for if the bourgeoisie does not succeed in defeating the proletariat in this attack of rage, then it will only collapse all the faster in exhaustion and Social Democracy will triumph all the sooner. However, the fact is that the politicians of the ruling classes are, in large part, already in a mood in which they believe they have no other choice than to wager everything on a single card. Out of fear of revolution, they want to provoke civil war.

In contrast, the Social Democratic Party not only has no reason to claim as its own such a policy of desperation. It has, rather, every reason to see to it that the ruling classes' attack of frenzy, if it should prove to be

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unavoidable, is delayed for as long as possible, so that it does not occur until the proletariat has become strong enough to defeat and subdue its raging opponent with ease, so that this attack is the last one, and the devastations that it causes, the sacrifices that it imposes, are as limited as possible.

Therefore the Social Democratic Party must avoid, indeed, it must combat, everything that would be a pointless provocation of the ruling classes, that would give their statesmen a pretext for inciting the bourgeoisie and its adherents to a frenzy of deadly hatred for socialists [*sozialistenfresserische Tollhäuslerei*]. If we declare that revolutions cannot be made, if we consider it nonsensical, indeed pernicious, to want to foment a revolution, and if we act accordingly, this is done not to oblige the German public prosecutors, but in the interest of the militant proletariat. And in this regard, the German Social Democratic Party agrees with all of its fraternal parties. Thanks to this attitude, it has to date not become possible for the statesmen of the ruling classes to take action against the militant proletariat in the way they would like to.

As slight as the political influence of the Social Democratic movement still is, relatively speaking, nonetheless it is already too strong in the modern states for the bourgeois politicians to be able to treat it just as they want to. Minor measures and disciplinary punishments do them no good; they only serve to embitter those they affect, without deterring them or reducing their fighting capability. Every attempt, however, to implement measures that are so incisive that the proletariat would thereby be made incapable of struggle, conjures up the danger of a civil war that, regardless of its outcome, will in any case result in enormous devastations. Today, everyone who is to some degree discerning knows that. And no matter how much the bourgeois politicians might have reason to wish that Social Democracy be put to a test of strength as soon as possible, a test to which it is perhaps not yet equal at the present time, the bourgeois businessmen have no interest in an experiment that can ruin everyone of them, at least

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as long as they are in their right minds, as long as they have not been seized by the afore-mentioned attack of frenzy. Then, of course, the bourgeois can be brought to do anything, and the greater his fear, all the more wildly will he cry out for blood.

Today the interests of the proletariat require more imperatively than ever that everything be avoided that would lend itself to pointlessly provoking the ruling classes to a policy of violence. The Social Democratic Party is acting accordingly.

There is a tendency, though, that calls itself proletarian and social revolutionary, and that has set itself as its principal task, besides combating social democracy, the provocation of a policy of violence. What the statesmen of the ruling classes yearn for, and what alone could still serve to arrest the proletariat's march toward victory, is the chief activity of this tendency, which therefore enjoys the marked favor of the Puttkamers and their associates. The adherents of this tendency do not seek *to weaken* the bourgeoisie, but *to infuriate* it.

The defeat of the Paris Commune in 1871 was, as mentioned earlier, the last great defeat of the proletariat. Since then, it has constantly marched forward in most countries, thanks to its above-described method, more slowly than we wish, but more certainly than any of the earlier revolutionary movements advanced.

Since 1871, the proletarian movement has suffered set-backs only in a few instances, and each time it was due to the intervention of individuals with means that, following present-day linguistic usage, can be characterized as *anarchistic*, that are in accord with the tactic of "propaganda of the deed" advocated by the greatest-by-far majority of today's anarchists. I will mention only in passing the damage inflicted by the anarchists on the "Internationale" and the revolutionary insurrection in Spain in 1873. Five years after this uprising, there occurred the attack of general frenzy called forth by the assassination attempts of Hödel and Nobiling; had it not been for this frenzy, Bismarck would hardly have succeeded in forcing through the anti-socialist law. In any case, it would not have been

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implemented so rigorously as it was in the first years of its existence; the German proletariat would have been spared immense losses; its advance toward victory would not have been checked for a moment.

The next reverse suffered by the labor movement happened in Austria in 1884, as a consequence of the trickeries and brutalities of *Kammerer*, *Stellmacher*, and their associates. The advancing socialist movement was suppressed there with a single blow, with not even a trace of resistance; crushed not by the authorities, but by the general rage of the population, which blamed socialism for the acts of the afore-named anarchists.

A further set-back occurred in America in 1886. At that time, the labor movement had developed there rapidly and powerfully. It advanced with giant steps, so quickly that some observers already considered it possible that within a short time it would outstrip the European movements and place itself at their head. In spring of 1886, the working class of the union made a powerful start at winning the eight-hour day. The workers' organizations swelled to colossal size; strike succeeded strike; in the ranks of the workers, there was general exultant enthusiasm; and the socialists, everywhere in the van and the most zealous, were beginning to gain the leadership of the movement.

Then, on 4 May in Chicago, in one of the numerous clashes between the police and the workers that were taking place then, there occurred the well-known bomb-throwing incident. It has still not yet been determined who the perpetrator was. The anarchists who were executed on 11 November for this deed and their comrades who were condemned to long prison sentences became the victims of judicial murder. But the act accorded with the tactic that the anarchists had always preached; it aroused the rage of all of America's bourgeoisie, and it confused the workers and discredited the social democrats. The difference between the latter and the anarchists was not grasped; indeed, in many instances there was no desire to grasp it. The struggle for the eight-hour day ended with the defeat of the workers; the labor movement collapsed; and social democracy was

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reduced to insignificance. It is now only slowly beginning to gain strength again in the United States. The only injuries of considerable importance suffered by the labor movement in the last twenty years have been occasioned by deeds committed by anarchists or at least in accord with the tactics preached by them. The anti-socialist law in Germany, the state of emergency in Austria, the judicial murders in Chicago with its consequences, these were only made possible by such deeds....

However, the prospects of anarchism's once again taking hold of the masses anywhere are today slimmer than ever before.

The two most important causes making them receptive to anarchism were lack of political understanding and hopelessness, especially the apparent impossibility of achieving even the smallest improvement by political means.

In the first half of the 1880s, when the workers of Austria and the United States allowed themselves to be captured in droves by anarchist slogans, there was in the latter as well as in the former country an unusually rapid growth of the labor movement—at the same time there was an almost complete lack of leaders. The battalions of workers consisted almost entirely of ignorant, untrained recruits, without experience and without officers. And, as if that were not enough, it appeared to be impossible to weaken the dominance of capital through political struggle. In Austria, the workers did not have the suffrage and had no hope of attaining it in the foreseeable future by legal means. In America, the workers had no hope of putting an end to governmental corruption through political means.²

Not just in these two countries, however, but elsewhere, too, a current of pessimism was moving through the labor movement in the early 1880s.

In that regard, things have now become different and better everywhere.

In Austria, though, there was yet another circumstance that favored the emergence of anarchism: *the masses had lost confidence in the Social Democratic Party*. When the German proletariat's political and economic means of

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struggle — organizations and the press — were suppressed by the antisocialist law, then the anarchism that was then beginning to emerge was able to make the Austrian workers believe that the silenced party had given up the struggle and renounced its revolutionary principles. The Austrian Social Democrats who defended their German comrades did not thereby succeed in rehabilitating them in the eyes of the majority of the Austrian workers; but only in discrediting themselves. A public prosecutor, Count Lamezan, helped out the anarchists, whom he, of course preferred, and declared scornfully that the Social Democrats were nothing but "revolutionaries in nightgowns."

Even at the present time, the anarchists are devoting their most strenuous efforts to proving to the workers that the Social Democrats are revolutionaries in nightgowns. So far they have met with no success. But should it ever be possible for a significant anarchist movement to arise in Germany, then it could be engendered not by the agitations of the "independents," but solely either by a course of action followed by the ruling classes which produced hopelessness in the working classes and was extremely detrimental to the spread of political understanding among them, or by statements from our midst giving the appearance that we intended to deny our revolutionary principles. The more "moderate" we became, all the more would we provide grist to the anarchists' mill, and thus further the very movement whose efforts are most directed toward the replacement of the civilized with the most brutal forms of struggle. It can be said that at present there is only one motive that could impel the masses of the proletariat to abandon voluntarily the "peaceable" methods of struggle discussed above: the waning of faith in the revolutionary character of our Party. We could only endanger peaceable development with all too-great peaceableness.

There is no need to explain the obvious here: what disaster any appeasement would additionally bring about.

The opposition of the propertied would not be lessened, nor would reliable friends be gained thereby. In our own

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ranks, however, confusion would be sown; the tepid would be made even more tepid, and the energetic would be repelled.

The great moving force behind our successes is revolutionary enthusiasm. In the future we will need it more than ever, for the greatest difficulties lie before us, not behind us. All the worse would the effects of anything that might serve to paralyze this moving force.

Implicit in the present situation, however, is the danger that we easily appear to be more "moderate" than we are. The stronger we become, all the more urgent do our practical tasks become, all the more must we extend our agitation beyond the circle of the industrial proletariat, all the more must we take care not to engage in useless provocations or even to make empty threats. It is very hard to strike the right balance while doing all of that, to do full justice to the present without losing sight of the future, to enter into the line of reasoning of the peasants and the petty bourgeois without abandoning the proletarian standpoint, to avoid every challenge as far as possible and yet to create a general awareness that we are a party of struggle, of implacable struggle against the whole existing social order.

Thus the article of 1893. In it, too, we find a prophecy that has been fulfilled. What I feared in 1893 happened a few years later. In France, some of our party comrades became for a time a government party. The masses had the impression that Social Democracy had renounced its revolutionary principles. They lost their faith in the party – and so they fell, in no small part, into the hands of the most recent variety of anarchism: *syndicalism*, which, just like the old anarchism of the propaganda of the deed, aspires less to strengthen the proletariat than to unnecessarily alarm the bourgeoisie, to rouse them to frenzy, and to provoke ill-timed tests of strength, to which the proletariat is not equal under the existing conditions.

Among the French socialists, it is precisely the revolutionary Marxists who are most decidedly opposing these activities. They are combating syndicalism just as energetically as ministerialism; they consider the one to be just as harmful as the other.

Revolutionary Marxists today still hold the position that was elaborated by Engels and me in the articles from the years 1892-95 quoted above.

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We are neither men of legality at any price, nor are we revolutionaries at any price. We know that we cannot create historical situations as we would like to have them, that our tactics must be adapted to them.

At the beginning of the 1890s, I acknowledged that a tranquil further development of the proletarian organizations and of the proletarian class struggle on the existing governmental bases would best advance the proletariat in the situation of that period. I cannot, then, be reproached with needing to intoxicate myself with revolution and radicalism, when observation of the present-day situation leads me to the opinion that conditions have thoroughly changed since the beginning of the 1890s, that we have every reason to assume we have entered a period of struggles for the institutions of government and for the government itself, struggles that, accompanied by diverse vicissitudes, can drag on for decades, the forms and duration of which are at present still unforeseeable, but which will very probably in the foreseeable future bring about considerable shifts in power to the proletariat's advantage and could even lead to its exclusive rule in Western Europe.

The reasons for this opinion will be sketched out in the following pages.

Notes

1. "Bourgeois revolutions, like those of the eighteenth century, storm more swiftly from success to success; their dramatic effects surpass each other; men and things seem set in dazzling brilliants; ecstasy is the everyday spirit. But they are short-lived; they have soon attained their zenith, and a long-lasting hangover grips society before it learns to soberly assimilate the results of its stress-and-storm period. In contrast, proletarian revolutions ... criticize themselves constantly, etc." Karl Marx, *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* [Marx, Engels, *Collected Works*, 11:106]. In his comparison of the bourgeois with the proletarian revolution, Marx, in 1852, could of course not yet take into account the influence of democratic institutions on the latter.
2. In one of the latest issues of our fraternal organ in the United States, *Vorwärts*, there appeared a report taken from a speech given by Michael Schwab, one of the victims of the 1896 bomb affair, who was recently freed from prison. He acknowledged that the anarchist tactics were wrong and foolish. But he also explained why anarchism had been able to spread in Chicago in the 1880s: "It cannot be repeated often enough that these (the anarchist) tactics gained ground in Chicago only after a judge had decided that the falsifying of ballots was permitted when one was dealing with Communists. Most of you remember the election that placed Mr. Frank Stauber on the city council for the second time. The result of the election was falsified in the most brazen manner by two election judges. This was proven by the sworn testimony of police officers and other witnesses, as well as by the matter-of-fact confession of the accused in the concluding hearing, which had been delayed as long as possible. And the judge acquitted the falsifiers! There was general outrage among the workers, and they did not want to hear any more about the methods that they had employed earlier. Since then, many of us have learned that in politics you must not let yourself be guided solely by upsurges of emotion."

Growth of the Revolutionary Elements

We have seen that the Marxists have, in general, not at all proven to be such bad prophets as some people greatly like to make them out to be, but that some of them have, admittedly, been mistaken again and again in *one* point: the determination of the time at which they expected great, revolutionary struggles, considerable shifts of political power in favor of the proletariat.

What reasons do we have for assuming that the long-yearned-for time is now finally approaching, the time when the spell of political stagnation will be broken and a new, joyful life of struggle and victorious advance on the road to political power will again arise?

In his preface to Marx's *Class Struggles*, mentioned earlier, Engels correctly pointed out that in the present conditions, great, revolutionary struggles can be carried on only by great masses who know what they have to do. The times are past when small minorities could overthrow the government with a surprising, energetic action and put a new one in its place.

That was possible in centralized states, in which the entire political life was concentrated in a capital city that dominated the whole country, in the villages and towns of which there was no trace of political life and of connections between them. Whoever succeeded in paralyzing or winning over the military and bureaucracy of the capital could seize control of the government and, if the general situation called for a social revolution, work toward that end.

Today, in the age of railways and telegraphs, of newspapers and assemblies, of numerous industrial centers, of magazine-fed rifles and machine guns, it is quite impossible for a minority to paralyze the military forces of a capital city, unless they are already completely disorganized. It is, however, also impossible to confine any political struggle to the capital city. Political life has become the life of the nation.

Where these circumstances exist, a great shift of political power, one making untenable a regime that is inimical to the people, can be expected only when the following conditions all occur at the same time:

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1. The regime in question must be decidedly hostile to the mass of the people.
2. There must exist a large party of irreconcilable opposition, with organized masses.
3. This party must represent the interests of the great majority of the population and have its trust.
4. The confidence of its own instruments, the bureaucracy and the army, in the governing regime, in its strength and stability, must be deeply shaken.

In the last decades, at least in Western Europe, all of these conditions have not yet occurred all together. For a long time, the proletariat did not make up the majority of the population, and the Social Democratic Party was not the strongest party. When, in earlier decades, we expected that a revolution would soon happen, we were counting not just on the proletariat but also on the party of petty-bourgeois democrats as a revolutionary mass party, and on the petty bourgeois and peasants as masses standing behind that party. But in this regard, the bourgeois democratic party failed utterly. Today, it is no longer even an opposition party in Germany.

On the other hand, the unstable conditions that obtained until 1870 have ceased since then in the large countries of Europe, with the exception of Russia. The governments consolidated themselves; they gained strength and stability. And each of them was able to instill in the masses of its nation confidence that it represented their interests.

Thus it was just in the first decades of the emergence of a lasting and independent labor movement, that is, since the 1860s, that the possibilities of a political revolution became for a time ever worse, while the proletariat needed one ever more and, judging according to the pattern of the preceding seven decades, believed it near.

Gradually, however, conditions are changing in the proletariat's favor. The *organization of the proletariat* is growing. Perhaps that can be seen most strikingly in Germany. In the last dozen years, this growth has been especially rapid; in that period, we saw the organization of the Social Democratic Party swell to a *half million* members, and that of the trade unions, which are closely linked to it in spirit, to *two million* members. Their *press* grew at the same time: a work of their organization, not of private firms. Political daily newspapers increased the size of their collective printing to about *one million* copies; the trade-union newspapers, for the most part weeklies, to far more than that.

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That is an organized power of laboring, ruled masses such as history has never seen before.

The superiority of the ruling classes to the ruled was based hitherto not least of all on the former's control of the government's organized instruments of power, whereas the ruled classes lacked organization almost entirely, at least any organization extending over the territory of the whole country. True the working classes did not manage wholly without organization. In antiquity and in the Middle Ages, up to the modern era, it was, however, solely a matter either of organizations of single, limited *trades* or of single, limited *localities*; of *guilds* or of *communal organizations* and also mark communities. The commune, in particular, could sometimes provide very strong support against the central government—nothing could be more mistaken than equating state and commune without distinction and calling the latter, like the former, an organization of the same class rule. The commune *can* be that, very often is that; however, the commune can also become a representative of ruled classes within the state, when those classes constitute a majority in the commune and gain control. This function has appeared most forcefully in different centuries in the commune of *Paris*. This commune sometimes became the organization of the lowest classes of society.

Against the government of a large modern country, however, no single commune can maintain its independence today. It becomes all the more important, then, to organize the lower classes in large associations encompassing the entire territory of the nation and the most diverse trades.

This has been done most successfully in Germany. Not only in France, but also in Britain, with its old trade unions, both the trade union and the political organizations are still very fragmented. But no matter how much the organization of the proletariat grows, it will never, in normal, non-revolutionary periods, comprehend the totality of the laboring classes in a state, but always only an elite that is raised above the masses of the population by some special occupational, local, or individual characteristics. In contrast, the attractive power of class organizations in revolutionary periods, when even the weakest feel fighting fit and eager to do combat, depends only on the size of the classes whose interests they represent.

In this connection it is worthy of note that at the present time the wage proletariat already makes up the majority not just of the *population*, but even of the *eligible voters* in the German Reich.

So far, exact figures about the structure of the population of workers are not yet available from the 1907 census, only from that of 1895. If we

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compare the latter with the figures for the election of 1893, we find the following.

In 1893, the number of eligible voters was 10,628,292. On the other hand, in 1895 there were 15,506,482 gainfully employed males. If we subtract from this number those under twenty years of age and half of those aged from twenty to thirty years, then we have 10,742,989 as the approximate number of gainfully employed males of voting age. This number is almost the same as that of the eligible voters in 1893.

Of the gainfully employed males in the voting-age cohorts in agriculture, industry, and commerce (using the same manner of calculation as before), 4,172,269 were self-employed, and 5,590,743 were wage workers and salaried employees. If, however, we consider that in commerce and industry, of 3,144,977 business enterprises [*Hauptbetriebe*] more than half, 1,714,351, were one-man shops [*Alleinbetriebe*] and in fact fall, in the immense majority, within the proletariat's circle of interests, then it is surely not exaggerated to assume that in 1895, among the eligible voters, for about 3.5 million self-employed (employers being considered self-employed) who had an interest in private ownership of the means of production, there were more than 6 million proletarians, whose material interest called for abolition of this private ownership.

We may assume that in the remaining strata of the population, which also enter into consideration in this regard, although they are insignificant in size, there is a similar proportional relationship. This is especially true in the case of those "individuals of independent means not exercising a trade or profession," which category includes, on the one hand, rich capitalists living from dividends and rents, and, on the other, very poor recipients of disability and old-age pensions.

In the total gainfully employed *population*, however, the proletariat preponderates far more than among *the eligible voters*. For in the age cohorts that have not yet reached voting age, the gainfully employed are almost entirely proletarians.

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Thus the count was:

AGE	SELF-EMPLOYED	WORKERS AND SALARIED EMPLOYEES
18-20 years	42,711	1,335,016
20-30 years	613,045	3,935,592

as compared with:

30-40 years	1,319,201	3,111,115
40-50 years	1,368,261	1,489,317
over 50 years	2,102,814	1,648,085

In 1895, there were all together 5,474,046 self-employed and 13,438,377 workers and salaried employees in agriculture, industry, and commerce. If one subtracts from the number of the first a portion who are proletarians engaged in cottage industries and others disguised as "self-employed persons," then one can safely say that, even in 1895, the strata of the population having an interest in private ownership of the means of production made up hardly more than *one fourth* of the gainfully employed population, whereas they still formed a good *third* of the eligible voters.

Thirteen years earlier, in 1882, the proportions were not yet so favorable. If we compare the figures of the 1882 occupational statistics with those of the 1881 election, and calculate using the same standard as for 1895, we arrive at the following numbers:

YEAR	TOTAL NUMBER OF ELIGIBLE VOTERS	SELF-EMPLOYED ELIGIBLE TO VOTE	WORKERS ELIGIBLE TO VOTE
1882	9,090,381	3,947,192	4,744,021
1895	10,628,292	4,172,269	5,590,743
INCREASE	1,537,911	225,077	846,722

The number of one-man shops was approximately just as large in 1882 as in 1895: 1,877,872. But the number of non-proletarians among the self-employed was certainly even higher in 1882 than in 1895. We may assume, then, that the number of eligible voters having an interest in private ownership of the means of production was approximately just as large in 1882 as in 1895; that it was, in round numbers, 3.5 million. In contrast, the number of proletarians was about 5 million. Then the force intent on safeguarding private property would have remained the same,

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from 1882 to 1895; the number of its opponents among the eligible voters would have grown by 1 million.

In that period the number of socialist voters grew even more strongly, rising from 311,901 to 1,780,989. To be sure, the number of Social Democratic votes was artificially reduced in 1881 by the anti-socialist law.

Since 1895, capitalist development and with it the growth of the proletariat has, of course, advanced still farther. Unfortunately, the figures of the 1907 statistics, which shed light on that advance, are not yet available to us in their entirety for the *Reich*.

According to provisional reports, in the period from 1895 to 1907 the number of self-employed males in agriculture, industry, and commerce rose by 33,084, thus *almost not at all*; that of salaried male employees and of male wage-workers, hence of proletarians, rose by 2,891,228, thus *almost one hundred times* as much.

The proletarian element that already predominated in the population as well as in the electorate in 1895, has thus achieved an enormous preponderance since then.

Let us assume that today the percentage of eligible voters among the male self-employed and the male workers is the same as in 1895. Then we can supplement the foregoing table in the following manner:

YEAR	TOTAL NUMBER OF ELIGIBLE VOTERS	SELF EMPLOYED ELIGIBLE TO VOTE	WORKERS ELIGIBLE TO VOTE
1895	10,628,292	4,172,269	5,590,743
1907	13,352,900	4,202,903	7,275,944
INCREASE	2,724,608	30,634	1,685,201

The proletariat has the lion's share of the increase in the number of eligible voters, to an even greater degree than in the period from 1882 to 1895.

However, the figures of the last population census, in 1905, are also indicative of industrial progress.

In general, cities are more favorable to political life, to the organization of the proletarians and to the spread of our teachings than the countryside. Thus it is of great significance that the population of the latter is declining relative to the urban population.

How quickly this change is occurring is shown by the following table. By rural population is meant the population of communes with fewer than two thousand inhabitants; by urban population, that of communes with at least two thousand inhabitants. The count was:

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YEAR	RURAL POPULATION		URBAN POPULATION	
	Absolute Number	Percent	Absolute Number	Percent
1871	26,219,352	63.9	14,790,798	36.1
1880	26,513,531	58.6	18,720,530	41.4
1890	26,185,241	53.0	23,243,229	47.0
1900	25,734,103	45.7	30,633,075	54.3
1905	25,822,481	42.6	34,818,797	57.4

In the period of thirty years, then, the urban population more than *doubled*, whereas the rural population declined not only relatively, but also *absolutely*. While the urban population increased by 20 million, the rural population diminished by almost 1 million. When the Reich was founded, the latter still constituted almost *two thirds* of the population; today it makes up only somewhat more than *two fifths*.

As for the individual states of the Reich, it is those having the greatest industrial development that are growing most quickly. These states have the following percentages of the total population of the Reich's present day territory:

STATES OF THE REICH	1816	1855	1871	1905
Prussia	55.2	59.0	60.1	61.5
Saxony	4.8	5.6	6.2	7.4
COMBINED	60.0	64.6	66.3	68.9
Bavaria	14.5	12.5	11.8	10.8
Württemberg	5.7	4.6	4.4	3.8
Baden	4.1	3.7	3.6	3.3
Hesse	2.3	2.2	2.1	2.0
Alsace-Lorraine	5.2	4.3	3.8	3.0
COMBINED	31.8	27.3	25.7	22.9

Thus, in 1816 the territories of present-day Prussia and Saxony, taken together, contained 60 percent of the population then living in the present territory of the Reich; in 1905, however, they contained almost 70 percent. Southern Germany, which in 1816 still had more than *half* of the population of the territory that today belongs to Prussia and Saxony, in 1905 had only one *third* of this population. In 1816, the territories of present-day Prussia and Saxony had 15 million inhabitants; the four South German states, together with Alsace-Lorraine, had 8 million. In 1905, the

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former territories had 42 million inhabitants; the latter, 14 million. The former almost *tripled* their population; the latter did not even *double* theirs.

Thus the economic development is uninterruptedly operating to increase more and more, at the expense of the conservative elements, the revolutionary elements among the people, those elements who have an interest in the elimination of the present order of property and government, and to make their preponderance in the country ever greater.

However, these revolutionary elements are, of course, for the present revolutionary only *potentially*, not *actually*. They form the pool from which the "soldiers of the revolution" are recruited, but not all of them are such soldiers immediately.

Coming, for the greatest part, from the petty bourgeoisie and the smallholder peasantry, many proletarians continue to be influenced by their origins for a long time. They do not feel they are proletarians, but would-be property owners. They save their money to buy a bit of land or to open a miserable little shop or to exercise a trade as a "self-employed person" on a dwarfish scale with a couple of unfortunate apprentices. Others have lost hope of attaining those goals or have recognized how wretched they would thereby make their lives, but they feel too weak and are unwilling to gain better lives for themselves by joining with their comrades in struggle. They believe that they will advance more easily by betraying them. They become strikebreakers and yellow trade unionists. Yet others are further advanced, recognize the necessity of fighting the capitalists opposing them, but do not feel secure and strong enough to declare war on the entire capitalist system. They turn to the bourgeois parties and governments for help.

Indeed, even among those who, after a struggle, have arrived at recognition of the necessity of the proletarian class struggle, there are still enough who do not go beyond the compass of the existing society, who doubt or even despair of the proletariat's victory.

The fact is that the more rapidly the economic development and thus the proletarianization of the population proceed, the more numerous the hosts flowing from the countryside into the cities, from the East to the West, from the ranks of those owning a little property into the ranks of the propertyless, then the more numerous in the proletariat are the elements who have not yet grasped the significance of a social revolution for themselves, indeed, who do not even understand the class antagonisms of our society.

Winning them for the idea of socialism is an indispensable, but under normal circumstances an uncommonly difficult, task requiring the greatest dedication and intelligence, and which yet does not proceed as quickly as

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we would like. At the present time, our recruitment pool surely consists of *three fourths* of the population, probably even more; the number of the votes cast for us does not yet amount to *one third* of all who voted, not yet to *one fourth* of all the eligible voters.

But when times of revolutionary ferment come, the tempo of progress all at once becomes rapid. It is quite incredible how swiftly the masses of the population learn in such times and achieve clarity about their class interests. Not only their courage and their desire to fight, but also their political interest is spurred on in the most powerful way by the consciousness that the moment has arrived for them to rise by their efforts out of darkest night into the bright glory of the sun. Even the most sluggish become industrious; even the most cowardly, bold; even the most intellectually limited acquire a wider mental grasp. In such times political education of the masses takes place in years, that otherwise would require generations.

Once such a situation has occurred, once a regime has reached the point where it is threatened with collapse from its internal contradictions, and if there is in the nation a class having an interest in gaining political power, and also the necessary strength, then all that is required further is a party that has the trust of this class, that opposes the tottering regime in irreconcilable enmity, that has a clear understanding of the given situation, and that, therefore, can lead the rising class to victory.

For a long time this party has been the Social Democratic Party. The revolutionary class, too, exists and for some time has made up the majority of the nation. Can we also reckon with the moral collapse of the governing regime?

Moderation of Class Antagonisms

We have seen, as Engels observed in 1885, that since the French Revolution, which, with its after effects, lasted from 1789 to 1815, revolutions, great shifts of political power, have recurred in Europe about every fifteen to eighteen years: 1815, 1830, 1848-52, 1870-71. Engels therefore assumed that at the end of the 1880s, or the beginning of the 1890s, the next revolution would be due. In fact, at this time there occurred a significant political change, the downfall of the Bismarckian system, a revival of democratic and social-political endeavors in all of Europe. But the upturn was slight and short-lived, and since then two decades will soon have passed without a true revolution having taken place, at least in Europe proper.

What is the reason for that? Why the continuous unrest in Europe from 1789 to 1871, and why from that time on a stability of political conditions that has recently become complete political stagnation?

During the entire first half of the nineteenth century, until 1848, the strata of the peoples of Europe that were most important for the economic and intellectual and cultural life of that period were everywhere excluded from the government, which confronted them in part uncomprehendingly, in part with hostility, as the agent of the nobility and the hidebound clergy. In Germany and Italy, the fragmentation into many small states prevented any economic upswing. That changed greatly in the period from 1846 to 1870. In this time industrial capital gained victory over landed property, first in Britain, where the Corn Laws were repealed in 1846 and free trade gained the upper hand; or industrial capital succeeded at least in gaining equal rights with landed property, as in Germany and Austria. The intellectuals received freedom of the press and liberty of action; the petty bourgeoisie and the small-holder peasantry, suffrage. The national unification of Germany and Italy satisfied a long-felt painful yearning of these nations. It took place, to be sure, after the defeat of the revolution of 1848, not by means of internal movements, but through external wars. The Crimean War of 1854-56 brought down serfdom in Russia and compelled the czar's government to pay heed to the industrial bourgeoisie. In 1859, 1866, and 1870, the unification of Italy was accomplished; in 1866 and 1870, that of Germany, both incompletely, of course. In 1866, a liberal era in Austria was introduced; in Germany, too, the

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introduction of universal suffrage, of a certain freedom of the press and of association was begun. The year 1870 brought these beginnings to completion and gave France the democratic republic. And in 1867 in Britain, the efforts to achieve an electoral reform succeeded. It gave to the upper strata of the working class and to the lower strata of the petty bourgeoisie the suffrage that they had theretofore lacked. For all classes of the European nations, with the exception of the proletariat, governmental bases were thereby created on which they could found their lives. They had achieved, even if incompletely, what they had striven for unceasingly since the great revolution. Although all their wishes had not been and could not be fulfilled, inasmuch as the interests of the different strata of property owners are often quite contradictory, the incompletely satisfied strata did not feel powerful enough to strive for exclusive rule in the state, and what they lacked was not important enough for them to take upon themselves the risk of a revolution for its sake.

In European society, only one class still remained revolutionary, the *proletariat*, and above all the urban proletariat. In it the revolutionary impulse lived on. Although the political situation had been fundamentally changed by the accomplishment of these upheavals, the proletariat nevertheless continued to nourish the expectation, based on what it had learned from its experiences from 1789 to 1871, that is, almost a century, that there would soon be another revolution. It would, of course, not yet be a purely proletarian revolution, but rather a petty bourgeois-proletarian one, in which, however, the proletariat, in accordance with its increased significance, would take over the leadership. That was not the expectation, say, just of a few "doctrinaire Marxists," such as Engels and Bebel, but also of realist politicians completely untouched by Marxism, such as Bismarck. The fact that he considered exceptional laws against the Social Democratic Party necessary as early as 1878, even though at the time it had not yet attracted a half million votes not 10 percent of all voters or 6 percent of the eligible voters; and the fact that he then considered taking the desperate measure of provoking the Social Democratic Party to engage in street battles before it became too powerful—that can only be explained by attributing to him the belief that the proletarian-petty bourgeois revolution was imminent.

And in fact, there were a number of circumstances that lent credibility to this view, even disregarding the memory of the lessons taught by the experiences of the preceding century.

In the course of the 1870s, an *economic crisis* engulfed Europe, so severe, extensive, and persistent as had never been known before: it lasted into the second half of the 1880s. The misery in proletarian and petty-

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bourgeois circles, the faintheartedness in capitalist circles called forth by this crisis were intensified further by the concurrent effects of the *competition in foodstuffs*, especially that of America and Russia, which appeared to bring about the end of all commodity production in Western Europe's agriculture.

The universal misery of peasants, artisans, proletarians, the fading confidence of the bourgeoisie, the brutal persecutions of socialist activities — since 1871 in France, since 1878 in both Germany and Austria — everything seemed to indicate that within a short time a catastrophe would occur.

But the governmental bases that had been created from 1848 to 1871 accorded too much with the need of the masses of the population for them to collapse already then. On the contrary, the more threatening the danger of revolution appeared, which could now only be a proletarian, anti-capitalist one, all the more closely did the well-to-do classes rally around the governments. However, the petty bourgeois and the small holder peasants possessed in their new political rights, in particular their suffrage, very effective means of influencing the governments and of obtaining all kinds of material concessions from them. They tried all the more gladly to buy help from the government with political services, the more sinister their ally up to then in their political struggles had become for them.

Thus the mood of dissatisfaction in broad strata of the population, which arose from the economic depression and from political repression, produced only the slight change that, as we noted above, had as its most outstanding feature the fall of Bismarck in 1890, in addition to which Boulangism in France in 1889 could be mentioned as a start toward a violent change of the constitution. With those developments, however, even the *appearance* of a revolutionary situation came to an end.

Just at the time of that political shift, the industrial depression ceased that had persisted so long. A period of the most lively economic upswing began that lasted until recently, with few interruptions. The capitalists and their ideologues, professors, journalists, and other intellectuals, plucked up courage again. The artisans participated in the upswing, and agriculture, too, got back on its feet. It found an expanded market in the rapidly growing industrial population, especially for such products as meat or milk, which were less affected by foreign competition in foodstuffs. It was not the protective tariffs on agrarian products that saved European agriculture, for even in countries with free trade, such as Britain, the Netherlands, Denmark, it recovered, but instead the rapid upturn of industry since the end of the 1880s.

This upturn was, however, for its part a consequence of the swift expansion of the world market, the same expansion that had produced the flow of foodstuffs from distant lands to Europe and thereby the crisis of its agriculture. This expansion of the world market was brought about in

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particular by the development of the system of railways outside Western Europe. The lengths of the railways (measured in kilometers) were:

COUNTRY	PERCENT OF INCREASE			
	1880	1890	1907	1880-1907
Germany	33,634	42,869	58,040	72
France	25,932	36,895	47,823	84
Britain	28,854	32,297	37,150	29
Compared with:				
Russia	22,664	32,390	72,020	218
British India	14,772	27,316	48,106	226
China	11	200	6,698	60,800
Japan	121	2,333	8,067	6,666
America	171,669	331,599	487,506	183
Africa	4,607	9,386	29,798	547

The preceding table shows clearly how much more rapidly the construction of railways has proceeded in all the new areas of capitalism since 1880, and especially since 1890, than in the old countries.

At the same time, however, the means of maritime transportation have grown by leaps and bounds. The cargo-carrying capacity of ocean-going steamers, measured in tons, was:

COUNTRY	1882	1893	1907	1908
German Reich	249,000	783,000		2,256,783
Great Britain	3,700,000	6,183,000	10,838,531	
Norway and Sweden	140,000	392,000	1,347,533	
Denmark	67,000	123,000	404,946	
France	342,000	622,000	739,819	
United States	617,000	826,000	2,077,477	
Japan	40,000	108,000	1,115,880	

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These figures are a reflection of the immense expansion of the world market in the last two decades, which made it capable of absorbing, for a time, increased masses of commodities. Interest in the world market was thereby brought to the fore in all industrial countries, and with it also interest in the colonial policy, as a means of expanding a country's external market. To be sure, the acquisition of new overseas possessions beginning in the 1880s had only little to do with the expansion of the world market.

The newer colonial policy followed from that time onward concerned almost exclusively Africa, where alone much land was still "free" according to the notions of the European powers, that is to say, not occupied by a strong government. However, a look at the preceding table indicating the expansion of railways suffices to show how small Africa's share of that growth is. True, from 1880 to 1907, the length of its railways grew from 4,600 to almost 30,000 kilometers, but how insignificant that is in comparison with the growth of Asia's railways from 16,000 to 90,000 kilometers, and even of America's from 171,000 to 487,000 kilometers! And in Africa, the lion's share of the railways is to be found not in the new colonies that have been acquired since the 1880s, but in the old colonies and independent states, as the following table shows:

LENGTH OF RAILWAYS IN KILOMETERS

COUNTRY OR REGION	1880	1890	1907
Algeria	1,405	3,104	4,906
Egypt	1,449	1,547	5,544
Ethiopia	—	—	309
Cape Colony	1,457	2,922	6,123
Natal	158	546	1,571
Transvaal	—	120	2,191
Orange Free State	—	237	1,425
Rest of Africa	438	919	7,729
TOTAL	4,607	9,356	29,798

Thus, only 7,700 kilometers, one fourth of the railways in Africa, not even a whole percent (0.8 percent) of all the railways of the world, are located in those areas which — not all, but the greatest part of them — were occupied as a result of the more recent colonial policy of European powers. It is clear how little this colonial policy has had to do with the expansion of the world market in the past twenty years and with the revitalization of production.

However, this revitalization was obviously connected with the opening up of foreign markets, which, for its part, coincided in time with the newer colonial policy followed since the 1880s. The colonial policy was therefore associated with the economic upturn by the bulk of the

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bourgeoisie, and for the bourgeois of the European great powers there arose a new ideal that in the 1890s they began to oppose to socialism – the same socialism before which so many of their thinkers had already capitulated in the 1880s. This new ideal was the annexation of an overseas realm to the state's European territory: *imperialism*, as it has been termed.

The imperialism of a great power means, however, a policy of conquest. It means also hostility toward the other great powers that wish to conduct the same policy of conquest in the same overseas areas. Imperialism cannot be carried out without strong armaments, without large standing armies, without fleets that are capable of fighting battles in distant seas.

Into the 1860s, the bourgeoisie was, in general, hostile to the military, because it was hostile to the government. It hated the standing army that cost so extraordinarily much money and was the firmest support of a government inimical to the bourgeoisie. The bourgeois democrats regarded the standing army as superfluous since they wanted to confine themselves to their own country and did not want to wage wars of conquest.

Since the 1870s, an increasing sympathy for the army on the part of the bourgeoisie has been emerging, not just in Germany and France, where the war of 1870 had made the military popular (in Germany as the winner of brilliant victories; in France as the means of defense against devastations such as that war had brought). In other states, too, people are beginning to wax enthusiastic for the military, as a means both of repressing the internal enemy and of defeating the external one. The propertied classes are becoming friendlier to the army to the degree that they are becoming friendlier to the government. No matter how much they may be split by conflicts of interest, they are all united in their readiness to make sacrifices for military preparations, the most radical democrats with the most conservative feudalists. The proletariat, the Social Democratic Party, is alone opposed to these.

Thus the governments have gained strength greatly in the last decades, and the possibility that a government would be toppled, the possibility of the revolution, appeared to vanish into the unforeseeable future.

Opposition based on principle – which is not to be confused with the opposition to the government in office of a clique greedy for positions that has been excluded from the government – became restricted more and more to the proletariat, but many of its strata, too, lost their revolutionary impulse after the last great shift of political power in 1890.

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This power shift eliminated the worst manifestations of political repression of the proletariat in Germany and Austria. In France, the last remnants of the era of persecution that followed the uprising of the Commune had disappeared even earlier.

To be sure, social reform, legal protection of workers, did not make headway. It had prospered best in the time when industrial capitalism was already so far developed that its ravages of the health of the nation's populace were evident and the remedying of them was urgently demanded, but when industrial capitalists did not yet entirely control state and society, when the petty bourgeoisie, the land owners, and a part of the intellectuals still strongly opposed them, and when at the same time it could still be believed that it was possible to satisfy the proletariat, which had already started to become a power, with a little worker protection. Britain found itself in this situation as long ago as the 1840s. The most important of its labor-protective measures, the *ten-hour day* for female workers, became law at that time (1847).

Continental Europe lagged far behind. Only in 1877 was the federal factory law, making the *eleven-hour day* the maximum workday for both men and women, enacted in *Switzerland*. In 1885, Austria established the same maximum workday. The period of the power shift after Bismarck's fall then brought a few small advances in *Germany* and *France* also. In 1891, the German supplementary law on the regulation of the trades was enacted; it fixed the *eleven-hour* maximum workday for women (who had previously been unprotected). In 1892, this regulation was introduced in France, too.

That was all! Since then no advances have been gained that are worth mentioning. In Germany, we have come so far in the whole seventeen years that the ten-hour day for female workers has just been established. Male workers remain still completely unprotected.

In the area of worker protection and also of every other social reform, stagnation is total.

But the economic upturn since the end of the 1880s gave some strata of workers the possibility to improve their situation without the aid of legislation, through "direct action" by the trade unions, thanks to the rapidly increasing demand for workers.

This increasing demand is clearly shown by the decrease of emigration from the German Reich.

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YEAR	NUMBER OF EMIGRANTS
1881	220,902
1887	104,787
1891	120,089
1894	40,964
1900	22,309
1908	19,883

This rapid increase of the demand for workers created a relatively favorable position for a considerable number of strata of workers in relation to capital. The trade unions, which were able to develop only slowly in the first two decades of the new era after 1870 owing to the economic depression and the political repression in Germany, France, and Austria, now grew swiftly, especially in Germany, where economic development was the strongest. The German trade unions drew level with, indeed surpassed the British trade unions, those old prize fighters of the working class, and succeeded in achieving considerable improvements with respect to wages and hours and other working conditions. In Austria, for example, the number of trade-union members grew from 46,606 to 501,094 in the period from 1892 to 1907; in the German Reich, the members of the industrial federations of trade unions increased in number from 223,530 to 1,865,506 in the years from 1893 to 1907. In contrast in the same period, from 1892 to 1907, the British trade unions only grew from more than 1,500,000 to 2,406,746 members. They increased in size by 900,000 members; the German trade unions increased by 1,600,000.

However, the German trade unions did not surpass those of Great Britain only in rapidity of growth during this period. They were also a higher form of the trade union movement. The British trade unions had arisen quite spontaneously [*rein urwüchsig*], the children of practice pure and simple. The German trade unions were founded and led by Social Democrats, assisted by the rich theory of Marxism. Thanks to that fact, the German trade-union movement was able to assume much more effective forms. It replaced the fragmentation of the British trade unions by locality and trade with great, centralized industrial federations; it was much better able to check jurisdictional disputes of the individual organizations, and, lastly, it avoided the dangers of guild-like ossification and aristocratic exclusivity much more than the British trade-union movement did. Far more than the British trade unionists, those of Germany feel they are the representatives of the entire proletariat and not just of the organized

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members of their trade. The British are succeeding only slowly in shedding their traditional limitations. The leadership of the international trade union world is devolving more and more on the German trade unions—owing to the fact that they have been, whether consciously or unconsciously, more influenced by Marxist theory than their British comrades.

This magnificent development, of the German trade unions in particular, impressed the masses of the proletariat all the more deeply; the more social reform failed to progress in the parliaments, the fewer were the practical successes attained by the working class through political means during this period.

The trade unions and, in addition, the workers' co-operatives appeared able, without any political upheaval, simply by making use of the existing legal bases, to advance the working class ever further, to restrict the capitalists more and more, to replace capitalist absolutism with the "constitutional factory," and by means of this transitional stage to gradually attain to "industrial democracy" without any sudden, sharp rupture or catastrophe.

However, while the class antagonisms seemed to be moderated more and more, the elements were already growing that were to intensify them afresh.

Intensification of Class Antagonisms

At the same time the trade unions were being organized, another powerful organization was being formed which is threatening more and more to block the former's advance. This organization is the *employers' association*.

We discussed the *joint-stock ownership of firms* earlier. It took hold of commercial enterprises and banks long ago. Since the 1870s, it has spread also to industry in an increasing degree. We have called attention to the fact that the centralization of enterprises in a few hands, already begun by the advance of large-scale enterprise, was powerfully furthered by the joint-stock ownership of businesses. It promoted the expropriation of small fortunes, which are invested in shares of stock, by the masters of high finance, who manage to navigate the dangerous waters of modern economic life much better than the small "savers," and, indeed, in part artificially create the whirlpools and shoals of those waters. Through joint-stock ownership of firms, the small fortunes invested in shares of stock also become means of exercising power, which are entrusted to the masters of high finance, the rulers of the corporations, to use entirely as they will. Lastly, joint-stock ownership of firms permits individual financiers, individual millionaires, and large banks to gain control of numerous firms of the same kind even before acquiring full ownership of them, and thus to unite them in a common organization.

Owing to that fact, we have, since the 1890s, seen employers' organizations spring up like mushrooms in all the capitalist countries, assuming the most diverse forms depending on the laws in effect in the various countries, but all setting themselves the same goal: creating artificial monopolies in order to increase profit. This is accomplished partly by raising the prices of the products, thus through increased exploitation of consumers, partly by reducing the costs of production. The latter is achieved in different ways, all of which ultimately lead either to the laying-off or to increased exploitation of workers — often to both.

Even more easily accomplished than the joining together of employers in cartels and trusts in order to keep prices high, is their joining together in organizations to keep the workers down. In the latter sphere, there is no competition, no antagonisms among them; there, they are all

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of one mind. There, not only all the employers of the same branch of industry, but all those of the most diverse branches of industry, feel the same interest. No matter how great the antagonism with which they confront each other in the commodity market as buyers and sellers, in the labor market they find themselves fraternally united as buyers of the same commodity: labor power.

These employers' organizations are posing ever greater obstacles to the advance of the working class through organization in trade unions. Naumann exaggerates the strength of those organizations in his statements quoted earlier. The trade unions are not entirely feckless in relation to them. But the unions' victorious advance has been obstructed more and more in recent years. Everywhere they have been thrown onto the defensive; a strike is countered with a lock-out more and more often and more and more effectively. The favorable moments when the unions can still fight battles successfully are becoming rarer and rarer.

This situation is made even worse by the ever growing immigration of very undemanding foreign workers. That is a necessary consequence of the industrial upturn, which in point of fact has its origin in the expansion of the world market through steamships and railways, in the opening up by them of the most remote corners of the globe to the products of capitalist industry. In the newly opened regions, these products replace those of the indigenous industry, especially of the peasant cottage industry. On the one hand, new needs and desires are thereby awakened in the inhabitants of the newly opened regions; on the other hand, it is made necessary for them to acquire money. At the same time, the decline of the indigenous industry in those backward regions makes workers superfluous. They find no employment in their homeland, let alone money-earning employment. Now, the new means of transport, railways and steamships, which bring them the industrial products of the capitalist countries, also provide them with the possibility of traveling easily, as live return freight, to the industrial country that offers the prospect of paid work.

The exchange of men for commodities is an unavoidable consequence of the expansion of capitalist industry's market. First, in its own land, capitalist industry sends its products from the city into the countryside, and from the latter it draws not just raw materials and food, but also workers. If the industrial country becomes a commodity-exporting one, then it thereby also soon becomes a country that imports men. Thus it happened first in Britain, into which there poured numerous multitudes of workers, especially from Ireland, in the first half of the nineteenth century. This influx of less-developed elements is certainly a serious

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hindrance to the proletariat's class struggle, but it is linked, as a matter of natural necessity, with the expansion of industrial capitalism. It is unacceptable to do as the "realist politicians" of socialism love to, namely to praise this expansion as a blessing for the proletariat and to consider the immigration of foreigners a curse having nothing at all to do with that blessing. Under the system of capitalism, every economic advance is tied to a curse for the proletariat. If America's workers do not want an influx of Japanese and Chinese, then they must also oppose the transport by American steamships of American commodities to Japan and China and the construction there of railways with American money. The one is necessarily linked to the other.

The immigration of foreigners is a means of pushing the proletariat down, just like the introduction of machines, the substitution of women's labor for men's, of unskilled for skilled labor. The oppressive consequences of their immigration are a reason for opposing, not foreign workers, but the dominion of capital, to renounce any illusions that the rapid development of capitalist industry brings permanent benefits to the workers. That is always only temporarily the case. The bitter ending inevitably follows after. Now, too, that is again becoming apparent.

We saw above how greatly emigration from the German Reich has declined in the last twenty years. At the same time, however, the number of foreigners in the Reich has grown. They numbered:

YEAR	NUMBER OF EMIGRANTS
1880	276,057
1890	433,254
1900	778,698
1905	1,007,179

The census always took place on 1 December, when agriculture and construction are inactive. The many foreigners who work in Germany only in the summer, returning to their homelands in the fall, are not included in the census.

The hindering of the trade unions' struggle by the employers' associations and the immigration of undemanding, unorganized, defenseless foreign workers were felt with doubled sharpness when food prices rose.

For the standard of living of the European working class, the fall of food prices that began in the 1870s was of extreme importance, as we have already mentioned. It increased the purchasing power of the workers' nominal wages and moderated the effects of their decrease during the depression. After the depression had been surmounted, it caused real

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wages to rise even more rapidly than nominal wages, insofar as customs duties on agricultural products did not offset the beneficial effects of the low food prices.

But for some years, food prices have again been climbing.

Their change can be traced most clearly in Britain, where it is not hindered and affected by customs duties on agricultural products. According to one of Conrad's tables, the price in German marks for a ton of wheat (a ton equaling 1,000 kilograms) was:

YEARS	PRICE
1871-75	246.4
1876-80	206.8
1881-85	180.4
1886-90	142.8
1891-95	128.2
1896	123.0

In contrast according to the data published in the *Vierteljahrshefte zur Statistik des Deutschen Reichs* [Quarterly journal of statistics for the German Reich (1908, no. 4)], the recent changes of this price are as follows. In Liverpool, the price in German marks of La Plata wheat in the period from July to September was:

YEAR	PRICE
1901	129.1
1902	—
1903	139.3
1904	152.1
1905	144.8
1906	138.0
1907	160.0
1908	176.0

Of course, the prices for the different years rise and fall with the changes in the harvest. However, it nonetheless appears that the rising food prices are now not a passing, but a persisting phenomenon.

In view of the bankruptcy of Russian agriculture and the transformation of the United States from an agrarian into an industrial country, it can be expected that the massive influx of cheap food into Europe will gradually diminish and then stop.

American production of wheat, for example, stopped growing some years ago. It yielded:

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YEAR	AREA PLANTED, IN ACRES	YIELD IN BUSHELS	AVERAGE PRICE PER BUSHEL, AS OF 1 DECEMBER
	(million)	(million)	(cents)
1901	49.9	748	62.4
1902	46.2	670	63.0
1903	49.5	638	69.5
1904	44.1	552	92.4
1905	48.9	693	74.8
1906	47.3	735	66.7
1907	45.2	634	87.4
1908	47.6	664	92.8

It is clear that the production of wheat in America is declining more than it is increasing. The prices, however, have shown a marked tendency to rise.

The rings of capitalists, which, in addition, artificially drive up all prices and freightage, have the same kind of effect as the decrease of the food supply.

We are completely disregarding here customs duties on agricultural products, which, in addition to the foregoing, especially increase the burden on the working people through the rising food prices caused by the state.

If to all these circumstances an economic crisis is added, such as occurred at the end of 1907, with its aftermath of widespread unemployment, then the plight of the proletariat becomes terrible, as it is right now. But the proletariat must not expect that the end of the crisis will bring back for it the progress of the period from 1895 to 1907. The high food prices will remain and climb higher, and the influx of cheap workers from abroad also will not stop; on the contrary, it will start again with increased strength when better economic conditions return. But above all, the employers' associations will more than ever form an iron ring that will be impossible to break apart by mere trade union methods.

As important, indeed indispensable, as the trade unions are and will remain, we must not expect that they will again advance the proletariat as powerfully by purely trade-union methods as they succeeded in doing in the last dozen years. We must even reckon with the possibility that the proletariat's opponents will become strong enough to temporarily push it back again.

It is noteworthy that even in the last years of prosperity, when industry was working at its full capacity and complained about a continuous shortage of workers, the workers were no longer able to raise their real wages — that is, their wages measured not in money but in provisions — instead their real wages declined. That has been shown by private studies to be the case for various strata of workers in Germany. For *America*, we have an *official recognition* of this fact for the entire labor force.

Since 1890, the Bureau of Labor in Washington has conducted a study every year of the conditions of the workers in a number of firms belonging to

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the most important branches of industry in the United States. In recent years, the level of wages and the length of work time, as well as the workers' household budgets, what they consumed, and the prices of their foods were investigated in 4,169 factories and other work sites. The figures thus obtained were then compared with each other to show the improvement or deterioration of the workers' standard of living.

For each rubric, the average of the numbers for the period 1890-99 was made equal to 100. The number 101 indicates then an improvement of 1 percent relative to the average for the years 1890-99; the number 99 a deterioration of 1 percent. The bureau's study yielded the following findings:

YEAR	WEEKLY WAGES OF FULL-TIME WORKER	RETAIL PRICES OF PROVISIONS CONSUMED IN WORKER'S HOUSEHOLD	BUYING POWER OF WEEKLY WAGES
1890	101.0	102.4	98.6
1891	100.8	103.8	97.1
1892	100.3	101.9	99.4
1893	101.2	104.4	96.9
1894	97.7	99.7	98.0
1895	98.4	97.8	100.6
1896	99.5	95.5	104.2
1897	99.2	96.3	103.0
1898	99.9	98.7	101.2
1899	101.2	99.5	101.7
1900	104.1	101.1	103.0
1901	105.9	105.2	100.7
1902	109.2	110.9	98.5
1903	112.3	110.3	101.8
1904	112.2	111.7	100.4
1905	114.0	112.4	101.4
1906	118.5	115.7	102.4
1907	122.4	120.6	101.5

What this table shows us first is how matters really stand with the proletariat's "reformist progress." The last seventeen years have been unusually favorable ones for the working class; they were years of a tumultuous upswing in America, the like of which will perhaps never recur. And there is no working class that enjoys such freedoms as that of America; none is more politically realist, freer of all revolutionary ideologies that could distract it from day-to-day spadework to improve its situation. And yet, in the year of the 1907 upturn, when nominal wages rose on the average by 4 percent relative to the preceding year, real wages were only slightly higher than in 1890, when business was by no means doing splendidly. Of course, unemployment, uncertainty about one's

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physical survival, make an enormous difference between a period of economic crisis and a time of prosperity, but the buying power of the weekly wages of the full-time worker has changed only slightly in 1907 relative to 1890.

Nominal wages have, certainly, risen significantly. During the depression from 1890 to 1894, they fell from 101.0 to 97.7 (thus by more than 3 percent), but then rose continually, reaching 122.4 in 1907, an increase of almost 25 percent.

In contrast, the prices of *food* fell even more rapidly from 1890 to 1896 than nominal wages, dropping from 102.4 to 95.5, a decrease of almost 7 percent. Thus the buying power of the weekly wages did not fall to the same extent as their nominal value. From 1890 to 1894, real wages fell only from 98.6 to 98.0, thus by a mere 0.6 percent, whereas during the same period nominal wages fell by 3 percent. From 1894 to 1896, nominal wages rose from 97.7 to 99.5, while food prices continued to fall. So, in 1896 the worker has, with his nominal wages, a buying power of 104.2.

Since then, the worker's nominal wages have never again reached that buying power. All the prosperity notwithstanding, his real wages have remained for *more than a decade* lower than they were at that time. And that is supposed to be the workers' slow, but certain *progress*.

It is equally noteworthy that even in the midst of the wildest frenzy of business activity, when the capitalists were raking in the fattest profits, the workers' real wages did not even remain the same, but were already starting to *fall* again. It is true that from 1906 to 1907 real wages rose from 118.5 to 122.4, thus by almost 4 percent, but during the same time food prices shot up from 115.7 to 120.6, almost 5 percent, so that even then the buying power of the weekly wages fell by 1 percent. In reality, conditions are surely even worse than depicted here. American statistics do not have the reputation of painting too dark a picture, to the detriment of the existing conditions.

This gives a premonition that, even when the crisis is past and prosperity has begun again, the proletariat can no longer count on a repetition of the last era of brilliant trade-union successes.

But we repeat: That does not mean that trade unions have, for that reason, become powerless or even superfluous. They remain the proletariat's greatest mass organizations, without which it would be left defenseless against complete pauperization. The change of the situation does not lessen the trade unions' importance, but only modifies their methods of struggle. When they have to deal with the large employers' organizations, they can, admittedly, not directly harm them. However, their struggles with such organizations are growing to a gigantic size; they

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are able to convulse the entire society, the whole state, to influence governments and parliaments, if the employers are refusing to make any concessions.

Strikes in branches of industry dominated by the employers' associations and important for all economic activity are increasingly assuming a *political* character. On the other hand, occasions are arising with increasing frequency when in purely political struggles, for example, struggles for the suffrage, the weapon of the mass strike can be used successfully.

Thus the trade unions are coming to have more and more *political tasks*. In Britain and in France, in Germany and in Austria, they are turning increasingly to politics. That is the valid principle at the heart of the syndicalism of the Latin countries, which, however, as a consequence of its anarchist ancestry, is smothering this central principle in a chaotic jumble of anti-parliamentarianism. And yet the "direct action" of the trade unions can effectively serve only as a *supplement and reinforcement*, not as a *substitute* for the parliamentary activity of the labor parties.

The focus of proletarian action will again be shifted to politics, more than in the past two decades. Of course, the proletariat's interest will at first be directed again more to social reform, to worker protection. But in that area it will find a general stagnation that cannot be overcome under the existing relations of power, on the existing governmental bases.

By stagnation must not be understood a complete standstill, which is impossible in such a turbulent society as ours, but rather a rate of progress so slow that it becomes a standstill, indeed retrogression, when compared with the rate of radical technical and economic change and of the growth of exploitation. And increasingly, the ground must be prepared for these inexpressibly slow advances, and they must be gained forcibly, through great struggles, particularly trade union struggles, the costs and sacrifices of which are rapidly growing and outweighing the final positive results more and more.

It must not be forgotten that it is just our "positive" and "reformative" effectiveness that not only strengthens the proletariat, but also stimulates our opponents to ever more energetic resistance to us. And the more the struggles for social reforms again become political struggles, all the more do the employers' associations endeavor to make the parliaments and governments "get tough" with the workers and curtail their political rights.

Thus the struggle for political rights is once again advancing into the foreground in political life, and constitutional questions, the questions concerning the bases of political life, are becoming the crucial questions.

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The opponents of the proletariat are directing their efforts more and more toward limiting its political rights again. In Germany, after each great electoral victory by the proletariat, the threats to replace universal, equal suffrage with plural suffrage increase in number. In France and Switzerland, the military is savagely attacking strikers; in England and America, it is the courts that are restricting the proletariat's liberty of action, which the Parliament and the Congress lack the courage to confront openly.

But the proletariat cannot be content with warding off as much as possible such attempts to silence it. It will become increasingly hard pressed if it does not succeed in conquering new bases of political life, which permit it to continually make the government serve its class interests. Today that is necessary most of all, leaving aside Russia, in the *German Reich*. Even the suffrage for the Reichstag is turning more and more against the urban proletariat. The boundaries of the electoral districts for the Reichstag are still the same today as they were in 1871. We have seen, though, how the relationship between city and countryside has changed since that time. If in 1871 this relationship was still such that two thirds of the population lived in the countryside and one third in cities, it has now been reversed, but the boundaries of the electoral districts have remained the same. More and more they favor the countryside at the expense of the urban areas. In the last Reichstag elections, the Social Democratic Party received 29 percent of all votes cast, but only 10.8 percent of the seats, whereas the Center Party received 19.4 percent of the votes and 26.4 percent of the seats, and the Conservatives 9.4 percent of the votes, but 15.7 percent of the seats.

Although the last two parties together did not receive as many votes as the Social Democratic Party, they nevertheless obtained 42.1 percent of the seats, thus four times as many as the latter. With proportional representation the Social Democratic Party would have had a claim to 116 seats in 1907, instead of 43; the Conservatives and the Center Party together, 115 seats instead of 164.

The continued existence of the present electoral-district boundaries amounts to a plural suffrage of the most backward strata of the population. A plural suffrage, the inequality of which is increasing from year to year, is increasing in the same proportion in which the urban proletariat is growing in size.

Moreover, we have a system of balloting that makes the proletariat's political dependency on the propertied classes effective in the countryside and the small towns, where this circumstance is especially significant, almost to the same extent as its economic dependency, since the ballot

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envelopes now in general use render the secrecy of the ballot even more ineffective than the previous system did.

However, it is certainly true that the elimination of these disadvantages would not of itself solve the problem. What is the use of the growth of our influence, our power in the Reichstag, if the Reichstag itself has no influence and power. First, power must be conquered for it. The resistance to the establishment of a truly parliamentary regime must be overcome; the government of the Reich must be made a committee of the Reichstag.

The Reichstag is suffering, however, not only from the independence of the Reich government from it; but also from the Reich's still not at all being a proper unitary state. Its powers and responsibilities are extremely limited. At every step it knocks against the sovereignty of the individual Lander, of their governments and their diets, and against their narrowminded particular interests. In all likelihood, it would be able to deal easily with the small Lander, but an immense obstacle is blocking its way: Prussia and its three-class diet. It is above all Prussian particularism that must be broken; its diet must cease to be the stronghold of all reaction. Conquest of secret and equal suffrage for the North German diets, in particular that of Prussia, and also the elevation of the Reichstag to the ruling power are among the most urgent political tasks of the day.

However, if the transformation of Germany into a democratic state succeeds in this manner, that does not yet suffice to help the proletariat move forward. The German proletariat, which already makes up the great majority of the population, will certainly then be able to control legislation, but this will not avail it much if the state does not have at its disposal abundant funds, which are indispensable for social reforms.

At the present time, though, all the state's funds are being consumed by *militarism* and *navalism*. The constant growth of the expenditures for these purposes is the reason why the present-day state is neglecting even such socially useful tasks, which are in the most urgent interest of the entire population, not just of the proletariat, as the improvement of the system of primary and secondary education, of transportation links—canals and roads—etc., projects that would greatly increase the country's productivity and competitive capability, and that are therefore imperative even in the purely business, capitalist interest.

But no large sums of money can be made available for those projects, for the army and the navy are devouring everything, and will devour ever more as long as the present system continues to obtain.

Abolition of the standing army and disarmament are absolutely necessary if the state is to be able to carry out significant social reforms. That is

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increasingly acknowledged even by bourgeois elements, but they are unable to accomplish it. Prattling about peace in the manner of [Bertha von] Suttner [pacifist, author of the novel *Die Waffen nieder!* (Lay down your arms!), published in 1889; received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1905] does not bring matters a single step forward.

The present armaments race is primarily a result of the *colonial policy* and *imperialism*, and it does not help to propagandize for peace as long as one continues to go along with this policy. Whoever is in favor of the colonial policy must also be in favor of militarism and navalism, for it would be nonsensical to set oneself certain goals and to reject the means for obtaining them. This should be reflected on by those of our friends who enthusiastically call for world peace and disarmament, who attend any and all bourgeois peace congresses, and who at the same time consider the colonial policy necessary, to be sure an ethical, socialistic colonial policy. They are heading for the position of those Prussian progressives of the 1860s who, as bourgeois politicians, recoiled in horror from the revolution, who strove to achieve the unification of Germany not by revolution, but through the victories of the Hohenzollerns, but who at the same time, as *democratic* politicians, sought to limit militarism and denied to the Hohenzollerns as much as possible the instruments of military power necessary for carrying out their task. They perished from their own contradiction.

Whoever makes propaganda for the colonial policy must also be resolved to accept the armaments race. Whoever wants to put a stop to the latter must convince the population of the futility, indeed the perniciousness, of the colonial policy.

In the present situation, those are the most urgent political tasks of the militant proletariat; that is the "positive" policy it must implement. Until these tasks have been carried out, it cannot hope for any further significant "reformist" advance, given the growth of the employers' associations, the rise of food prices, the influx of less-developed strata of workers, the general standstill of all legal social reform, the increase of the governmental expenditures with which it is being burdened.

Improvement of the suffrage for the Reichstag; conquest of equal and universal suffrage for the diets of the Lander, especially those of Saxony and Prussia; achievement of a dominant position for the Reichstag in relation both to the governments and to the diets of the individual Länder — those are tasks that concern in particular the German proletariat, which must still gain complete democracy and the unity of the Reich through struggle. The fight against imperialism and militarism is the common task of the entire international proletariat.

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There might be some who believe that the execution of these tasks will not be enough to advance us. Is not Switzerland a state that already fulfills all these conditions: the most complete democracy, a militia system, the absence of any colonial policy? And yet even in Switzerland social-welfare policy is making no progress; the proletariat is exploited and oppressed by employers just as much there as elsewhere.

The first reply to that objection is that Switzerland is not escaping the consequences of the armaments race going on around it, but is also assiduously arming itself, which is costing it not a little money. A portion of the military expenditures is being borne by the cantons; nevertheless, the expenditures of the confederal government have grown by the following leaps and bounds:

YEAR	AMOUNT IN MILLIONS OF FRANCS
1875	39
1885	41
1895	79
1905	117
1906	129
1907	139
1908	151

Military expenditures, in particular, have been growing rapidly, but so have the revenues from *customs duties*. They were:

YEAR	CONFEDERATION'S MILITARY EXPENDITURES (millions)	REVENUES OF THE FINANCE AND CUSTOMS DEPARTMENT (millions)
1895	23	4
1905	31	64
1906	35	62
1907	42	73
1908	40	70

If the revenues and expenditures of the postal and telegraph systems, which are almost the same (63 million francs of expenditures and 66 million francs of revenues), are subtracted, then we find that in 1908 revenues amounted to 81 million francs, of which 70 million were derived from customs duties, and expenditures amounted to 88 million francs, of which 40 million were for the military and 6 million for the interest on the public debt.

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Thus, even in Switzerland, militarism is swallowing the lion's share of the state's revenues, and its requirements are growing rapidly.

Further, however, it makes an immense difference if a right is inherited or received as a gift, or if it has been conquered through a tenacious struggle requiring many sacrifices.

Surely no one will be so naive as to maintain that from a military state and from absolutism we will, imperceptibly and without a struggle, "grow into" democracy, from conquering imperialism into the league of free peoples. The notion of such a gradual growth could originate only at a time when it was believed that the entire further development would take place exclusively in the economic sphere, without any change of the relations of political power and of political institutions being necessary. As soon as such changes prove to be urgently necessary for the proletariat, if it is to be able to make further economic progress, then, by the same token, political struggles, shifts of power, and upheavals are shown to be necessary.

In these struggles, the proletariat must grow immensely. It cannot be victorious in them, it cannot achieve democracy and the elimination of militarism (the goals I mentioned above) without itself attaining to a dominant position in the state.

Thus the conquest of democracy and the abolition of militarism must have wholly different effects in a large modern state than those the militia system, an age-old tradition, and the republican institutions in Switzerland are now having.

That will be all the more true, the more these transformations are gained by the proletariat alone through struggle. And it has no prospect of loyal allies in the coming struggles. Formerly, we counted on allies from the bourgeois camp, especially petty bourgeois and small-holder peasants. We have seen that for a long time Marx and Engels very much expected the petty bourgeois democrats to join in the revolution at least at the beginning, as they still did in 1848 and in 1871 in Paris. When the democratic politicians and parties were failing more and more, we Marxists still believed that we would be able to attract, to interest in our revolutionary goals, sizeable numbers of petty bourgeois and small-holder peasants. This expectation was still expressed in my article of 1893, cited earlier, and expressed even more strongly in Engels's preface of 1895:

If it continues in this fashion, by the end of the century we shall have the greater part of the *middle strata* of society, petty bourgeoisie and small peasants, and we shall grow into the decisive power in the land. (Frederick

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Engels, "Introduction to Karl Marx's *The Class Struggles in France 1848 to 1850*." Marx, Engels, *Collected Works*, 27:521-22)

This expectation was not fulfilled. Here, too, it is shown again that we Marxists were in error with our expectations and "prophecies" when we overestimated the revolutionary sentiment of the petty bourgeoisie. But one can also see how unfounded the criticism is that Marxist fanatic dogmatism expels such elements from the party. When Engels opposed the French agrarian program in 1894, and when I, one year later, opposed the German one (Frederick Engels, "The Peasant Question in France and Germany." Marx, Engels, *Collected Works*, 481-502; Karl Kautsky, "Unser neuestes Programm" [Our newest program], *Die Neue Zeit*, 13/2 [1895]: 557-65, 586-94, 610-24), we did not do so because we considered it superfluous to win over the peasants, but only because we considered the proposed manner of winning them over to be wrong. Since then fellow party members in France, Austria, and Switzerland have tried their luck with the peasants using this approach, without success.

The same is true of the petty bourgeoisie. It can be said of broad middle strata that at the present time they are harder to win over to our side than ever before, no matter what kind of socialist propaganda is carried out among them. This view does not have its origin in Marxist "orthodoxy" — we have seen that Marxism erred more through too great than through too small expectations in this respect. It is a result of bitter lessons learned from experiences of recent years. Our Marxist "fanatic dogmatism" has played a part in this matter only insofar as it has made it easier for us to acknowledge these lessons and to grasp them, that is, to uncover their causes — the absolutely necessary pre-condition for a successful "Realpolitik."

Here, too, we find again that our "positive" work, as soon as it strengthens the proletariat, by that very fact also intensifies its antagonism to the other classes.

Some of us expected that the capitalists' cartels and rings, as well as the customs policy, would bring the middle strata, which suffered so greatly from them, into our ranks. In fact, just the opposite happened. The customs duties on agricultural products and the employers' associations arose at the same time as the trade unions. Thus, the *owners of craft businesses* found themselves hard pressed from all sides. The customs duties and the employers' associations drove up the prices they had to pay for food and raw materials, while the trade unions raised the level of wages. Admittedly, this wage increase was, for the greatest part, only a

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rise of nominal wages, not of real wages; prices rose more than wages. Nonetheless, the wage struggles incensed the small-shop-owning master craftsmen, who saw in the employers' associations and the parties favoring extortionate customs duties their allies against the organized workers. The latter, not customs duties and cartels, were, they thought, responsible not just for the rise of nominal wages, but also for the high prices of raw materials and apartments, which were caused by the wage increases!

As for the *small merchants*, they, too, found themselves hard pressed by the rising prices, since the buying power of their customers, who were mostly workers, did not increase at the same rate. They directed their rancor all the more readily against the workers, instead of the customs policy and the employers' associations, the more the workers sought to escape the consequences of the price increases by eliminating intermediate trade through formation of consumer co-operatives.

A rise in prices always intensifies the antagonism between buyers and sellers. It also made greater the antagonism between the proletarians as buyers of foodstuffs and the *peasants* as sellers of them.

It must not be forgotten that in the commodity market the worker plays a special role. Everyone else enters that market not merely as a buyer, but also as a seller of products. What a vendor of commodities loses as a buyer of other commodities because of a general rise in prices, he gains from the rise in the price of his own commodities. Only the worker comes to the world market solely as a buyer, not as a seller of products. His labor power is a commodity of a unique kind with its price governed by its own laws, with the result that wages for labor do not simply follow the general changes of prices. For labor power is, after all, not a product separated from man, but is rather inseparably linked with his very life; its price is subject to physiological, psychical, and historical conditions that play no role with regard to the other products, and that impart to nominal wages a greater moment of *persistence* than is proper to the prices of products. Nominal wages follow the fluctuations of the prices of products only slowly and only to a certain extent. Thus, when prices fall, the worker wins more than other buyers of products; when prices rise, he loses more. His position in the commodity market is opposed to the seller's; although he produces everything and consumes only a portion of his products, his position is that of the consumer, not of the producer. For the products that he produces belong not to him but to his exploiter, the capitalist. It is the latter who appears in the commodity market with the products of the wage worker's labor, as their producer and seller. The worker appears in that market only as the buyer of provisions.

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Hence his antagonism to the sellers of provisions, thus also to peasants, to the extent that they face him as sellers. It was precisely the workers who opposed the peasants most energetically, not only in the question of customs duties on agricultural products, but also in other matters, for example, attempts to raise the price of milk.

Peasants who employed wage workers were no less incensed by the wage increases and the improvements of working conditions in industry. The period of industrial prosperity, of the strengthening of the trade unions, and of their victories was also the period when there was a shortage of workers in agriculture. Not just farm laborers of both sexes, no, even the peasants' children streamed to industry in growing multitudes, fleeing the barbaric working conditions in agriculture. The ones responsible for the resulting lack of workers in the countryside were, of course, the damned Reds.

Thus it has happened that growing strata of those classes of the population that formerly constituted the heart of the petty-bourgeois democratic movement and were vigorous champions of the revolution, and then were at least allies of the revolutionary proletariat, even if only tepid ones, now have been transformed everywhere into nothing less than its most enraged enemies. So far, this has happened least in "Marxism-infected" Germany; it has occurred far more in France, Austria, and Switzerland.

In the large countries, the hostility of the middle classes to the proletariat is increased still more by their opposed positions on the question of imperialism and colonial policy. Whoever does not accept and advocate socialism, whoever rejects it, has absolutely no other choice, if he does not want to despair, than to believe in the colonial policy. It is the only prospect that capitalism can still offer its partisans. With that policy, however, is logically linked acceptance of militarism and navalism. Even those middle strata that do not share the interests of the crafts, of intermediate trade, of food production, namely, the *intellectuals*, insofar as they are unable to accept socialism, will for that reason be repelled by the proletariat and its farther-sighted representatives because of its condemnation of imperialism and militarism. Messrs Brentano, Naumann, et al., who have such a friendly attitude toward the proletariat's trade unions and consumer cooperatives, as well as its strivings for democracy, are all enthusiastic supporters of navalism and expansionism, and are friends of the Social Democratic Party only as long as it is not a question of imperialism and its instruments.

Thus this policy appears destined to make the isolation of the proletariat complete and to thereby condemn it to political sterility just at

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the time when it needs more than ever to demonstrate and bring to bear political power.

And yet it is precisely the policy of imperialism that can become the point of purchase at which leverage will be applied to overturn the dominant system.

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A New Age of Revolutions

We have seen that in Switzerland the costs of militarism are rapidly rising. That is, however, only a pale shadow of what the great military powers are expending. Let us consider just the German Reich. There (according to *Das Statistische Jahrbuch für das Deutsche Reich* [Statistical yearbook for the German Reich]) millions of marks were spent for:

	1873	1880-81	1891-92	1900	1909
Army	308	370	488	666	814
Navy	26	40	85	152	409
Colonial					
Administration	—	—	—	21	32
Pension Fund 21 18 41 68 115					
Interest on					
National Debt	—	9	54	78	171
TOTALS	355	437	668	985	1,541
ANNUAL INCREASE		12	21	35	62
REICH'S TOTAL					
EXPENDITURES	404	550	1,118	2,056	2,850
				or	
				1,640*	
ANNUAL INCREASE		21	52	58	88

* Beginning in 1900 the expenditures for the Reich's postal and railway systems and printing office appear in the budget of expenses, where they had not been listed previously. In 1900, they amounted to 416 million marks.

It is manifest that the expenditures are growing incessantly, but at a continuously increasing rate. In the first decade of the Reich's existence, they grew by 21 million marks per year; finally in the last decade, by 88 million marks per year. In the most recent years, the annual increase even reached hundreds of millions (1905: 2,195 million; 1906: 2,392 million; 1907: 2,810 million; 1908: 2,791 million; 1909: 2,850 million; within four years, hence 700 million).

The principal increase is in the costs of military armaments — more in the expenditures for the navy than in those for the army. While the population of the Reich grew from 50 to 64 million from 1891 to 1909, thus by *one fourth*, in the same period the costs of the army almost *doubled*, those of the pension fund and the servicing of the national debt *tripled*, the

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costs of the navy almost *quintupled*. And there will be no stopping of this furious growth as long as the present regime is not changed *from top to bottom*. The constant radical modification of technology, which follows from the capitalist use of machinery and the introduction of natural science into production, is also taking hold of military affairs. Here, too, it is creating an uninterrupted competition of new inventions, a constant devaluation of what already exists, a constant expansion of the instruments of power, not, however, as in the mode of production, resulting in the constant increase of the productivity of labor, but instead in constant expansion of the devastations of war and constant increase of the unproductive waste of peace.

In addition to the upheaval effected by technology, it is the constant enlargement of the sphere of domination, or at least of influence, of every great power through the policy of colonial expansion, which makes it increasingly necessary that it expand its instruments of power. As long as the policy of expansion continues, the madness of the armaments race must increase until complete exhaustion is reached. Imperialism, however, as we have seen, is the only hope, the sole idea for the future that still beckons to currently existing society. Aside from this hope, there is only one alternative: socialism. And thus this madness will grow worse until the proletariat becomes strong enough to determine the state's policies, to overcome the policy of imperialism, and to replace it with that of socialism. The longer the armaments race lasts, all the heavier will be the burdens that it imposes on every people. All the more, however, does each class try to foist those burdens on the other classes; all the more does the armaments race intensify class antagonisms.

In the German Reich, it is, of course, the workers on whom the greatest burden is foisted. That was bad enough even in the period of the business upturn, of low food prices, and of the trade unions' progress. It is becoming intolerable in the period of economic depression, of rising prices, and of the ascendancy of the employers' associations.

But the growing tax burden is not merely diminishing the worker's income, reducing the buying power of his wages; it is also threatening in the extreme the very industrial progress that allegedly is supposed to be promoted by the policy of colonial expansion.

The United States is the most dangerous competitor of German industry. In relation to the former, the latter is placed at a disadvantage by the German system of protective tariffs. To be sure, America has even higher protective tariffs, but only for industrial, not for agricultural products. It has at its disposal the cheapest foodstuffs and produces almost all raw materials itself. Furthermore, it has the advantage of not

having any land power worth mentioning as a neighbor. It has no need to withdraw a half million men from production year in, year out, by having them fruitlessly play soldier.

The more militarism increases in Europe, all the more powerful does the industrial superiority of the United States grow, all the more is Europe's economic progress slowed down, and all the more unfavorable does the economic situation of the European working class become. And, in order to even promote this process, it is asked to make the most painful sacrifices.

The United States has, to be sure, also entered upon the path of imperialism and thus upon that of increased armaments. Since its war with Spain, its expenditures for army and navy have been growing. Nevertheless it is less harmfully affected by that growth than the European great powers because, unlike the latter, it does not have to keep a large standing army in the homeland. In all of the United States, there are only seventy thousand soldiers. As in the sphere of industrial competition, the United States can participate in the armaments race the longest without losing its breath.

In the United States, for the years and the categories listed, the numerical data were, in millions of persons or dollars (see p. 123). As one can see, the national debt has not been growing by and large. Until 1890 it decreased considerably. From that point on, it grew, certainly, just as the expenditures for the army did, owing to the war with Spain. But since then, it could be reduced again until 1907, despite growing expenditures for the army and navy.

The table of exports shows, however, how rapidly the exportation of manufactured goods from America has been growing, how much it is presenting itself in the world market increasingly as an industrial, not an agricultural, country.

In 1908 of the total German export of commodities, having a value of 7,000 million marks, 4,300 million marks (62 percent) were manufactured goods. In the United States, of a total export of domestic products having a value of 8,000 million marks (\$1,835 million), more than 3,000 million marks (\$750 million) were manufactured goods. In 1890 the value of the German export of manufactured goods amounted to 2,147 million marks; that of the total American export to only about 800 million marks (\$1.79 million). Thus in the same period of time, the former increased by 150 percent; the latter by 300 percent.

It is plain that, as an industrial country, the United States has already closed in on us to a considerable degree.

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YEAR	1880	1890	1900	1907	1908
Population in millions	50	63	76	86	87
Interest Bearing National Debt in millions of dollars	1724	725	1023	894	897
Army Budget in millions of dollars	38	45	138	125	140
Navy Budget in millions of dollars	14	22	56	98	119
Food Stuffs as percent of total exports	56	42	40	28	28
Raw Materials as percent of total exports	29	36	24	32	30
Manufactured Goods as percent of total exports	15	21	35	40	42

And in this situation, while from 1900 to 1908 the United States reduced its national debt by \$130 million (a half billion marks), Germany, in the same period, increased its debt by 1.5 billion marks. And since then, colossal new increases of expenditures and a tax raise of a half billion marks have been put into effect without satisfying the Moloch.

Although the working class is most strongly affected and weighed down by such burdens, they also encumber industry and make its competitive struggle more difficult. This, however, is finally passed on to the worker, on whose back this struggle is fought out. There are, though, limits to the load that can be placed on the worker, beyond which it cannot be increased, and thus the armaments race must at last bring even industrial progress itself to a halt.

At the same time, however, the armaments race more and more intensifies national antagonisms and increases the danger of war, even though it is supposed to serve the preservation of peace. For each government, the continuing progressive armament, each stage following hard on the heels of the last, becomes increasingly intolerable, but none of the ruling classes looks for the roots of that plight in the policy of expansion that they are pursuing. They cannot allow themselves to see the reason there because the last refuge of capitalism lies in that policy. Thus each seeks to ascribe responsibility only to the other; the Germans to the British, the British to the Germans. That puts everybody more on edge and

makes them more suspicious, which only provides a new stimulus to continue the progressive armament with increased rapidity, until finally the point is reached where a terrifying end is preferable to an unending terror.

This situation would long ago have led to war as the only way, aside from revolution, to escape from this insanity of reciprocally forcing up national expenditures, were it not for the fact that behind war the alternative of revolution was nearer at hand than behind armed peace. The growing strength of the proletariat is what has prevented every European war for the last three decades and is now causing every government to shrink back in horror from such a conflict. But the great powers are heading toward a situation in which the rifles will finally fire of themselves.

Another phenomenon is working to the same end — a phenomenon destined, even more than the armaments race, to carry the policy of colonial expansion to the point of absurdity and to thereby deprive the currently existing mode of production of its last possibility of development.

The colonial policy or imperialism is based on the assumption that only the peoples possessed of European civilization are capable of independent development. The men of other races are considered children, idiots, or beasts of burden, according to the degree of unfriendliness with which one treats them; in any case as beings having a lower level of development, who can be directed as one wishes. Even socialists proceed on this assumption as soon as they want to pursue a policy of colonial expansion, an ethical one, of course. But reality soon teaches them that our party's tenet that all men are equal is no mere figure of speech, but a very real force.

It is certainly true that the peoples outside the pale of European civilization have for centuries been almost completely defenseless against the latter, have always been incapable of sustained resistance to it. However, that was due not to their being naturally at a lower level of development, as the overbearing arrogance of the European bourgeoisie believes, which arrogance is given scientific expression in the fantasies of our racial theorists. Those peoples were simply crushed by the superiority of European technology, certainly also of the European intellect, the superiority of which, however, is based in the final analysis also on that of technology. The peoples of non-European civilization — with the exception, perhaps, of a few very backward tribes having a few thousand members — are certainly capable of absorbing that civilization's intellectual life, but they have heretofore lacked the necessary material conditions for doing so.

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For a long time, the expansion of capitalism changed this situation only slightly. The capitalist exporters at first took into the regions lying outside European civilization (to which, of course, America and Australia now also belong) only capitalist *products*, not capitalist *production*. In this activity, they confined themselves chiefly to the waterways; the sea coasts and a few large rivers. This state of affairs underwent a tremendous change in the last generation and especially the last two decades. These saw not only a new era of a policy of overseas conquest; the export from the industrial nations to the barbaric lands changed from export solely of *products* to include export of modern capitalism's *means of production and transportation*.

We have already seen the extent to which railways made rapid advances during this period, especially in the Orient (here including Russia). But capitalist *industry*, too, developed swiftly there: the textile and iron industries, mining. The last revolutionized also southern Africa.

This export of *means of production* has formed the basis of a new blossoming of capitalist industry since the second half of the 1880s. In the first half of that decade, it seemed to have already reached the limit of its capability for expansion, and had in fact done so with respect to the export of manufactured goods. However, the export of means of production, which then conferred on capitalist industry that unexpected, magnificent upturn, was only possible because it fostered the development of a capitalist mode of production in the countries of non-European civilization and quickly knocked the traditional economic relations there into a cocked hat. The continuation of the old ways of thinking thereby also became impossible in the Orient. With the new mode of production from Europe, the intellectual abilities of the hitherto barbaric peoples suddenly developed to the level of those of Europeans. However, this new mind was not imbued with love for Europe. The new countries became competitors of the old ones. Competitors are, however, *enemies*. The development of the European mind in the countries of the Orient made the latter not friends, but only *equally matched* enemies of Europe. That did not become obvious immediately. We saw earlier the role played by *consciousness of strength* in social life, and how long a newly rising class or nation, which already has the strength to be independent, but has not yet become aware of that strength, can remain in a subservient position. That happened here, also. The peoples of the Orient had been defeated too often by the Europeans to not believe any resistance to the latter futile. The Europeans shared this view. It was the basis of their colonial policy, in the course of which they exercised control over the alien peoples, exchanged and sold them, as though they were so many head of cattle.

A New Age of Revolutions

But as soon as the Japanese had broken the ice, that had an immediate effect on the entire Orient. All of Eastern Asia, as well as the whole Muslim world, rose up to engage in independent political activity, to resist any domination from without.

Imperialism has thereby been brought to a standstill. It can no longer really make headway. And yet it must constantly be carried further, just as capitalism constantly expands further and must constantly expand, if its exploitation is not to become completely intolerable.

The only area for expansion now remaining is equatorial Africa, where the climate is the natives' best ally; where European soldiers cannot be used; and where the Europeans have to recruit natives as mercenaries, arm them and train them in the use of their weapons—creating the conditions for the time when the Europeans' mercenary troops will turn against their own masters.

Everywhere in Asia and Africa, the spirit of rebellion is spreading. There, the use of European weapons, too, is spreading; resistance to European exploitation is growing. Capitalist exploitation cannot be transplanted into a country without the seed of rebellion against this exploitation also being sown there.

This fact expresses itself first in a continuous growth in the difficulty of carrying out the colonial policy, in a growth of its costs. Our enthusiasts for this policy console us for what the colonies are now costing us by pointing to the rich fruits they will yield in the future. In reality, the military expenses required from us for maintaining possession of the colonies must henceforth constantly increase—but it will not stop there. The majority of the countries of Asia and Africa are heading toward a situation in which the occasional revolt will lead to open, sustained insurrection and finally to the shaking off of the foreign yoke. Closest to that point are the British possessions in East India; their loss would amount to bankruptcy of the British state.

We have already observed that since the Russo-Japanese War, Eastern Asia and the Muslim world have risen to fend off European capitalism. In doing so, they are fighting the same enemy the European proletariat is fighting. We must not forget, of course, that although they are fighting the same enemy, they are not by any means doing so to the same end. They are rebelling, not in order to lead the proletariat to victory over capitalism, but in order to oppose to foreign capitalism a domestic, national capitalism. We must not allow ourselves any illusions in this respect. The Boers are terrible slave drivers; the rulers of Japan are the worst persecutors of socialists; and the Young Turks have already felt

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themselves compelled to take action against striking workers. Thus we must not view the opponents of capitalism outside of Europe uncritically.

That does not in any way alter the fact that they are weakening European capitalism and its governments and introducing an element of political unrest into the whole world.

We have seen that in Europe a period of continuous unrest lasted from 1789 to 1871, until the industrial bourgeoisie had achieved throughout that region the political conditions making possible its rapid development. Since the Russo-Japanese War of 1905, a similar period of continuous unrest has begun for the Orient. The peoples of Eastern Asia and the Muslim world, as well as those of Russia, have now attained a position in many respects similar to that of the West European bourgeoisie at the end of the eighteenth and the beginning of the nineteenth century. The conditions are, of course, not quite the same. Since then the world has become older by a century, and that fact alone makes them different. A country's political development does not depend just on its own social conditions, but also on the conditions of the entire environment, which affect the country. The various classes of Russia, Japan, India, China, Turkey, Egypt, etc., might have a relationship to each other similar to that of the classes of France before the great Revolution. But they are influenced by what has been learned from the class struggles that Britain, France, and Germany have gone through since then. On the other hand, their struggle for favorable conditions for a national capitalist mode of production is at the same time a struggle against foreign capital and its domination, a struggle that the peoples of Western Europe did not have to wage in the revolutionary period from 1789 to 1871.

But no matter how much the effect of these differences is that the events which occurred in the West a century ago are not simply repeating themselves in the East, the similarity of the situation is great enough that a similar kind of revolutionary period is beginning for the East—a period of conspiracies, coups d'état, uprisings, reactions and renewed rebellions, continuous upheavals, that will last until the conditions required for a tranquil development and secure national independence of that world have been achieved.

Because of the policy of colonial expansion, however, the Orient—taking this word in its widest meaning—is linked politically and economically so intimately with the Occident that the political unrest of the East will have that of the West as one of its consequences. The political equilibrium between states that has been achieved so laboriously is now being shaken by unexpected changes on which they can exert no influence. Problems, the peaceful solution of which appeared impossible

and therefore was continually deferred, such as the relationship to the Balkan countries, have acquired a new urgency and are crying out for their solution. Unrest, mistrust, insecurity are everywhere; the nervousness that has already been intensified by the armaments race is being pushed to the limit. World war is now being brought most dangerously close. The experience of the last decades proves, however, that war means revolution, that it results in enormous shifts of political power. In 1891 Engels was still of the opinion that it would be very unfortunate for us if a war broke out that led to the revolution and brought us into power, since this would happen prematurely. For a time, he thought, the proletariat could make progress more securely by using to its advantage the existing governmental framework, than by the risky means of a revolution brought on by a war.

Since that time, the situation has changed greatly. The proletariat has now gained so much strength that it can look forward to a war more calmly. And it can no longer speak of a *premature* revolution when it has drawn from the existing governmental framework as much strength as could be drawn from it, when a transformation of this framework has become a condition of its further advancement.

The proletariat hates war with all its might; it will do its utmost to prevent a mood of bellicosity from arising. If, nevertheless, a war should break out, the proletariat is, at the present time, the class that can look forward to its outcome with the greatest confidence.

Since 1891, it has not only grown extraordinarily in numbers or consolidated itself organizationally; it has also made immense gains in *moral superiority*. Two decades ago, the Social Democratic Party was still confronted in Germany with the great prestige that the rulers of the Reich had won in the struggles to found it. Today, this prestige has been scattered to the four winds.

On the other hand, the more the idea of imperialism becomes bankrupt, all the more does the Social Democratic Party become the only party still championing a great idea, a great goal, one that is able to unleash all the energy and devotion that flow forth from such a goal.

In contrast, faintheartedness and apathy are being sown in the ranks of the party's opponents by the awareness that corruption and incompetence are degrading their leaders. They no longer believe in their cause or in their leaders, who just now, when it matters greatly, in a situation the difficulties of which are multiplying from day to day, are failing more and more and must of necessity fail, who are revealing ever more their complete worthlessness.

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That, too, is no accident and not the fault of individuals, but instead has its roots in the conditions.

The causes are of the most diverse kinds. As soon as a class or a political system has passed from the revolutionary to the conservative stage, as soon as it no longer has to struggle for its existence or its advancement, and comes to terms with the existing order of things and attempts henceforth to improve it only in small ways, that must necessarily have a constricting effect on the intellectual horizon of its spokesmen and leaders. Their interest in questions of great moment dies out, but their boldness, too, is no longer spurred on. Bold thinkers and fighters are felt to be disagreeable and are rejected. The penchant for petty scheming and the cowardly lack of character come to the fore.

The same kind of effect follows from the fact that in statesmen and thinkers of classes and states that no longer have to engage in struggles of great importance, the selfless interest in the interests of the entire class, polity, society is supplanted by interest in their own persons. Those individuals striving for power are no longer animated by the impulse to accomplish something great, something new for the community; instead they are now motivated only by the impulse to acquire wealth and power for themselves. Their unscrupulous self-serving ambition is complemented by the efforts of those in power to not surround themselves with such persons as are most capable of serving the polity, but instead, with such as know how to adapt themselves most flexibly or amusingly to the personal needs, wants, and inclinations of those in power.

In addition to these general causes of the moral and intellectual decline of all who wield power in a conservative stage, there are other, particular causes of such decline that arise from the nature of capitalism.

Formerly, the exploiting classes were also the ruling classes. They reserved at least the topmost positions of government for themselves. In contrast, the capitalist class is so taken up with doing business that it leaves politics to others, who, of course, are basically nothing more than the clerks of the capitalists. In democratic countries, these are professional politicians, members of parliament, journalists; in countries with absolutist governments, the court society; in countries whose government lies between these two forms, a varied mixture of these elements, of which now the one, now the other predominates.

As long as capitalist exploitation is of a low degree, the capitalists' slogan is "save", and they try to impart this principle also to the public administration. The petty bourgeoisie remains loyal to this slogan *nolens volens*. In contrast, the big capitalists develop—the greater the degree of exploitation becomes, which they carry out—an ostentation and a

wastefulness that ultimately proceeds at just as furious a pace as the armaments race and assumes just as senseless forms.

Formerly, it was the rulers of the state who outstripped all their subjects in wealth and splendor of display. Now, the politicians and statesmen, even at the highest levels, are increasingly outdone by the rulers of high finance. It is, however, difficult to increase the regular incomes of the governing statesmen from the state coffer, especially in parliamentary states where it is necessary to take into consideration the voters and taxpayers who clamor for thrift. It is all the more difficult, the more preparations for war absorb the entire growth of government revenues.

If politicians and statesmen want to keep pace with the great exploiters' rising standard of living, they have no choice but to gain access to illegal sources of income, in addition to their legal ones, by taking advantage of and prostituting their influence in government. They use their knowledge of official secrets and their influence on governmental policies for speculation in the stock market; they parasitically take advantage of the hospitality of the great exploiters; they let them pay their debts; indeed, in the worst cases, they go so far as to accept direct bribes as the price of their political power.

The evil is universal. It can be found in all capitalist countries with large-scale exploiters. It is always most likely to lay hold of the most politically influential agencies: in democratic countries, members of parliament and journalists; in absolutist states, court society. Everywhere it breeds a far-reaching corruption that spreads its infection all the more rapidly, the more capitalist exploitation and waste grow, and with them the needs and desires also of the politicians and statesmen, and the more the strength and the economic functions of the government increase.

One should certainly not believe that those affected by the corruption are always aware of it, or that all politicians and statesmen of the ruling classes are corrupt. That would be an exaggeration. But the temptation to corruption is becoming ever stronger in these circles. An ever greater strength of character is required not to fall prey to it, and one falls prey to it all the more readily, the more widespread the atmosphere of corruption is, the more highly developed and insinuating is the way corruption is carried out, which does not permit those held fast in its clutches to have the least inkling of their own decline.

Thus we see that, to the degree in which political problems are becoming ever more complex, to the degree in which they make ever greater demands on the knowledge, conscientiousness, far-sightedness, and resolve of statesmen, to the same degree shallow prattle is

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increasingly replacing intellectual seriousness in the ruling classes; irresponsibility is replacing conscientiousness; the seeking of personal advantage and narrow-minded scheming are replacing the methodical pursuit of distant goals; unprincipled vacillation between provocative brutality and cowardly retreat is taking the place of calm, resolute firmness. And at the same time far-reaching greed and corruption are revealed here in a Panama Scandal; there in an alliance between governors and gangsters; and almost everywhere in the deceptions of the suppliers of military materials, who in one instance, provide brittle armor plates, in another unuseable artillery pieces, and who, in yet another case, charge their homeland twice as much as foreign governments. Since time out of mind, supplying military materials has been a means for many capitalists to enrich themselves, but never before have the suppliers of military materials had such intimate relations with the governments as now; never before have they had so much influence on the political activity that decides between war and peace.

And today these same suppliers are the largest industrialists, the greatest exploiters of the proletariat. They have the strongest interest in brutal war against both the internal and the external enemy, and the greatest influence on the governments, which are coming to consist more and more of unprincipled individuals.

In these circumstances, each state and the working class of each state must at every moment expect and be prepared for a provocation, for an attack, the state from its neighbors, the working class from its rulers, that can result in incalculable disaster. All of which can bring about a new change in the petty bourgeoisie.

Of course, the moral decline of the ruling classes takes place in spheres that are inaccessible to the broad masses of the people. It takes a catastrophe, such as the Russo-Japanese War, to lay bare all the system's rottenness. In ordinary times, only now and then, because of some extraordinary ineptness, is a corner of the cloak lifted that otherwise prudishly conceals everything. Class-conscious proletarians are affected only slightly by such revelations. They have viewed the ruling classes with hostility all along and have no illusions about their moral qualities.

As for the petty bourgeoisie, that is a different matter. The more it becomes unfaithful to its democratic past, the more it skulks behind the governments and expects help from them, the greater its trust in them and their stability is, then all the greater is its horror when the depth to which those governments have sunk has become manifest and their prestige has gone to the devil.

And at the same time the petty bourgeoisie is being increasingly hard-pressed by the great rings of capitalists and by the demands the state is making on its purse. That does not strengthen its trust in the ruling classes.

It would surely be completely beside itself, though, if incompetence, irresponsibility, corruption on the part of those governing should frivolously bring about a catastrophe, a war or a coup d'état, say, that exposed the country to the worst tribulations. If that happens, the blind rage of the petty bourgeoisie will suddenly turn against those then governing all the more readily and furiously, the more it previously expected from them and the greater it imagined their intelligence and nobility to be.

The last decade has certainly developed in the petty bourgeoisie a growing hatred for the proletariat. The latter must adapt its policies to fighting the coming struggles alone. Many years ago, Marx pointed out that the petty bourgeois, being a creature intermediate between the capitalist and the proletarian, vacillates back and forth between the two, that he is the man of "on the one hand and on the other hand." We cannot count on him. He will always be an unreliable customer — in the mass; individuals can make excellent fellow party members. His hostility toward us can still increase. But that does not preclude that one day, under intolerable pressure from taxation and shaken by a sudden moral collapse of those in power, he might swing over to us en masse and perhaps thereby sweep away our opponents and decide the struggle in our favor. And, in truth, that is the smartest thing he could do, for the victorious proletariat can offer to all who are not exploiters, to all who are oppressed and exploited, including those who are now vegetating as petty bourgeois and small holder peasants, an enormous improvement of their living conditions.

No matter with how much hostility the petty bourgeoisie might face us at the present moment, it is far from being a firm support of the existing order. It, too, is swaying and groaning in all its joints, like all other pillars of society.

The certainty of the existing order is ceasing more and more in the popular consciousness just as in reality. The feeling is widespread that we have entered a period of general uncertainty, that things can no longer go on as they have been for a generation, that the present-day conditions, which are quickly becoming increasingly untenable, cannot survive for another generation.

In this general uncertainty, however, the immediate tasks of the proletariat are clearly indicated. We have already described them. It can

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make no further progress until there has been a change in the governmental bases on which it is waging its struggle. Its immediate task in Germany is to strive with all its might for democracy in the Reich, but also in the individual Länder, Prussia and Saxony in particular; its immediate international task is to combat the policy of colonial expansion and militarism.

Just as evident as these tasks are the means at our disposal for carrying them out. To those already employed has been added the *mass strike*, which we accepted theoretically as long ago as the beginning of the 1890s, the feasibility of which in favorable circumstances has been repeatedly tested since then. If the mass strike has receded somewhat into the background since the glorious days of 1905, that proves only that it is not effective in every situation, that it would be foolish to want to apply it in all circumstances.

To that extent the situation is clear. However, with regard to the coming struggles, it is not a matter just of the proletariat. Many other factors that are completely unpredictable will also play a role in them.

For one, our statesmen are unpredictable. The individuals exercising this function change rapidly, and their moods change just as swiftly. It can no longer be said that they are pursuing a consistent, goal-directed policy.

Unpredictable, too, are the petty-bourgeois masses, which throw their weight now on this side, now on that side of the balance, causing it to jerk unsteadily up and down.

Even more unpredictable are the confusions of international politics, in which so many unstable states are participating, with the result that the unpredictability of every state's domestic politics appears multiplied in magnitude in international politics.

Lastly, the transformations of the states of the Orient are completely unpredictable, as a great many wholly new factors, about which no experiential knowledge at all is yet available, are playing a role in them.

All of these factors have now entered into the most intimate and continuous interaction. They will assure that there is no end to our surprises.

In this general vacillation, the Social Democratic Party will stand its ground all the better, the less it itself vacillates, the more firmly it remains true to itself. Confronted with unprincipled mood-determined political activity, it will increase all the more the working masses' consciousness of their strength, the more its theory makes possible for it a consistent practice certain to attain its goal. The more the Social Democratic Party maintains itself as an imperturbable power in the midst of the perturbations of authority of every kind, all the higher will its authority

rise. And the more it persists in irreconcilable opposition to the corruption of the ruling classes, all the greater will be the trust placed in it by the great masses of the people in the midst of the general decay that today has laid hold even of the bourgeois democrats, who are completely abandoning their principles in order to win the government's favor.

The more imperturbable, consistent, and irreconcilable the Social Democratic Party remains, all the more readily will it get the better of its opponents.

To demand that the Social Democratic Party participate in a policy of coalition or alliance now, when the dictum about the "reactionary mass" has become reality, is to expect the Party to commit political suicide. To want the Social Democratic Party to link itself with bourgeois parties through an alliance policy now, at the very time when those parties have prostituted and utterly compromised themselves; to want the Party to link itself with them in order to further that very prostitution – is to demand that it commit moral suicide.

Worried friends fear that the Social Democratic Party will prematurely gain control of the government *through* a revolution. However, if there is for us a premature attainment of power, it is the acquisition of an appearance of control of the government before the revolution, that is, *before* the proletariat has achieved real political power. Until the proletariat has succeeded in doing that, the Social Democratic Party can attain to a share of the control of the government only by *selling* its political strength to a bourgeois government. The *proletariat* as a class can never win in such a transaction, but rather, in the best case, only the *members of parliament* who conclude the sale.

Whoever considers the Social Democratic Party the means for freeing the proletariat must categorically oppose such participation of his party in the prevailing corruption. If there is a means of depriving ourselves of the trust of all honest elements in the masses, a means to bring down upon ourselves the disdain of all strata of the proletariat able and eager to fight, to hinder our advance, then it consists in the participation of the Social Democratic Party in a policy of alliance.

From such an alliance, only those elements would benefit for whom our party is nothing but the ladder by means of which they as individuals will climb higher, the *personally ambitious* and the *place-hunters*. The fewer such elements we attract, the more of them we repel, the better for our struggle.

To be sure, hardly anything definite can be said about just what form that struggle will take, beyond what has already been observed about it here. Never was it more difficult to predict the forms and the speed of the

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coming development than now, when all factors that must be taken into consideration, except for the proletariat, are so indeterminate and unpredictable.

The only thing that is certain is the general uncertainty. It is certain that we have entered upon a period of general unrest, of continual power shifts, a period which, regardless of what its forms and its duration might be, can no longer end in a state of relatively long-lasting tranquility until the proletariat has acquired the strength to expropriate the capitalist class politically and economically and to thereby begin a new era of world history.

It is, of course, not foreseeable whether this revolutionary period will last as long as that of the bourgeoisie, which began in 1789 and continued until 1871. It is true that today developments are occurring much faster than formerly, but on the other hand, the field of battle has grown enormously. When Marx and Engels wrote the *Communist Manifesto*, they regarded only Western Europe as the field of battle of the proletarian revolution. Today, it has become the whole world. Today, the battles in the liberation struggle of laboring and exploited humanity are being fought not only at the Spree River and the Seine, but also at the Hudson and Mississippi, at the Neva and the Dardanelles, at the Ganges and the Hoangho.

And enormous, too, like the field of battle, is the task that ultimately arises from it: the social organization of the world economy.

But the proletariat will emerge from the revolutionary era that is beginning and that will last perhaps a generation, different than when it entered this era.

The elite of the proletariat today forms the strongest, the most far-sighted, most selfless, boldest stratum, and the one united in the largest free organizations, of the nations with European civilization. And the proletariat will, in and through struggle, take up into itself the unselfish and far-sighted elements of all classes; it will organize and educate in its own bosom even its most backward elements and fill them with understanding and the joy of hope. It will place its elite at the head of civilization and make it capable of guiding the immense economic transformation that will finally, over the entire globe, put an end to all the misery arising out of subjection, exploitation, and ignorance.

Fortunate are those destined to take part in this sublime struggle and share in this glorious victory!

Appendix

Translated by Ernest Haberkern

This appendix contains the more significant published letters concerning Karl Kautsky's dispute with the SPD Executive Committee [Parteiivorstand] over the publication of what became a second edition of *The Road to Power*. Passages in the letters that are unimportant in this context or irrelevant to it have been omitted. These omissions are marked by ellipses (...).

Letter nos. 1, 2, 4-9, 12, 13, 16, 17, and 19-24 are translated, along with some of the editor's footnotes from Ursula Ratz, ed., "Briefe zum Erscheinen von Karl Kautskys 'Weg zur Macht'," *International Review of Social History* 12 no. 3 (1967): 432-77.

Letter nos. 10, 14, 15, and 18 are translated from Victor Adler, *Briefwechsel mit August Bebel and Karl Kautsky*, ed. Friedrich Adler (Vienna: Wiener Volksbuchhandlung, 1954), 494-98.

Letter nos. 3 and 11 are translated from *August Bebel's Briefwechsel mit Karl Kautsky*, ed. Karl Kautsky, Jr. (Assen: Van Gorcum, 1971), 202-3.

1. Kautsky to Hugo Haase

Berlin-Friedenau, February 14, 1909

Dear friend Haase,

...Your first letter seemed to me so compelling and convincing that I could think of nothing better to do than to forward it to Bebel. I expected that would settle the matter. Unfortunately, I was fooling myself. Bebel just wrote me that he could not understand you....

I am not even going to show Bebel your letter of today. It is pointless, since he and the entire Executive Committee have already firmly made up their minds. Besides, your letter contains some observations regarding the Executive Committee that are, unfortunately, very accurate and which I assume are meant only for me.

But even so the letter provides firm support for me in my dealings with the Executive Committee. The specific revisions I have decided to agree to will not alter the substance of my book in the least. If the Executive Committee had read the proofs, I would have acceded to their wishes without question, because where no principle is involved I always try to be conciliatory. I am only angry over the changes in the *printed* and already *published* pamphlet because of the cost, the delay, and the weakening of my position if, by chance, an opponent should happen to

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notice the revisions and throw them up to me as expressions of my guilty conscience.

What depresses me most about this whole affair is August [Bebel]'s weakness, which is probably attributable to his physical condition.... The word "revolution" seems to make him actually physically uncomfortable. In his obituary for N[atalie] Liebknecht, he writes of "The Years of Change" instead of "The Revolutionary Years."

As matters now stand, the most powerful social democratic party in the world has the most servile Executive Committee in the world. August has lost all his spunk, and in recent years he was the only politician among them with any vision. Singer has good instincts and worked well with Bebel, but without him or against him he is not capable of setting the sluggish mass moving.

Is there no possibility of your transferring your business to Berlin? I know very well that it would mean a serious financial loss for you, but if you were active at the center of the movement, you could now accomplish something of world-historical importance. I would be very glad if you also thought so. You tell me who else could replace Bebel in the Party leadership.

Yours,
K. Kautsky

2. Kautsky to Haase

Berlin-Friedenau, February 19, 1909

Dear friend Haase,

You're probably wondering why I haven't been in touch with you, but the fact of the matter is that there isn't yet anything for me to report. The Executive could not be convinced and even demanded by a vote with only one opposed – Luise Zietz was the only man on the Committee – that my pamphlet be suppressed. I appealed to the Control Commission, which will decide the matter this afternoon. I was then going to write you immediately.

I am only sending you these lines today, because Bebel shared your letter to him with me and I see from it that he relied in his letter to you on three of our attorneys. This business is a real scandal. B[ebel] had to admit in the discussion before the Executive Committee that *not one of the three attorneys had read the pamphlet*. He showed them only the two passages on pp. 55 and 62 [pp. 74 and 83 in this translation], and after a fleeting glance they declared that, yes, that was certainly actionable.

When I mocked the Executive Committee about these "legal experts," the EC dropped them.

Meanwhile, I have also spoken to Mehring and he too agrees with me that the pamphlet is absolutely not dangerous. The discussion at the Executive Committee was very depressing. It demonstrated a frighteningly low level of political understanding.

Our Party is about to fall far behind. Already at the Congress of the International in Stuttgart, it played a sad role,² not least as a result of August's skittishness, and that will get worse. August was for years the only fighter and the only politician [with vision and insight] on the Executive Committee. Now he is worn out. But he won't admit it and, since he still wants to march in front, we are to adjust our stride so he can keep up. Understandable in human terms, but very regrettable for our Party. Of course, I do not despair because of it. Others do. Events are working in our favor. But what *we* can do to take advantage of these events, that is missing. If in earlier times our leaders speeded our progress as far as individuals can do so, they now obstruct it as far as individuals can....

I write today mainly because you mentioned that you would be writing to Bebel at some length. So it is good that you know how things stand with the experts.

More tomorrow. In haste and with best wishes.

Yours, K. K.

3. Clara Zetkin to Kautsky

February 20, 1909

...I have to underline just one point: that is, the decision of the [Control] Commission was adopted *completely without qualification*.... Kaden stated ... explicitly, that our decision could only be a simple and clear yes or no response to your complaint. And so, without any stipulation, without any "preference," without any "suggestion," the resolution was adopted. The majority of the Control Commission unconditionally considered your complaint to be justified and declared for the publication of your pamphlet.

4. Kautsky to Haase

Berlin-Friedenau, February 20, 1909

Dear friend Haase,

[Otto] Braun has probably already told you how things went. The Control Commission members upheld my complaint. It is true that they weren't all there. Bock [and] Timm were absent. It is possible, however, that the real difficulties will only start with this decision. As far as I can recall, this is the first case (at least in the last thirty years) in which the Control Commission has overruled the Executive Committee. Is it now required to comply? There is nothing in the by-laws on this. An appeal to the highest court, the Party Congress, is, however, excluded in this case. We can hardly debate openly whether or not I have committed high treason. Obviously I will not force the Executive Committee to publish the pamphlet themselves. I am prepared to withdraw it from Vor[warts] Verlag and give it to some other publisher. The Executive Committee certainly has no longer any moral right to prevent me from doing that.

Mehring advises against this on the following grounds: the state prosecutor's office knows that the work was supposed to be brought out by "Vorwärts." They will be suspicious when they notice that the publisher has been changed for no apparent reason. Informers could let them know that the Executive Committee prevented publication by the Party publishing house. That would lead the prosecutor to bring charges against me and to subpoena the Executive Committee as witnesses and they would then have to acknowledge that they had discovered high treason in the pamphlet. That would mean a legal judgment against me and, what is far worse, a moral one either against the Executive Committee, because it was cowardly and acted like an informer, or against the author, because he was frivolous and obstinate. I think it can only avoid this danger if I bring out the pamphlet with a new publisher and some changes. Then the Executive Committee can in good conscience tell the judge that its objections were only against the original version, which could be misunderstood, and not against the new, clearer version.

On the other hand, if the Executive Committee doesn't want to bring out the pamphlet in its own press and I give up on having it published by another house, then I have to give up on publishing the pamphlet altogether. That wouldn't be so bad. It doesn't contain that much that is new, except for the demonstration that our expectations of revolution, even if they proved unwarranted, still cannot be said to have been a pure fantasy. But everything in the pamphlet that is important to me I can say

another time. So my author's pride is not a factor, but there is another consideration. The work was already actually in the bookshops, a lot of people know that it was distributed and then withdrawn in a highly peculiar manner. If now the work doesn't appear at all, what will people think? And am I not constantly threatened with the danger that some revisionist or bourgeois journalist will one day write that I wrote a book containing such hair-raising stuff that the Executive Committee forced me to withdraw it? What should I then reply? Should I say that I stood by the book and only submitted to compulsion? Or shall I remain silent? And won't I confirm everything said against me by the mere fact that I agreed to withdraw a work already printed and distributed in the bookshops. But by accident the dart may also be aimed not at me but at the Executive Committee; they can be accused of suppressing freedom of opinion. What will they say? Their hands will also be tied. They can say nothing that will not compromise either themselves or me. And I do not consider them capable of doing the latter.

So the Executive Committee's stroke of genius, the conspicuous act of suppressing a pamphlet that had already appeared, has put us in a situation that threatens to produce unpleasant consequences no matter which way we turn or twist.

The smartest thing would obviously be for the Executive Committee to act as if nothing had happened and to release the work. Then talk will soon die down and if some question were to be raised in public, an explanation for the delay in the publication could easily be found. Since the pamphlet itself would then be available, irresponsible rumors about it could not find any basis.

If the Executive Committee opposes this alternative, then I consider the publication of my book in Leipzig' less compromising than forgoing its publication altogether. Such an abandonment of the pamphlet's publication would arouse to a high pitch the curiosity of the state prosecutor, and the Berlin police would have to be even stupider than they are if they couldn't manage to get hold of one of the copies that have already been sold. What was to be avoided would come about precisely because I completely withdrew the work. It would provide the proof that I was aware myself of its actionable contents.

Forgive me if I burden you still further with the case, but I hope that not only personal interests, but also Party interests are at risk here. I am very curious to know how you reply to Beb[el's] letter. Yesterday, he was convinced that his arguments were very persuasive for you....

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Warm greetings to you and yours from all of us.

Yours,
K. Kautsky

P.S. Doesn't a copy of every book published in Prussia have to be sent to the royal Library in Berlin? Then all our deliberations are superfluous. The state prosecutor's office can in this case acquire or demand a copy from the library.

5. Haase to Kautsky

Konigsberg, February 22, 1909

Dear Comrade Kautsky,

... Today I wrote to Bebel; I would gladly have vented some spleen, but I restrained myself out of consideration for him. With his arguments he struck a blow at his whole past and certainly his best work. And I left him in no doubt about that.

The tactics of the Executive Committee are, in every respect, harmful and disastrous. They have added grist to the revisionists' mill and bound the hands of the radicals in their fight against them. I won't waste words on their treatment of you personally. What I think of that I will tell our dear comrades of the Executive Committee face to face when the occasion presents itself....

For the present I am glad that you won the moral victory at the Control Commission. According to the by-laws, the Control Commission is, indeed, the court of appeal for complaints against the Executive Committee. From this it follows that the Executive Committee have to comply with the decision of the Control Commission, if they don't want to bring the dispute before the Party Congress, which is, of course, impossible in this case. I can't tell from your letter whether they will make use of the device – which is available to them – of a joint meeting with the members of the Control Commission.

So although you have at present in any case a well-founded claim for the distribution of the pamphlet, still it cannot be *enforced*. Well, what then? Mehring is right that the publication of the pamphlet by another press can have unpleasant consequences for the Party and perhaps for you. According to your letter, you are prepared to bring out the pamphlet with some alterations with a different publisher. Can't then the solution be found in its publication by Vorwärts-Verlag with the changes you *have decided on*? You can build a bridge for the Executive Committee, which has gotten itself into a disastrous position, if you tell them that you indeed have the right to publish the pamphlet as is; but now that your right to

that has been confirmed by the members of the Control Commission you have decided on your own on some changes....

If an agreement between you and the Executive Committee is not reached, it remains for you to decide whether to bring out your book with another press and with minor changes only after the statute of limitations has expired, say at the beginning of August.

If I can help you further in any way, please call on me. In any case, keep me posted on further developments in this affair.

Yours,
Hugo Haase

6 Kautsky to Haase

Berlin-Friedenau, February 25, 1909

Dear friend Haase,

The last few days here have been a combination Mardi Gras and Ash Wednesday. This business is getting crazier and crazier.

The Executive Committee has not said anything since the decision of the Control Committee members. I wrote them, therefore, and asked them to let me know what should be done now. I saw only two ways out of the difficulty if they didn't want to just release the pamphlet, which was unthinkable according to various remarks Bebel and Singer made to me. [I wrote that] either the Executive Committee should explicitly and clearly designate the passages they want changed. Until now they have only hemmed and hawed and mentioned different passages each time. However if they reject the pamphlet in its entirety, then I would feel justified, in light of the verdict of the Control Commission members, to give it to another publisher. In any case, I asked the Executive Committee to decide quickly.

Hardly had I sent off the letter when I got hold of the article in the L[eipziger] Volkszeit[un]g.⁴ I was perplexed and didn't know whether to be pleased or angered. Angered, because I could be suspected of being involved in a conspiracy against the Executive Committee, in a malicious attack on them, or pleased, because the situation was now cleared up and there was no turning back. In any case whatever one might think of the article from the standpoint of discipline or comradeship, it was now imperative that the pamphlet be published. Any damage that could result from it was already done by the publication of the quotations and their emphasis in bold type. To continue to keep the pamphlet out of circulation could only increase rather than diminish the damage, insofar as there

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could be any. For taken out of context, the passages look much worse than they do in the pamphlet itself.

I hurried to the Executive Committee and implored them to decide immediately. But they could not bring themselves to abandon their sleepy pace and postponed the meeting to the next day, yesterday. There I stated my case as coldly and in as businesslike a fashion as I could. I was so angry at the indolence and procrastination of the Executive Committee that I had intended to break off all relations with them if they rejected my proposal and to resign as editor of the *N[eu]e Z[eit]*. Strangely it was Mehring who counseled moderation. I shouldn't abandon unnecessarily the only secure position that we still occupied.

I accepted his objections (this happened before the meeting) and spoke as calmly as possible at the meeting. The Executive Committee was calm as well and not, as I expected, upset over the article which they did not hold me responsible for. Bebel admitted that the Executive Committee itself was to blame since they failed to ask the editors not to publish anything about the pamphlet. However now it must still not appear. For one thing the state prosecutor could not proceed on the basis of the quotations alone if he didn't have a copy of the pamphlet, and the Executive Committee simply assumes as certain that he didn't have it and would never have it. Also the quotations were not the most dangerous passages, others were far more dangerous, and, finally, they were even more dangerous in context than they were in the articles.

Furthermore the publisher and his representative refused to put out the pamphlet because he himself could be brought to trial as an accomplice to high treason! As though it had occurred to anyone to proceed against Liebknecht's publisher.

Finally if the pamphlet were distributed, I could be imprisoned, because it could be proved that I profited from the sale of the book!

In vain I tried to counter these arguments, but it didn't help. They were blind to the immense scandal they are unleashing, blind to the danger they put me in by their behavior, which is an accusation and an admission of my guilt at the same time and provides the state prosecutor with the best arguments that could be available to him.

I was angry and ready, despite all of Mehring's warnings, to break with the Executive Committee, but I controlled myself and stated that I agreed not to publish in Vorw[ärts] or anywhere in Germany. But I could not go so far as to forgo publication altogether. [I said] that would be political suicide for me now that the work had already become known, but it would do severe damage to the party, too. Even if one managed it so that all party comrades calmly accepted the suppression of the work, our

that has been confirmed by the members of the Control Commission you have decided on your own on some changes....

If an agreement between you and the Executive Committee is not reached, it remains for you to decide whether to bring out your book with another press and with minor changes only after the statute of limitations has expired, say at the beginning of August.

If I can help you further in any way, please call on me. In any case, keep me posted on further developments in this affair.

Yours,
Hugo Haase

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The danger is that the row will then really get going and the Executive Committee will then declare that the withdrawal [of the book] was caused by concern over the reaction, not of the revisionists, but of the state prosecutor's office. Even if it doesn't come to that, I am afraid that the withdrawal will provoke the state prosecutor into bringing a charge against me, if only for the purpose of allowing him to interrogate the publisher and the Executive Committee under oath as to what was in this work they so firmly withheld and what passages were the stumbling blocks. If it gets that far, my position in Germany will be untenable. It could happen overnight without my knowing about it and without my being able to defend myself. As anxious as I am, however, to defend my work, I have no desire to place my fate in the hands of people who in some cases have not demonstrated a really high level of intelligence and whom one cannot expect to risk a couple of years in jail for perjury to spare me a couple of years' imprisonment. I called this eventuality to the Executive Committee's attention, too. Bebel's opinion on that point was that, if anyone testified against me, I would just have to try and get out of it as best I could! Indeed very convenient and simple for everybody else.

And the turn that things have taken now rules out the use of the trial for propaganda purposes. If it were only a question of my pamphlet, I would have accepted the risk of some years of imprisonment in a fortress, not exactly with pleasure—I am not that pleasure-seeking—but still without grumbling. If I were sentenced for this work, there would be widespread outrage and that would have a very powerful propaganda effect, perhaps even greater than that caused by Liebknecht's trial. This could certainly console me about the sacrifice of several years. It is, after all, immaterial how one is effective, if only one is effective; it doesn't always have to be with a pen.

But if it comes to trial now after the Party press has withdrawn my work, it will not be the state prosecutor who is compromised but the Party functionaries, who will then be state's witnesses and play the most disgraceful role before the world. And I don't know whether I should risk three years in a fortress to make possible the production of this Party tragedy.

But perhaps you and my other Party friends are of a different opinion. Maybe you think it essential that I stand trial in any case. [Kautsky added a note here pointing to the consequences that would follow given his lack of German citizenship.] In my case consideration has to be given to the fact that I cannot thereby buy my continued ability to work in the country, since I will certainly be expelled after release.] If you

believe this, I will do it. In this matter, my friends can judge better than I who am personally involved.

In any case, however, I want to protect my freedom to consult with my friends, I want to be safe from surprises and that is also one of the reasons why I am going to Vienna. This is my plan: if there is a fight, then it has to start in the next few days. I will wait for whatever statements in the course of it. If there are any that legally compromise me, then I will remain abroad until the six-month period of limitation has expired. If the matter is handled within the Party and leaves no trace, which is the best outcome as far as I am concerned, then I believe that I won't need to worry about returning home in a few weeks. If it should then come to a trial, which I don't expect, the danger would no longer be so imminent that my comrades could be used against me publicly. And I don't fear anything else. I would now be very grateful, if you could let me know *immediately* what you think about the matter; first about the appearance of my pamphlet in Vienna, and second about my remaining abroad. I don't want to initiate publication in Vienna before I have your opinion, and I also don't want to make any other move without your agreement. No one can advise me in this situation like you who, unlike my other friends, most perfectly understands how to unite the lawyer with the friend and party comrade.

The crisis is now serious enough that I don't need to excuse myself for the loss of time I am causing you.

I thank you heartily for everything you have done and are still doing for me.

Best wishes from all of us to you and your loved ones.

Yours,

K. Kautsky

My address is, until further notice, that of V[ictor] Adler, Vienna VI, Blumelgasse 1.

7. Zetkin to Kautsky

Wilhelmshohe, February 26, 1909

Dear Karl,

Thanks for your letter. I hope you received my long letter about my conversation with D[ietz] and others before your departure. At the same time as your note, an official announcement arrived from Kaden⁵ which informed me that the Executive Committee could not implement the decision of the Control] Com[mission]. The reason is so priceless that one

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must have heard it. "C[omrade] Weber refuses to take responsibility and likewise the business manager of 'Vorwärts' refuses to take on the publication."

I replied immediately as follows:

"Your announcement has completely surprised me, in my opinion nothing like this has happened before. I am registering my protest against the CC's acceptance of this slap in the face. Now the question how [the Commission] stands on K[autsky]'s pamphlet is no longer on its agenda. That question is settled. What is at issue is something else. Are decisions of the Control Commission to be tossed blithely into the wastebasket? If that is to be the case, then the work of the Control Commission is reduced to the level of an undignified farce, in which I do not wish to play a part. I therefore reserve the right to go public with a ruthless analysis of this case and to accept all the consequences that might result for me. I reserve the right to decide when I shall proceed. I was reinforced in my position and opinion on this issue of the pamphlet by a discussion with C[omrade] Dietz. He assured me that he did not think the pamphlet was actionable. At most a single passage, on which he could come to terms with K[autsky] in two minutes, was a cause for concern. And C[omrade] D[ietz] certainly has more experience as a publisher than the business manager, Comrade Weber and all the rest at 'Vorwärts' combined. Besides no one will claim that C[omrade] D[ietz] is a 'Radicalinski.'"

Yours,
Clara

8. Zetkin to August Kaden

February 27, 1909

Dear Comrade Kaden,

After my letter to you was posted, a good idea came to me on how we might overcome our difficulty. You informed me that the Executive Committee could not implement the decision of the Control Commission because the employees of the Vorwärts publishing house refused to take responsibility for Kautsky's pamphlet. I will not at this time raise the question of what judgment should be passed on comrades, who about three weeks ago, without *any worry or concern*, distributed to the world a pamphlet which they now, all of a sudden, condemn as so dangerous that they do not want to have anything to do with it. This question I will explore before the highest forum of the Party, where it properly belongs in the Party's interest. For now we have to put the poor Executive

Committee in a position to implement our decision. The way to make this possible is very simple. I hereby offer to be responsible for Kautsky's pamphlet, to act as its publisher and, in short, to assume all functions that will make me personally answerable for the pamphlet, to the authorities legally, and the whole Party morally....

I will inform Kautsky immediately of my proposal and ask you, for your part, to distribute my proposal to the appropriate bodies and to let me have a response as soon as possible.

Yours,

[Clara Zetkin]

9. Kautsky to Haase

Vienna, [Sometime after February 26, 1909]

Dear friend Haase,

Adler thinks as I expected. He is shocked at the mindless behavior of the Executive Committee. He does not agree with viewpoint of the pamphlet, politically he objects to much of it, but he considers it unobjectionable legally and the only danger to be the behavior of the Executive Committee. He is also convinced that the work must come out, and he has written very energetically in this vein to August and Paul [Singer]. Another meeting of the Executive Committee has been called for today, to which the members of the Control Commission who are present in Berlin are invited, which seems to me really improper. But that is the business of the Control Commission.

Yesterday along with your letter there was one from Clara, which confirms that the Executive Committee now is hiding behind the publisher, who doesn't want to take the responsibility, and so the Executive Committee is supposedly not able to implement the decision of the Control Commission.

This excuse is rendered untenable by Clara's offer to take responsibility for the publication. Now they have no excuse and more. I immediately informed the Executive Committee of that and also that, if it nevertheless stood by its refusal, there were, in my opinion, no further grounds which could prevent me, out of respect for party discipline, from having the work issued by another publishing house in Germany. You are right that it shouldn't appear in a foreign country.

Yours faithfully, K. K.

10. August Bebel to Victor Adler

Schöneberg-Berlin, February 28, 1909

Dear Victor,

I, of course, take no offense. It is your right to express your opinion as sharply as you can.

I am, it is true, not in agreement with you when it comes to your legal opinion, *and it is only the legal aspect* that is in question, but, nevertheless, I am personally inclined to reconsider the matter. I will call for a meeting of the Party Executive Committee and those members of the Control Commission present here for Tuesday afternoon, and we will consider the matter yet once more. I had already decided on this step yesterday; your letter today strengthened my resolve.

I won't say any more about the case itself, I only want to note that it is a mistake on your part to think that the political situation militates against a trial. The exact opposite is the case in the opinion of all of us. If it were certain that we could, as far as possible, avoid a trial, then I would be in favor of continued publication. In the Executive Committee, however, it will be at the cost of a tough fight.

I have just sent your letter to Paul [Singer], who is one of the most stubborn, as I learned from him only yesterday when I discussed with him a possible further reconsideration....

Best regards, also to Karl,

Yours,

A.B.

11. Bebel to Kautsky

Berlin, March 2, 1909

Dear Karl,

The Party Executive has decided to leave the decision on the further distribution of your pamphlet up to you. So it will be best if you come home.

Everything else we can talk about face to face. Best regards to you and Victor.

Yours, A. B.

Further publication by the Vorwärts-Verlag is refused.

12. Zetkin to Kautsky

W[ilhelmshohe] March 5, 1909

Dear Friends,

... I can only recapitulate in summary form what I wrote to Luise:

1) Karl must no longer rely on negotiations but has to bring the book out unaltered in Leipzig as soon as possible. Any agreement with the Executive Committee is not just at the expense of his scholarly reputation, also of his personal standing as a man of character. The Executive Committee itself has, like an old washerwoman, made sure that the affair is as widely known as possible, and, in light of the situation and their interpretation of it, every compromise is a stain on Karl's personal and scholarly reputation that cannot be washed away.

2) The issue is no longer just K[arl]'s pamphlet but the arbitrariness of the Executive Committee and the authority of the Control Commission. That means that the whole affair must become the proper business of the entire party. I will therefore pursue it, under all circumstances, regardless of how Karl may react to the "revised" decision of the Executive Committee, which differs from the original only in being even more blatantly idiotic. I am only waiting for the official response to our demand that a meeting of the Control Committee be called to decide how it should react to its decision being ignored. Depending on the outcome, I will immediately proceed, resign as a member of the Control Commission, and release a straightforward explanation to the press. If K[arl] stands fast, so much the better, if he doesn't, I will be forced to carry on without him.

Vogue la galere! [Forward!] I warmly embrace you all.

Your Clara

13. Kautsky to the Executive Committee of the SPD

[Berlin,] March 5, 1909

Esteemed Comrades,

As Comrade Bebel has informed me, the Executive Committee, despite the opposition of the Control Commission, has definitely decided against the release of my pamphlet *The Road to Power*, which was issued at the end of January by Vorw[ärts] press and whose distribution was forbidden by the Executive Committee.

Before I take any further steps, I am requesting a ruling of the Executive Committee *in writing*, because its oral ones have not been completely unambiguous. I request above all to be informed of the following:

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1. Does the Executive Committee *unconditionally* refuse to have the "Vorwärts" press distribute my pamphlet, which they published?

2. If not, what *conditions* does the Executive Committee place on the continued distribution of the pamphlet; for example, what passages do they want changed and how?

After so many discussions on the subject, it will surely not be difficult for the Executive Committee to let me have a written decision on this by *return* mail, for which I will be very grateful.

With comradely greetings,
K. Kautsky

14. Bebel to Adler

Schöneberg-Berlin, March 6, 1909

Dear Victor,

Our decision was taken in full awareness of all the consequences, as you can imagine. If we had decided to print another edition, we would have run into business difficulties.

As far as the content of the pamphlet is concerned, my opinion is: one can think anything and even, among responsible party people, say anything; but to say such things publicly is asinine. And then, since lawyers can object to quite a number of passages, a revision had to be made, and then Karl can explain that he couldn't come to an agreement with us and therefore preferred to get another publisher.

If Karl had possessed the sense of solidarity he should have, then he would, after our decision, have announced the first time that he gave up on further distribution. We all asserted that we did not have the slightest objection to the tendency of the work, but that we could, in the present situation, not wish for a trial for high treason, least of all for him, and that, besides, the work was an inexhaustible source of charges against the party.

We are of the opinion that it is just the internal [political] embarrassments that produce a search for a diversion; so a real red scare could be welcome. Why, then, should we be so dumb as to prepare this banquet for our opponents? Karl has no feel for these tactical questions, he contemplates, as if hypnotized, the goal, and has no interest in, or understanding of, anything else. In this you and I agree in our opinion of him....

With best regards from both of us to you and Emma,
Yours,
A. Bebel

15. Kautsky to Adler

Berlin-Friedenau, March 7, 1909

Dear Victor,

On my return I found the situation more confused than ever. The Executive Committee had made the following clever decision:

It demanded of me a preface along the lines you suggested and the revision of a number of passages. If I do this, then — they still reject further publication in Berlin but will graciously allow me to publish with another press.

Nothing sillier could be imagined. If I revise the work completely in line with the Executive Committee's wishes, they still will prohibit publication by its press. They claim the right to prescribe to me what I must write for another publisher. That is a position of contrariness and of pure arbitrary power that is hard to top.

I answered with the demand that they give me their decision in writing. As soon as I had that, I would take further steps. I meant that I would publish in Leipzig, but the Executive Committee evidently interpreted the thing differently and assumed I was going public, and so at a stroke the whole situation changed.

Yesterday afternoon Dietz appeared here and offered to let the work be published by his press, under conditions that he would discuss with me today. Yesterday Wurm and Mehring were present which evidently embarrassed him.

Today he came by with August, and it was agreed to have the work published by Dietz without the slightest revision and without a new preface.

The Executive Committee agrees to everything, if only the work isn't published in Berlin. They are deathly afraid of publicity, but they felt they owed it to their reputation that they would not give in on at least *one* point. It is a demonstration of their unbelievable stupidity that they refused to give in on precisely the point that is least in their favor; the demand to change the publisher, which is completely senseless, can only hurt them, since it is apt to bring about what they fear: it will attract public attention.

But that is the Executive Committee's problem. I propose the alternative: either the pamphlet appears with the proposed new preface as a second edition in Berlin or it appears unchanged in Stuttgart. If the Executive Committee prefers the latter, it's all the same to me.

I hope that the matter will be put to rest this way and the party saved from serious embarrassment. Aug[ust] himself feels that he has been

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discredited, because, when I asked him how he intended to defend his behavior in public, he declared that he was prepared to take the consequences, even the most extreme ones; that is, presumably, to resign his position on the Executive Committee. I also wish he would do that, for his sake and ours, given the state of his health. But I wish it could happen in an honorable way, freely and not forced, with his reputation still glorious and not the butt of the world's contempt.

Yours,
Karl

16. Kautsky to SPD-Executive Committee

Berlin-Friedenau, March 3, 1909

Esteemed Comrades,

On March 2, a decision was taken by the Executive Committee in reference to my *Road to Power*,⁶ which, as of today, has not been clearly communicated to me. My request of the 5th, to be given a *written* decision has, as of today, not been answered. This is unheard of lack of consideration, which is typical of the Executive Committee's treatment of me so far.

Today I finally got the decision, via Stuttgart, from Comrade Zetkin. According to the decision, the Executive Committee declines to release the pamphlet published by its own press but permits me to publish it elsewhere, if I write a new preface and revise various passages in a way the Executive Committee considers appropriate.

Allow me to inform the Executive Committee that they have exceeded their authority with this decision. I concede the Executive Committee as a publisher, like any other publisher, the right to examine a pamphlet or other work submitted to them as a manuscript, to reject it if they do not find it worthwhile or appropriate, or to suggest revisions to the author.

However they have the right to withdraw, without the author's permission, a work already published, at most in a case where it contains the grossest offenses against Party principles or Party interests.

There is no such offense in this case. The confiscation of my work by the Executive Committee seemed to me, therefore, unwarranted. In accordance with § 24 of the bylaws, I turned to the Control Commission, which was created specifically for the purpose of enabling a comrade, in the case of a conflict between that comrade and the Executive Committee, to seek redress.

If the Control Commission had decided against me, then I would have abided by the decision. The Executive Committee does not recognize

the same obligation. They do not implement the order of the Control Commission. They are, therefore, of the opinion that, if a difference of opinion arises between a comrade and the Executive Committee, the former has no rights and must submit without protest to autocracy.

But the Executive Committee goes even further than an autocrat in its most recent decision: they want to dictate what I should write in my book which I am going to publish with another press.

That is a mistaken interpretation of the Executive Committee's authority, against which I must decisively protest not only in my own interest, but also in the interest of all Party writers regardless of tendency. According to § 23 of the bylaws, the Executive Committee has only an oversight role. My pamphlet is not a Party organ, and the Executive Committee itself has no objection to its basic concept. The Executive Committee may disavow and condemn my book after it has appeared, they may remove me as editor [of *Die Neue Zeit*]; that is their right, as long as they believe that the interest of the Party requires it. But they do not have the least right to make the smallest demands of a book that I publish in a press independent of the Executive Committee.

This decision of the Executive Committee is null and void. I don't acknowledge its validity. It stands in contradiction to the bylaws and the decision of the Control Commission. It is a product of naked arbitrariness.

With comradely greetings,
Karl Kautsky

17. Kautsky to Haase

Berlin-Friedenau, March 9, 1909

Dear friend Haase,

This business is getting to be as long as a sea serpent. I celebrated my triumph too soon and was proceeding from false assumptions. Dietz was acting in agreement with Bebel alone without the knowledge of the Executive Committee. When they found out about it, they simply forbade publication in Stuttgart under any circumstances, even if I wrote the preface and accepted the revisions! What held for Berlin also held for Stuttgart.

It is not Party interest that is being expressed here but a brutally domineering position, which treats me like a coolie who cannot obtain his rights at any price.

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I have written the Executive Committee a defiant letter, in which I describe their action as arbitrary.

At first I intended going to Leipzig right away. But there is so much to be said for Stuttgart that I still want to make another try.

The Executive Committee rejected the Control Commission's decision on the ground that they were not in a position to overcome the opposition of the employees of the press. This motivation doesn't hold for publication in Stuttgart. The Executive Committee, therefore, hasn't the slightest excuse any more for failing to implement the decision of the Control Commission. And if they still, even now, refuse, it will be as clear as day that they do not want to see their autocracy limited by the Control Commission. There can no longer be any other reason. Don't you think so, too? You would be doing me a great favor, if you informed Braun, as a member of the Control Commission, of this letter. I have had, and have, so many letters to write in connection with this miserable affair, I have lost so much time, that I could have spent more profitably, that I am grateful for every letter I am spared.

Dietz does not want his intervention and its fate spoken of. He told me this only last night after I had already gleefully let my friends know about the peace agreement. I can't, therefore, remain completely silent. But I am asking you, in any case, not to spread the news any further.

I have less and less respect for the Executive Committee, however. Bebel realizes that he was impulsive and went too far, but the rest see nothing except that, to protect their "reputation" it is necessary that the Executive Committee refuse to recognize the rights of a writer. They are puffed up narrow-minded parvenues.

When and how the thing will end, cannot be foreseen at all now. And I have no other desire except to work in peace! It is only with great selfcontrol that I don't throw it all over and retire from all Party activity to concentrate on theoretical work.

With best regards,
K. Kautsky

18. Kautsky to Adler

Berlin-Friedenau, March 9, 1909

Dear Victor,

The business is not over with, instead, it goes on. I was mistaken, Dietz was not acting in the name of the Executive Committee, as I believed, but on his own account in agreement with August, who is fed up with the thing. But he still sees further than the others.

When the Executive Committee learned of the agreement, they simply forbade Dietz, despite Bebel, to bring out the pamphlet, in whatever form, even if I agreed to all changes. There would be absolutely no danger in Stuttgart, as Dietz avers, but the Executive Committee simply won't have it: *sic volo, sic jubeo*. [What I wish to be so, I order to be so.]

That there will now be a fight, appears to me unavoidable, because it is now clear that it is neither the Party's interest let alone mine that guides the Executive Committee; in that case they would have to have greeted the Stuttgart solution with joy. No, it is simply the thrill of power. The scoundrels want to let the intellectual [*den Literaten*] feel their power, to show him that he is only their coolie and has to shut up when they command.

It is clear that one can't put up with this. I have just written the Executive Committee that I do not acknowledge the validity of their decisions and will not submit to them. We will see what they will undertake now. May they propose my expulsion!

So much in a hurry. With best wishes,

Your K. K.

19. Kautsky to the SPD-Executive Committee

March 9, 1909

Esteemed Comrades,

I thank you for your speedy response to my letter and am glad to acknowledge that there has been a misunderstanding here. It is true that I myself proposed to the Executive Committee that I write a new preface, in which I would state that the pamphlet expressed my personal views only. I was also prepared to change the passage on p. 62 [p. 83 in this translation] and perhaps also to strike the conclusion that made comrade Herzfeld so upset, even though the conclusion is completely harmless. But I offered these concessions only in the event that the pamphlet was brought out by the "Vorwärts" publishing house. These concessions were meant to overcome the political and legal qualms of the Executive Committee. I still offer these concessions even now in the event that the Executive Committee releases the pamphlet in its own publishing house. There was never a discussion of concessions in the event the Executive Committee did not do that. Since, however, the Executive Committee do not insist on these concessions if I go to another publisher, the matter is settled.

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Now, however, still another question. I had the opportunity to speak with Comrade Dietz on Saturday and Sunday about the matter, and he indicated that he was prepared, contingent on the agreement of the Executive Committee, to take the pamphlet to his publishing house, where not the slightest danger threatens it. I was very happy with this outcome and very much in agreement with it, because I assumed that it would free, not only me, but the Executive Committee as well from a situation that has been most disagreeable for all participants, as it would remove the problems that caused the Executive Committee to stop the Berlin publisher from issuing the work. These problems were of two kinds. One is legal. Comrade Dietz is convinced that in Stuttgart no danger threatens, and one can surely trust such an old hand. The second problem was the concern for the representatives of the Berlin publisher, who refused to take responsibility for the work. This problem was the reason why the Executive Committee felt unable, as they told the Control Commission, to implement its decision. That problem evaporates as soon as a publisher is found who is prepared to take this responsibility. Acceptance of Dietz's proposal would therefore eliminate the conflict with the Control Commission, which, if it were not settled, would necessarily lead to the affair's being dragged into the open, which would have very serious consequences. Acceptance of this proposal would also free the Executive Committee from the erroneous suspicion that they wanted to play the party censor for opportunist reasons. It would provide a means painlessly to put an end to an affair whose continuation can bring with it very unpleasant conflicts, even catastrophes, for all participants – I remind you only of the possibility of an action against me in which the Executive Committee would figure as prosecution witnesses. I assume, therefore, that the Executive Committee will accept the Dietz's proposal as a solution of a difficult situation, a solution as practical as it is honorable, a solution in which there are no winners and no losers. It would be of great value to me to know what the Executive Committee thinks of this.

With comradely greetings,
Karl Kautsky

20. Kautsky to the SPD Executive Committee

March 12, 1909

Esteemed Comrades,

I call the Executive Committee's attention to the lead article of the *Konservative Korrespondenz* of March 9 and to the item "Comrade KK" in yesterday's evening edition of the *Berliner Neueste Nachrichten*. In both my

Road is dealt with; in the *Berliner Neueste Nachrichten*, there was also a report on a meeting of the Berlin action committee [Aktionsausschuß] of January 29. Of course the party is being mocked for the game of hide-and-seek it played with the pamphlet. Even the Executive Committee will realize that it must now be published, if the Party does not want to continue to make itself ridiculous in public. The only question left is where the work should be published. It would be simplest and most practical to release it in Berlin. If the Executive Committee still rejects that, despite the new situation, then they are left with the right to decide only the place of publication. It is up to them whether the pamphlet appears in Stuttgart or Leipzig, on ground most favorable to us or most dangerous, as inconspicuously as possible or as conspicuously as possible.

If the Executive Committee bars the favorable, inconspicuous route to me, I cannot change that. The responsibility before the Control Commission and perhaps before the public will then not have to be borne by me. One will not be able to make the charge against me that I irresponsibly ran off to Leipzig. In any case, however, I have to request most urgently a prompt decision. If I do not have an answer from the Executive Committee in hand by tomorrow, the 13th, I will have to consider that a definitive rejection of publication in Stuttgart and will go to Leipzig.

With comradely greetings,
K. K.

21. Kautsky to Haase

Berlin-Friedenau, March 15, 1909

Dear friend Haase,

A new turn, not by God's dispensation but perhaps by yours!

The Executive Committee declares itself prepared to publish my *Road* in the Berlin publishing house, under conditions which I proposed to them myself before I went to the Control Commission: a new edition with a new preface and revision of some passages.

Naturally I had to accept this situation. But it is still not an end of our difficulties. For one thing, what shall the new preface say? For another what passages are to be revised? I have declared that I will take into consideration only legal considerations, not political ones; to agree only to revisions that you consider necessary. There are lawyers who like to offer incredible legal opinions. Herzfeld, for example, warns that the most dangerous passage in the pamphlet is the concluding sentence; that "Happy etc." was a direct call for revolution. Timidity makes one crazy.

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Then the question arises whether the new edition should appear now or in August. Concerning that there is so much to be said for and against that I don't want to come to any decision before I explore the matter thoroughly with you and have discussed all the angles. That can't be done in writing.

New relevant factors include the campaign against me in the bourgeois press. I enclose one example of many, a clipping from the *Leipziger Neueste Nachrichten*. The *Berliner Neueste Nachrichten*, the *Staatsanzeigerzeitung*, and the *Konservative Korrespondenz* are writing similarly.

Then, too, a matter for concern is the fact that Dutch, Italian, Polish, and Russian translations will appear within a few weeks; all translated from the first edition.

As I said to gain clarity on all these factors and how best to reconcile regard for my safety with regard for my political reputation and the interest of the party, the last being, naturally, the first in importance, and the first, last — all of this can only be done in a comprehensive, face-to-face, discussion.

Yours faithfully,
K. Kautsky

22. Haase to Kautsky

Konigsberg, March 16, 1909

My dear Kautsky,

Finally the Executive Committee in corpore [collectively] seems to understand how appropriately it would have acted, if it had immediately accepted your proposal. As my personal intervention can, perhaps, lead to a definitive resolution, I am prepared to come to Berlin. . . .

I look forward to a happy reunion,

Yours,
Hugo Haase

23. Zetkin to Kautsky

Wilhelmshohe, March 16, 1909

Dear Karl,

Words and actions seem to have lost all meaning for you, if you call this love affair a "victory." It is out-and-out capitulation. In actuality, the

Executive Committee has achieved everything it wanted to achieve for the sake of the revisionists. Namely: 1) the fundamental point of the pamphlet, that we are not growing into the state of the future but must conquer political power through a revolutionary struggle, is banished from the party as your personal opinion; indeed it is officially rejected as the opinion of the party; 2) the revision of various passages, which they demanded according to their legal and political timidity. In light of these revisions, the preface, with its declaration that the pamphlet is only the expression of your personal view, appears as cruel, humiliating self-mockery, which the Executive Committee exacts from you. *Tant de bruit pour une omelette* [What a commotion for an omelette]! Was it worth the fight, was it worth for me the time, the energy and, I may say without exaggeration, considering my condition, my heart's blood, to arrive at this miserable result, which can no longer be characterized as the result of political conflicts but as that old petty-bourgeois fantasy: "They sit so peacefully together and love one another so much!" Your correspondence with the Executive Committee, with the exception of the one letter of March 9, is nothing more than a constant flirting and courting to obtain the favor of being permitted to capitulate. And, dammit, is it your business in this situation to help the Executive Committee avoid a conflict with the Control Commission and its consequences! In the interest of restoring the health of our Party life, there was only one thing to do: to try and see that the Executive Committee got the public thrashing they deserved for their disgraceful behavior. It was the only way to protect them, in the interest of the party, from a worse drubbing [*Revidivirung – sic*]. Whether your pamphlet was published by "Vorwärts" or in Buxtehude was all the same. What mattered was its being published unrevised so that the entire Party could judge it and thereby the Executive Committee. From the beginning until now, you have considered the whole matter from the narrow point of view of the publication of your pamphlet by Vorwärts and your pious position vis-à-vis the Fathers, rather than from the broader one of the evolution of the Party as a whole. So you capitulate and worse still: by your capitulation you let down those who wanted to use the situation in the interest of the Party as a whole. Incidentally, you are wrong as far as the decision of the Control Commission is concerned. The Control Commission did not at all decide that Vorwärts Verlag was obliged to publish your revised and, by means of a preface, disinfected pamphlet; rather the decision concerned the pamphlet as you submitted it to us. But enough. Every word about this sad incident is a waste. Do what you have to do. I will do the same regardless of your decisions. I ask of you only one thing: spare me further communications on this topic. That is my last private word on it....

Best regards,
Clara

24. Haase to Kautsky

Konigsberg, March 18, 1909

Dear Comrade Kautsky,

It is not very uplifting to have to deal, on March 18,⁷ with the question, whether one may speak of the "expectation of the proletarian revolution" within German Social Democracy. But I don't feel the least inclination to retire to the quietist position. On the contrary, I am spoiling for a fight, even if I can't ignore the fact that, at present, what is needed is to make peace. How some of your friends can see a disgraceful capitulation on your part in your willingness to help the Executive Committee out of the fix it's in, to protect the Party from unspeakable ridicule before the whole world, and to evade an alerted state prosecutor is not comprehensible to me.

Substantively, you do not give up anything; the Executive Committee offers you what you demanded to begin with. You do not submit to a "decree" of the Executive Committee; rather, you help the Executive Committee out of a difficult situation. That's how I see things. More face-to-face....

With best regards, I am
Yours, Hugo Haase

Notes

1. According to the Party bylaws, Kautsky was entitled to turn to the Control Commission "as a court of appeal in cases of complaints against the actions of the Party Executive Committee."
2. Kautsky refers here to the debate at Stuttgart on militarism. Bebel denied that a mass strike in the event of war was obligatory. *Internationaler Sozialisten-Kongress zu Stuttgart, 18 to 24 August, 1907*. Berlin, 1907, pp. 100-101.
3. Kautsky is thinking of the publishing house of the *Leipziger Volkszeitung*.
4. "Frische Brise," *Leipziger Volkszeitung* 43 (22 February 1909). The *Leipziger Volkszeitung* characterized Kautsky's pamphlet as a literary expression of the "fresh breeze" (*frische Brise*) which was noticeable in German and international political life.
5. J. H. W. Dietz, manager of the SPD publishing house in Stuttgart; August Kaden, chair of the Control Commission.
6. The Executive Committee's decision read as follows: "On the assumption that Kautsky will write a new preface, will describe the pamphlet as his personal expression, will remove, respectively change, a number of passages, and will let it be published as a second edition, the Party Executive Committee will raise no objection; they refuse, however, to permit it to be published by the Vorwärts press and leave it to Kautsky to have the work published by a German publisher."
7. 18 March was the anniversary of the barricade fighting in Berlin in 1848.

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Karl Kautsky (1854-1938) was the leading theorist, interpreter, and popularizer, as well as the most authoritative champion, of orthodox Marxism in the German Social Democratic Party (SPD) and the Second International in the period of the Wilhelmine Empire. As such, he fought both Eduard Bernstein's revisionism and Rosa Luxemburg's radicalism, while as the principal representative of democratic Marxism, he bitterly opposed Lenin's communism in the last two decades of his life.

The Road to Power was a highly controversial political pamphlet published in 1909, an important document for the understanding of the Wilhelmine Empire and especially of the German SPD and Kautsky's role in it-and it was Kautsky's last major attack on the revisionists' hope for a gradual "growth into socialism" without any drastic changes in the political order. To this Kautsky opposed his view of the political revolution that he hoped for and predicted as the achievement of parliamentary democracy and of workingclass power through a parliamentary majority. He believed that the initial democratization of the autocratic empire could be realized peacefully by electoral victories and trade-union political action.

Lenin, misled by the revolutionary Marxist vocabulary he shared with Kautsky, praised *The Road to Power*, which has led to much subsequent misunderstanding of it. Conversely, Kautsky's radicalism aroused the opposition of the German trade-union leadership and of the SPD's Executive Committee, which for a while sought to prohibit further publication of the book.

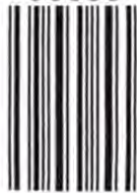
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John H. Kautsky is Professor Emeritus of Political Science at Washington University, St. Louis, Missouri. He is the author of several books and numerous articles on the politics modernization and on communism and Marxism. Raymond Meyer received his doctorate in German Studies from Stanford University. He is the translator of the abridged edition of:
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